



LISA PLAYS HER PART

an interracial
hotwife romance

ARNICA BUTLER

Thirteenth Line Publications



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An Interracial Hotwife Romance

By Arnica Butler

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More From Arnica

CHAPTER 1

Luke

I don't know where to start with this story.

Where *do* you start? All the way back, when I saw Lisa for the first time, telling a story on the porch? She was small then and she's small now; blonde hair that she's always kept in some unusual style above her shoulders, curvy frame, doll-like features. An odd sense of style, something that set her apart from everyone else. And then, from this tiny, doll-like figurine, the most enormous hand-waving, the biggest personality. I watched her for a while and thought of Altoids mints. Then hooked up with some other girl of the plain brown hair, sultry-lipped variety.

Do I start when Lisa told me she thought I was an asshole the first time she saw me? Something that was pretty funny, given that the moment she saw me I was drunker than I had ever been and would ever be in my life, dancing around like an idiot at a basketball game with some guys who were barely my friends.

With the fumbling, dark and sweaty first time we made love? At a party in my old neighborhood, locked away in one of those cheap apartment bedrooms, a thin door almost amplifying the loud party outside. The two of us in our own little world. It would be a lie to have called it romantic, or earth-shattering, but it was the beginning of something. I knew that when she grinned at me over her heaping pile of pancakes at iHop the next day.

Do I start when Lisa, arms folded, a cold October wind whipping her hair against her face, her nose and cheeks bright red from the cold, her eyes from crying, told me she was pregnant? Or in the middle, where things seemed like they would fall apart? Later, when we came back together and had a nice, comfortable life that we both seemed to find acceptable?

Or do I start where things ended up, with me standing on a stage with my heart beating wildly, hoping that I still had the love of a woman in a period costume and a wig?

Or do I start here?

When Wallace Brown entered the stage of our lives.

*

We didn't talk much anymore in the car, and that day was not any different. Lisa flipped down the sun visor to check her make-up, commented on a new restaurant, checked some messages on her phone. I drove. It was the typical kind of car ride that a couple who have been married for 18 years have.

Quiet. Neutral. Somewhat impersonal.

Lisa was looking forward to the barbecue as much as I was dreading it. This is the kind of thing that I think about in retrospect, and the kind of thing I didn't bother thinking about at the time. She started to flutter whenever we had somewhere to go those days. Now that Drake and Mike were out of the house and she didn't have them to worry about all the time, she was back to needing social interaction.

This barbecue was going to be a piece of shit, I was sure of it. More corporate nonsense, more waffling and cheerful networking, more of the same garbage that at this point in my life I was really beginning to detest. And now, to top it off, the consultation company that was hosting the stupid thing was probably also going to hack away at our jobs.

Here, have a boiled hot dog before we kick you through the door!

Lisa was wearing a pretty sundress, that much I remember taking note of. That was me, always taking note of some things and not others. The dress was white with red flowers, or maybe red with white flowers, and I had noted it for the unusually low cut between her breasts. She liked it because it was "retro."

I liked it because she looked hot. She had just cut her hair recently. Lisa had always had a fun, sexy, shoulder-length or above haircut going – *not* middle-aged woman hair. The kind of haircut that gave off a vague allusion to blonde bombshells like Marilyn Monroe, Carol Baker, or Jean Harlow. Her hairdresser had put a ton of highlights in it, which she had disliked, but it took her naturally sunny, reddish hair to almost platinum levels. In that sundress her hairstyle looked very sexy, very 50's pin-up girly.

"Do you think this lipstick is too red?" she said, finally. The drive was long, out to the ex-exurbs where the ultra-rich people lived, and she hadn't spoken for almost twenty minutes along the highway.

I glanced over. "It matches your dress," I remember saying.

Lisa, who by now had grown used to me talking that way (middle-aged man, always saying the half-wrong thing, efficiency over poetry) turned back to the flip-down mirror without giving me a reaction. She pressed her lips together. “Red is just so dangerous. One wrong turn and you’re in slutsville.” She dotted her lips and began one of her playful rants, which I admit, I barely listened to.

She got her “kooky voice” on. This is a deeper voice, and she adds a little frogginess to it, and then starts saying goofy shit. “A little too much orange, you look like you read the latest Cosmo with Halle Berry on the cover and thought, ‘heck, I’m *almost* as tan as Halle Berry’....too much purple, you look like you’ve got a red light above your bed.” She sighed. “Oh well. Whatever. I think it looks good. You don’t mind if I look like a slut, right?”

I wasn’t really listening. In fact, the above quote is probably all made up. I was caught again in one of those moments where she had asked me a question, and I had been thinking about what the fuck I would do if I lost my job. I was considering selling a kidney on the black market. No shit. I’d already looked into it.

It wouldn’t make a dent in my money problems though.

But I did hear the word ‘slut.’ This caught my attention and re-routed my brain to the present moment.

“Huh?” I said. “A slut?”

Lisa, unflappable as ever, rolled her eyes and smiled. Like I said, we’d been married for 18 years, and somewhere in that time Lisa had just learned to live with me not paying that much attention to what she was saying. She was overall pretty cheerful about it.

“Okay, then,” she said. “Slutsville it is.”

“It looks great,” I said, shaking snippets of her rant out of my subconscious. “You look great.”

“Nice save,” Lisa said, smiling.

“Thanks.”

“So... who is throwing this barbecue, actually?” Lisa said. “The guys who want to ax you, or Steven Whositface?”

I ground my teeth.

Ever since I had come home with the news that a consulting firm had busted in out of nowhere and set up shop (serious shop; they had offices to themselves in our building), Lisa had started cracking jokes and making

light of what I did not find to be a funny situation. I knew she was trying to help by being sunny and lighthearted, but Jesus. Drake was spending about \$60 a second at school, Mike was busy being an uninsured ski bum, and I had a deep sense of panic about “getting axed” as she so cheerfully put it.

I was 38. I didn’t want to climb halfway up some other corporate ladder, and I wasn’t high enough up this ladder to get some kind of parachute on my way down. I didn’t have any interests, or any passions, or anywhere I really wanted to go. I wanted to pay my bills and get my kid through college with the least amount of hassle possible at this point.

Ambition? Dreams? All that crap went out the window 18 years ago when a very pale, very dour Lisa told me she was pregnant.

“Steve Kenner,” I said dryly, answering her question and trying not to sound too annoyed. “It’s at his house. But I guess Bain and Frost is paying for the catering. Or... something.” I was exasperated by the end of my sentence, and I wiped my brow like I was sweating.

Lisa seemed not to notice. She seemed not to notice, most of the time, how much she was stressing me out.

“Maybe you can finally go back to school,” she would say cheerfully, whenever we were having a serious conversation about the possibility of me “getting the ax.”

Yeah, because *that* was going to work out. I’d go back to school! Drake was in school! *She* was in school! We could all pay to be alive!

Even though Lisa’s was a Master’s program that was largely paid for by the school in exchange for a TA-ship, I wondered sometimes if she had totally lost her mind and, along with it, the concept of paying for food. Or the mortgage. Or all the other shit – so much other shit – that we had to pay for.

My stomach started to hurt every time I thought about this crap.

Lisa made a noise, sucking in her breath and balling up her fists. “Oh,” she said breathlessly. “I can’t help it, I’m excited. I’m excited about this butter chicken fries thing.”

I was already miles deep in the ocean of my problems. “Huh?” I said.

“Oh, God, you didn’t even read the invite? There are *food trucks* coming. They have a gourmet pizza one, an Indian food one, and then just, like, hot dogs and hamburgers. Something else.” She sucked in her breath and clasped her knees. “I am going to eat *everything*.”

I looked over at her. “I thought you were on a diet.”

Of course, I realize how that sounded, now that I'm telling the story.

Lisa leaned on her elbow and regarded me coolly. Her eyes came to rest – poignantly – on the slight paunch in my middle. She cleared her throat.

“I didn't mean it like that,” I said, exasperated. My irritation about money, and my worries about getting canned, as always, had crept into my whole brain. “I meant... well, you won't eat anything anymore, so I thought...”

I stopped talking. It was probably for the best, because I could see I was making a mess of explaining myself.

Luckily, I had a sweet wife. A forgiving wife. She clicked her tongue.

Then she adjusted her makeup one more time. Dipping her hand into the front of her sundress to adjust her breasts, she said: “I'm breaking the law tonight. I'm *lawless*.”

I kept driving, my mind going back to all my problems.

Lisa put on kooky voice.

“Lawless!” she said, trying to get my attention.

“Just taking it all off!” she continued, when I didn't answer.

I nodded absent-mindedly.

“Rubbing that butter chicken *all* over my boobies.”

I turned sharply to look at her, making her laugh. She mimed rubbing butter chicken all over her breasts.

“Just kidding,” she said suddenly. “I have to eat those suckers as fast as I can and then not eat for two weeks so I can get into that dress.”

I barely knew what she was talking about, I admit. It took a moment to remember that she was Desdemona in a university production of *Othello*.

None of this should be construed to mean that Lisa didn't have a killer figure, or needed to diet. She just liked to take care of herself, and she really wanted to fit into this costume as a matter of personal pride. She was small, 5'4,” and had a tiny waist and pretty, rounded thighs. Her bottom was pert and hadn't started to take on that flat-butt appearance that so many women nearing 40 got. Her breasts were supple and small, shaped like plump pears, tipped by brilliant pink nipples. She was *hot*, and frankly a little out of my league, which was something I'd kept in mind throughout our entire marriage. All the tough times aside, I was a lucky guy.

We were there. Lisa let out a low whistle, as she always did, whenever we came to Steve's house. The property was more like an estate.

I've never really been a social guy. I'm less so now, and becoming less so with every passing year. So I'm probably in the wrong business – marketing research – which relies on people, networking, and social media like fleas rely on dogs.

It's company policy that you can be reimbursed for a taxi at any company function, and I was already contemplating this as I stared at the scene in front of me once I entered the back yard. Sure enough, a garish display of wealth: food trucks on a driveway that extended to the back “yard” of the house, in front of a guest house arguably about the same size as our home.

Though, to be fair to myself, we did live in Claredale, which was a way more expensive neighborhood, price-per-square-foot-wise.

I always started licking my wealth-management and corporate-ladder wounds when I went to these things, and there was no way out of them. The reason I wasn't as rich as Steve, or as high up the management ladder, was because I'd had kids so young, and been a loving husband and supportive father, involved in my kids' lives. By the time I could work hard enough to ascend the golden ladder to Steve-level heights, I was thirty and it was kind of too late. Middle management it was. And sure, Steve probably didn't know his own kids' middle names, and frankly they looked like the walking dead and probably burned through about \$1,000 a month in therapy, but... he had this fucking house. I couldn't help the envy.

I watched Lisa disappear with Kate into the crowd, and for a moment my wealth-jealousy was abated by the sight of my pretty wife. If she wanted to, Lisa could have been a trophy wife; she was blonde, well-built, petite and pretty. Where Kate had had to resort to expensive spa treatments and Botox to maintain her youthful appearance, Lisa held it together with her affable personality and a magical combination of features that made her look younger than her 37 years.

It wouldn't be long before Lisa would be commanding an audience with her kooky-voiced stories, because Lisa was, after all, a natural actress and a social butterfly. She was the kind of person who everyone liked, who could blend in the company of these slightly-snobby nouveau-riche types, and real classy-types, and her schoolteacher colleagues at a potluck.

Me, not so much. I'm not into it at all.

I headed to the bar.

*

I lost track of Lisa for about an hour, and spent the time listening to one of the Bain and Frost guys give me the company line and try to sell me on how they were all about “professionalism, ethics, and integrity” or “character, ethics and efficiency,” or some other three-word slogan I would never remember. The guy was like 24 and just out of business school. It was an annoying-as-hell conversation.

Lisa caught my eye, her red and white dress glowing against her skin, her voice breaking over the hum-drum babble of the crowd gathered near the food trucks and the pool. No one was actually in the pool, of course, because this was the kind of house and the kind of party where the pool was just for being seen by and conveying the wealth of its owner in a cool, blue stare from the middle of the party.

I edged my way over to the group she was in, where she was keeping almost everyone mesmerized with a rendition of one of her favorite stories about a time she got lost in Rosehill Heights. It was a story that, in my opinion, poked fun at rich people, but I guess Lisa was telling it with her usual beloved flair, and so no one noticed.

I got caught up in a quick exchange with Steve and a Gerry Mason, some guy from logistics at Quantum whose job I barely understood. I had to talk to this guy all the time, so I paused, my eye on Lisa’s group, to chat with him.

And then there he was. He broke away from his own group, and started circling in toward Lisa’s, just as I joined the cluster around her.

I’d seen this guy before, and so as he approached, I didn’t really get where he was going. He was from Bain and Frost, and I gathered from where they put his office and the way he acted around everyone else, he was pretty high up.

He was a dark black guy, one of those men you could cast as a hood rat or a corporate executive with equal ease. He didn’t walk, he swaggered, and he didn’t smile except for a sort of underlying grin that he had on all the time. It was the grin of a man who had it all fucking nailed. Tonight he was wearing a pricey-looking shirt and some ripped jeans, the kind of \$1,000 grunge outfit that rich people wear. Of course, he looked good in it.

He came up to the group with his eyes on Lisa's waving hands, and an intensity burning through the back of her head. That half-smile, becoming more profound.

Of course, I interpreted it as more predatory, especially because he moved quietly and with such focus, right toward her. I looked over at Tom, who was caught up in Lisa's story and smiling broadly as she told it. He seemingly hadn't noticed this black panther coming up on Lisa, looking more and more ready to pounce.

Then he edged his way in to the loose semi-circle, two people from Lisa. It wasn't hard: he looked at some young girl from reception and she practically disintegrated into a pool of cum.

He stood there, shook his drink a little to dislodge the ice, and turned toward Lisa.

Lisa was right in the middle of a sentence, getting to the best part of the story, everyone hanging on her every word. Her hands were waving and she looked around, and when she got to this guy, she just stopped.

Stopped telling the story.

Her hands hung in the air, her whole body froze, and I saw something I hardly ever see:

Lisa stopped talking.

Everyone stared at her, wondering what the hell was going on.

Black-Guy grinned.

And then, his silky-smooth voice rumbled:

"Thought that was you."

Lisa dropped her hands, slowly.

I looked at her face, trying to figure out what was going on. She was surprised, sure, but recognition – along with several other emotions – was creeping into her expression.

The look of shock faded. She smiled.

"Oh my God. Wallace."

Just that.

Oh my God. Period, slight pause, exhale: Wallace.

No high-pitched sing-song greeting.

Wallace.

The way she said his name inflamed me.

"So what happened?" asked Tom Pinker, who was still listening intently for the story.

Lisa turned her head to him, and I could see that she could barely process who he was, let alone what he'd asked her. She had been taken to another time and place, another planet, and she blinked slowly to indicate that she was gone.

Long gone.

"I..."

"She's just seen a ghost," Wallace said, still looking at her.

"This is... yeah, Tom, sorry, this is..." Lisa was waving her hands in Wallace's direction.

"I'm an old friend," Wallace said, his voice smoother than ever.

The group, sensing that Lisa was never going to keep talking, began to break off into their own conversations in pieces.

"I can't... I can't believe..." Lisa gushed. "What...?"

They looked at each other for a moment.

Then Wallace stepped toward her, and he seemed suddenly larger. He must have been about 6'4", so he towered over Lisa. She had to tilt her head to look at him. He opened his arms, and Lisa shook her head in disbelief before falling into an embrace with him.

Now, I need to preface this with some facts: I'm not prone to exaggeration. I'm also not prone to random jealousy. In fact, I sort of liked *imagining* that Lisa did things that merited my getting jealous. But she just never did anything like that. Lisa never embraced men in anything more than a sterile handshake or a perfunctory hug. Even if she was acting and it required her to pretend to be in love, the chemistry on stage was always sort of lacking. Never hot enough to make me burn with jealousy. And Lisa wasn't the type to go out with friends, one of whom you knew was a guy, or go out for a beer with a colleague who happened to be a man.

But the way these two embraced made the back of my neck burn, and then an indescribably queasy feeling sank through my abdomen and settled – curiously and not – in my groin. Wallace's big, wiry hands rubbed Lisa's back in a long, deliberate circle as he held her tightly to him. Lisa turned her cheek to his chest and closed her eyes as they hugged.

When they broke apart, Lisa was still forgetting herself – blatantly. She looked up at Wallace, right in the eyes, and the moment became incredibly awkward from the sidelines.

Me.

Suddenly, she gave a shake of her head and wiped the side of her lip. Her eyes fell to Wallace's shirt, where she saw the slight stain of lipstick, and she looked at him in alarm.

All of this before she looked quickly over at me, and her eyes were dark with just the tiniest bit of guilt. She touched her lip again, and opened her mouth.

"Oh, honey. This is... Wallace, I think I got... I'm so sorry, maybe a little bit of my...."

I stared as she reached out and wiped his expensive shirt with a pointer finger.

Then back to me, as if she had suddenly remembered (again) that she was married. "This is, uh, my husband. Wallace, this is him...er, Luke. He's... Luke this is Wallace, Wallace, Luke."

Wallace let his eyes take in my flustered wife for just a moment longer. Inappropriately longer. Slowly, deliberately, he turned to me.

His face went Corporate-Smiles.

"Oh. Luke Healy, Research." He gave me a nod. "So you're married to the lovely Lisa Callaghan."

I hadn't heard Lisa's maiden name in conjunction with her first name for at least 18 years.

I waited for Lisa to flutter and advise him that it was Healy, Lisa Healy now, but she just stared at him instead.

And the huge black man was looking at me, waiting for a response.

"I am," I said, as confidently as I could muster.

Lisa was off in la-la land. We all stood there for an uncomfortable moment. Wallace didn't seem too keen on deflating the tension, and Lisa was being – and there's no other way to say this – a complete idiot.

My chest felt tight. I looked at Lisa and raised my eyebrows. "So..." I said. "You two know each other..."

Lisa put a hand to her face. "Oh yes, yeah, yes of course. I... I know I've told you about Wallace. He was in... that production of *Romeo and Juliet*. That I... the one that was for the Braylee Scholarship."

Under normal circumstances, Lisa would have looked at me at that point, so that I didn't stick my foot in my mouth by saying, "you never told me about that."

But I was getting ahead of the game a little, as she stuttered out her terrible explanation.

I knew, of course, about the Braylee Scholarship: a program that put excelling and highly-motivated students into a theater production for the summer. It was an elite, highly prestigious program, and Lisa had not only won the scholarship but the lead role as Juliet. This had been right before we'd met.

I knew all that.

But I had never heard of Wallace.

And I had a sinking feeling that Wallace was Juliet's Romeo, though I couldn't say why.

And if that was the case, then I was going to look like even more of a sucker if my wife *hadn't* mentioned the tall, gorgeous Wallace to her husband. There was clearly something simmering between the two of them – hell, you could actually feel it in the air – and if women didn't mention a man they had something “simmering” with, there was a reason for that.

My neck felt like it was on fire. My stomach had turned to a mush of uncomfortable, cold snakes.

“Of course,” I said, amicably. “Wallace. I remember now.”

I was very impressed with the even-keel of my voice. I extended my hand. “Had no idea that was you,” I said. “I just didn't make the connection.”

Wallace shook my hand, and he was grinning at me in this kind of bared-teeth, alpha-male kind of way. He wasn't buying this shit, even if he wasn't 100% certain what shit it was.

Lisa, for her part, was unable to hide the flush on her cheeks. Her eyes were moving so quickly between me and Wallace that I could see them in my peripheral vision. Like a pinball machine. I knew she was trying to figure out why I was pretending that she had mentioned Wallace: was it a mistake? Had she forgotten about it, or had I?

“It's all right man,” Wallace said. His perfectly whitewashed speech grazed into black dialect. *Aight*. “Most people don't think of Romeo as black.”

This one threw me for a loop, and I just kept shaking his hand like a bit of an idiot.

“Jesus either,” Wallace said. Still grinning that slightly confrontational grin.

We dropped our handshake at pretty much the same time.

Wallace let his gaze linger on me just a little longer than polite, and then turned to Lisa, who was still staring at the whole scene with an utterly uncomfortable look on her face. “So, Lisa Healy now. What is it you’ve been up to all this time?”

Lisa folded her arms over her stomach and waved her glass around. “Oh... phbbt... jeez, where to start?” She pointed at him with her wineglass. “What about you? What have *you* been up to? Married? Kids? You’re... some big-wig now, I see.”

Lisa was literally blathering.

“No wife. No kids,” Wallace said calmly.

Staring.

My gut twisted. Lisa swallowed and looked at him while she tried to find something to say.

I wondered if this counted as hitting on my wife. And as for my wife... well, Wallace was having the exact same effect on her that he’d had on the receptionist. Lisa was turning into a puddle.

Right in front of me.

The moment dragged on uncomfortably long. “So what do you -” Lisa started, after clearing her throat.

“I’m going to get another drink,” I said loudly, at the same time. “Lisa?”

Lisa looked at her wine and shook her head. She looked half-helpless as she turned to me. “Thanks, though.”

“Wallace?” I said.

Wallace held up a drink glass in his hand. The liquid was clear; I suspected water. “I’m good, man.”

Of course he fucking was. Wallace didn’t need to steady his nerves while he swooped in with his ebony, smooth act and stole your wife.

I tipped my own drink at them and hurried away. I didn’t want to be part of that conversation anymore.

But as I walked away, the presence of Wallace Brown burned behind me, and the hairs on the back of my neck stood on end.

I found the bar, and an incredibly boring conversation about life insurance to join, and tried to get it off my mind.

I wasn’t going to look over there, I wasn’t going to be a jealous husband. I deliberately turned my back in their direction, but inside I

stewed and fumed, thinking about everything that Lisa had told me about the Scholarship program, the production of *Romeo and Juliet*.

It was so long ago. I had only the tiniest recollection that it had even happened. I remembered being attracted to Lisa because she was a vibrant, theatrical person. That I had been unsurprised that she was a lead actress, that she loved Shakespeare... but honestly, I couldn't remember anything else she had told me about it.

I hadn't listened, that was the problem. I hadn't listened *well*.

The allure of seeing them together proved too much for me. I found myself slowly rotating in the group so that I had a peripheral view of the last place I saw them standing. I could make out Lisa's dress, the curves of her body. Wallace's dark skin. They seemed to be standing close to each other. Lisa waved her hand, animated. I heard Wallace laugh – a low, deep rumble.

Involuntarily, I jerked my head in their direction, just in time to see Lisa brushing a stray lock of hair from her face and toeing the ground, smiling.

The picture stabbed me in the stomach. They looked good together, their contrasting complexions working together like a well-designed logo. Wallace was more like Lisa's "league;" fit and handsome. A smooth operator.

A thriving career.

Not only that, they had a real – and very obvious – chemistry together. If they really hadn't seen each other for 18 years they were certainly falling into a rhythm with extraordinary speed.

Had she slept with this guy? It seemed like she had. And not only did it seem like she had, the vibe I was reading off of her right now made it seem like she wouldn't mind doing it again.

Just as I had that thought, which was making me vaguely – and strangely – aroused, Lisa put her arm on Wallace's thick bicep and laughed. They were just inches apart now.

Tom Brady, who was standing in my little cluster now, raised an eyebrow as he followed my gaze. He lifted a drink to his lips. "So your wife knows Wallace Brown, eh?" he said.

Then he shook his head a little.

It was a gesture of pity.

I wanted to punch him in the face.

“They were in some kind of play together a long time ago,” I said.

Tom made a face. It was the kind of face that said a lot. It said, “sorry your wife is probably going to bonk that hot black guy,” and “you know what they say... once you go black you never go back,” and “you’re a fucking schmuck.” All that, in one expression.

Tom changed the subject. He leaned in and asked me in a low whisper: “You had your interview with the B and F guys yet? It’s brutal. Jenkins is already looking for another job.”

I suppressed the desire to punch him again and responded by taking a long drink. *It just gets better*, I thought.

And then, unwisely, I ordered another drink.

*

Lisa spent about two hours talking to Wallace. I kid you not. I mingled with the crowd, even forgetting myself for a few minutes during a particularly rowdy political discussion. But every time I looked around, there they were, under a tree, talking.

That’s all they were doing, talking. So it wasn’t as if I had any legitimate reason to go over there and break it up. They were there in front of all these people, and it wasn’t like they were doing anything obviously improper.

And I was not going to be the guy that stomped across the lawn and grabbed my wife by the arm to whisk her away because she was chatting – for two long hours – with a black guy who was better looking, better-employed, and better-dressed than me.

It wasn’t as if no one noticed, either, which added a particular kind of burn to the whole scene. There was Tom, and his funny expressions. More than one person looked in their direction, pointing with an elbow or a bicep in a pitying, non-committal way, and asked: “Hey, how’s your wife know Wallace Brown?” or “Whoa, what are those two chin-wagging about?”

“They’re old friends,” I would reply sullenly. “From a college thing.”

The faces I got in return were priceless.

Oh yeah, a “college” thing. Gotcha. Your wife was bonking a hot black guy and now they’ve spent two hours “chatting” under a tree while you stand here looking like a dumbfuck with your gourmet pizza.

And, this guy was probably going to get me fired, to boot. Just splendid.

I stopped drinking – probably later than legally required – in order to be able to drive. Then I stewed around, half-participating in conversation but all the while darting my eyes over at Lisa and Wallace, for about an hour.

While I stood there pretending to participate, my mind was going to some really dark places. I started picturing the two of them together, writhing on the bed. Their contrasting-colored limbs woven in and around each other, covered in a sheen of sweat, slippery and shiny. I pictured their tongues flicking in and out of each other's mouths, darting around, kissing in the most filthy ways.

I wasn't even *trying* to distract myself from these thoughts. In some kind of perverse way, I was enjoying going there. Piling on detail, imagining I could smell the heat of their bodies and the tangy-sweetness of Lisa's arousal. Imagining the sound of her moans and her wet pussy sloshing as the fat crown of Wallace's cock pushed inside her.

I sat down for a while, because I had an erection. I tried to distract myself from the thoughts but they were intrusive as hell. I also made a good effort at analyzing why I was having them, and more importantly, why they were making my dick hard, but I just kept sinking into an arousing fantasy

And then, at about 9:30, I decided it was time to leave. I walked as coolly as I could over to where Wallace and my wife were laughing and chatting like the old lovers that they obviously were.

"Lisa," I said, keeping my voice as steady and as neutral as I could. I didn't want to sound annoyed; I wanted to sound like I was the kind of man who was confident enough in himself and his marriage to let his wife sit there chatting with a hot black man she used to fuck, all night if she wanted to, and be totally unconcerned. "I think we better go, babe. I just spent an hour talking about a Lexus."

Lisa seemed completely disoriented. Her face fell a little, and she turned to Wallace. "Well," she said, uncertainly. "I... I guess I have to go. It was... um... I can't believe you're here. It's been so long."

She stood up. Wallace stood up with her, all of his manly, muscled blackness unfolding into his enormous, ebony-statue form. Then he opened his arms, and Lisa just about jumped into them. They embraced, and I stared openly at Wallace's big, black hands massaging the bare skin of her

back, *again*. I felt my cock twitch a little, even as my temples pulsed with annoyance.

“It was good to see you, girl,” Wallace rumbled. They were still hugging. I spun my keys to give them a jingle.

Still hugging.

Finally, Lisa was released from his grip, and she stepped unsteadily backwards. “Uh... well... I hope I see you again... around. Or something.”

Wallace gave her a long, sizzling look. “Oh, I’m sure we’ll cross paths.”

Lisa, twitterpated, babbled something like, “Oh! Okay, well... okay... so... see you, then.”

Wallace winked at her.

“Night, Wallace,” I said, pulling Lisa by the hand with slightly more force than I meant to.

“See you ‘round the office, Luke.”

Lisa had imbibed quite a bit, it seemed. She had to stop by the house to go to the bathroom, and she was gone quite a while. Outside, I fumed, planning my barrage of questions for her.

She almost twisted her ankle twice on the walk to the car, and opted for removing her shoes.

I was sour and angry, and there was no hiding it. But Lisa seemed not to notice. “Did you have the butter chicken fries?” she asked. “They were amazing. And the... mimosas?...samosas....whatever, you know the Indian thingies, they were -”

A soft honk interrupted her as a sleek, silver roadster rolled by. Of course. And of course Wallace Brown’s dark body was at the wheel. He lifted his hand to Lisa, and she smiled like an adolescent.

“Is that a Tesla?” she asked, as Wallace slow-rolled down the driveway, past our Honda.

I pretended not to hear her and crunched angrily down the road. I threw the door open and dumped myself into the seat, turning the ignition before I was even in the car.

Lisa took her time and plopped into the seat. ‘Whoa!’ she said, as I pulled out into the driveway. “I don’t even have my seat belt on.”

I braked and she had to put her hand out on the dashboard. “Hey,” she said. “Are you drunk?”

“No,” I said glumly.

She made a face and put her seat belt on.

Silence coated the drive home for about twenty minutes.

"Well," she sighed. "You're mad about something. You want to tell me what it is?"

Was she fucking serious? I shook my head slowly and pressed my lips together.

"It's Wallace," she said conclusively.

And then there was a really, really long pause. She looked out the window and pressed the backs of her fingers to her lips. "Look," she said quietly. "I'm sorry I spent the whole evening talking to him, it's just... I haven't seen him forever."

The rage and jealousy I'd been trying to tell myself I wasn't suffering from boiled over. "When were you going to tell me about this guy, huh?"

She looked at me. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, you never once mentioned Wallace Brown. Now that's a little peculiar, don't you think? Considering the way you were so cozy with him."

Lisa's mouth fell open. "I was not... *cozy* with him."

I nodded and blew through my nose, exasperated. "Yeah. Right. Not at *all*."

Lisa leaned her seat back. "You're drunk," she said.

"I'm not drunk. I think I know what I'm seeing when my wife is blathering like an idiot and squeezing a black man's biceps all night."

"Whoa!" Lisa half-shouted. "*There* it is."

"There's what?" I snapped, annoyed. I knew perfectly well what she was talking about.

"Are you seriously just pissed about this because he's black?"

"What the hell, Lisa. Why would you say that?"

"Why would you mention that he's black, if that wasn't the problem?"

I pulled off the highway, onto a shoulder on the exit.

This shut Lisa up, because it meant I was really angry.

"Why don't you tell me," I said, my voice shaking with anger. "Why you never mentioned that you'd fucked some black guy?"

Oh, the question was *way* out of line, and it sucked the air out of the car in a nanosecond.

I knew it was beyond the pale, right before I said it. But I said it anyway.

Maybe I *was* too drunk to be driving the car. Maybe I was a fucking racist. Maybe I was a jealous, insecure dick.

Anyway, it was out there.

But the thing was, we'd been married for eighteen years. How many dumb arguments had we had? We'd both said some pretty awful things to each other, and then made up after talking about it for hours and hours.

No one felt like wasting that kind of time anymore. Especially if we'd had some drinks.

Now, whoever said something that far out of line lost the argument, boom.

It was just the way it was.

Lisa swept her hand over her dress, and this victory lit her serious expression up a little. "Well," she said. "I think that's enough for now."

We drove home the rest of the way in silence, except for about five minutes from our house, when Lisa said, out of nowhere, her voice low and angry:

"For the record, I never slept with Wallace Brown."

I kept my lips pressed together, because there was one thing I'd sorted out in the half hour remainder of the drive: I was drunker than I thought, and I needed to just shut up.

CHAPTER 2

Lisa

Wallace Brown.

This was a guy I'd locked up... where? It must have been in my chest somewhere, because that's the part of me that felt like it exploded when I turned around and saw him there. All six feet, four inches of him, towering over me, chocolate colored and as muscled as the last time I saw him.

And then it was just like it was back then: my palms were actually itching to touch him.

I had a few things go through my mind just before he gave me a hug, and his muscled chest was against my cheek, only the silky shirt he was wearing between me and his skin.

You're married, Lisa, was one of them.

And Luke was right there, standing right by me... somewhere. But that thought, too, was gone in a flurry.

I could feel my heart beating faster. *Pull yourself the fuck together,* was another one.

You have kids.

And then a word from the demon inside of me: *They're out of the house.*

And then Wallace was pulling me in, and I could feel his hot hand on my back.

An actual shiver went through me, right up my spine and out to the ends of my fingers, then straight down to the center of my legs.

Not married, I heard him saying, and all the while my head was a windstorm. All these thoughts were confetti and I couldn't grab one of them long enough to think it through. I could feel my chest getting tighter, my breath faster, and from the tips of Wallace's fingers right through my body, I could feel heat all the way to my... er...

I'd rather not have had to talk about this. That's what I wanted to say to Luke, had that car conversation gone anywhere.

I'd put Wallace out of my mind for as many years as me and Luke had been together.

Well, maybe that's not entirely true. But mostly.

After the shock of getting pregnant, after the whirlwind of getting married, of learning to *love* Luke – which I did, I *do*, I love him more than anything in the whole world, but it wasn't a love-at-first-sight thing and it wasn't even that much lust-at-first-sight – I didn't think about Wallace because there wasn't time. I had a baby. I had to learn to love the life that I had been thrown into. I was tired as hell.

And by the time I had time to think about him again – once the kids were toddlers who slept through the night... I was falling in love with Luke. After all that work together, making it even though we were so young, making our lives and our family *work*, I was in love with Luke.

But then, you know... marriage started to get dull. The sex that had picked up where it had left off so abruptly with that ill-timed pregnancy, dropped off again. I started to think about other things at night, other people, other... times.

I didn't have much else in my head besides Luke. He was the second guy I'd slept with. The first was a really huge dweeb from high school and the whole thing was so awkward I liked to – and often did – pretend that Luke was my first.

And only.

I never slept with Wallace.

But every now and then, depending on how things were with me and Luke, I liked to take out the *idea* of Wallace. The idea of a man so large, so dark, so good-looking. So... well, black.

I didn't like the way I thought about him. This is the confusing part. I had liked Wallace – really liked him. As a person. As an actor. He was funny, he was sweet, he was very, very smart.

But, just being honest, I was kind of afraid of him. I had grown up in a white, white neighborhood, with no black friends and no real black presence. Wallace was probably the first black guy I'd ever had a real conversation with.

And then there we were, thrust into this heated play, rehearsing and rehearsing, kissing and pretending to be in wild, adolescent love.

I liked giving myself into that. Into being so close to Wallace, to feeling his body against mine (through the costumes), to the heat of his chest against my back when he embraced me, to my girlish fantasies about him.

But I was far too afraid of him – afraid of the fact that he was black, I'll admit it – to act on any of that. The closest I got to it was on the final night of the play. After all of this intense sexual tension for months, we went outside at the after-party and he put his arms around me because I was cold. His back was hot, his arms were strong, and he nuzzled my neck with his lips. I could feel his erection against my lower back. Just the silhouette of it, a slight pulse against me. I could feel that it was huge, and then I felt a surge of arousal inside of me. I had never, ever felt that turned on before.

I remember deciding that I was going to sleep with him, envisioning myself going back to my own dorm room with him, or to his.

The rest of the cast came out, laughing, silly drunk. They gave us the eye – they weren't dumb, they'd seen this coming all summer long.

But something happened between that moment and the end of the after-party. I chickened out. Even though he was there around me, simmering all night long, I lost my nerve. I remembered looking at him, his arms leaning on his knees, his youthful, big, athletic body reminding me of an animal, and feeling suddenly afraid.

I know it sounds dumb. Prejudiced. Downright racist. And it was.

I also had next to no sexual experience. I was really concerned about making an ass of myself. Even though I had imagined the feel of his cock in my hand, how thick it might be, the heat of his body coursing through it – I got spooked by the idea of actually doing it.

He walked me back to my dorm and it was clear he wanted to go in. We kissed, and he slipped a hand under my shirt. His fingers grazed my nipples and I could feel my core throbbing. His lips were warm and dry, big; they were all I could think about. And he smelled good. The kind of smell I could never know how to explain.

"I can't... um... let you come in," I said, after we made out for a while.

He did that thing all guys do, saying "come on," and massaging the back of my neck. But he didn't pressure me.

I made up some excuse about how we were all leaving, and I didn't want to just be a one night stand. Or a long-distance relationship.

His mouth was right next to my ear when he said, "I wasn't thinking about just a one-night thing."

"I'm sorry," I remember saying. And then we kissed some more and I kind of scurried away, leaving Wallace looking more than a little

disappointed standing there. But not in that hurt-puppy kind of way. Not Wallace. He was way too smooth, way too street-tough for that kind of look.

We all left for our respective cities the next day. I didn't get a chance to see him before he left, but he left a note outside my door with his phone number. I called him once, and he wasn't home.

And that was all.

Time went on, I met Luke. I flung myself into a hook-up with him partly because I felt so stupid for passing up my chance with Wallace. I told myself it was for the best.

Luke was more my speed. He was white, for one thing. What if I had gotten involved with Wallace? I didn't know how to blend with black people. And as much as he aroused me, he also sort of scared me. It's just the truth, even if it isn't pleasant.

But he was unforgettable.

I started fantasizing about him sometimes. This was maybe when I was thirty. The seven-year itch, I guess. I got really into it. I let myself think about him at night. I masturbated to thoughts of him. I imagined scenarios in which we'd meet.

I thought of looking him up, I even went that far.

And then I decided that I felt too bad about it all. Luke was having a tough time at work, the kids were having tough times at school.... I sort of gave it up, if you'll believe this, for Lent. No more thinking about Wallace. Just being present with my family.

It would be a lie to say that it worked like a charm, that I never had a single thought in my head about him. But this is the thing: I *did* feel godawful for Luke. I knew he didn't know about it, but I'm a one-man kind of gal. And not only that, I was grateful to Luke for everything he'd done. All the sacrifices he'd made to make our family work. The way he'd agreed to try and salvage our lives when I got pregnant. The way he'd understood that I wasn't really Catholic, but I was... you know, too Catholic to do anything else.

And I hated the way I thought about Wallace. It was so carnal. So sexual. This isn't to say I didn't have a little bit of a romantic bit going on in my mind... but that isn't what I imagined most. Okay, it isn't even what I imagined 99.99% of the time.

Most of the time I thought about him. And the size of his cock. And the way it would feel if his muscled chest was against my back, hot and strong, while he was inside of me, stretching me out.

Even dirtier things got into my head than that.

After all, it was fantasy.

But like I said, I put it aside. I stuffed it way down deep inside and kept it there. I hadn't thought of him for a long time. I'm sure I would have, eventually – the kids were gone and I had nothing to do, Luke was working overtime to save his job... I was a bored housewife who only got out of the house to take classes for my Master's degree. Of course I would have gotten back to thinking about Wallace. There were so many hot, black young men on campus now...

But really. I kept it suppressed for so long.

And then there he was.

The truth is, I'd been aware of the time passing at that party. Aware of how it *looked*, me sitting there, talking to Wallace Brown and no one else. For hours. But the conversation – and this surprised me – just flowed so naturally. You know how you meet people from your past, and now they're in their late thirties and they're boring as hell? That's how most of my friends were. They all had their kids three years ago, right under the wire. They had toddlers and kindergartners, or infants and diapers, and they just wanted to go to bed early. I went through all that almost twenty years ago. I was feeling a need for adventure, excitement, staying up late and partying. Things that got cut off abruptly so long ago.

Wallace was that kind of guy. He'd ended up doing all kinds of things; he went to Harvard, he ran a theater for a while, he started his own company, he went to business school, he lived in Paris and Beijing and Bangkok and Dubai. He went parasailing and regular sailing and skydiving and on these hard-core camping trips in places I'd never heard of. He still loved the theater, but he went to theaters *everywhere*.

What was I supposed to do? Stop talking to him? It was all really exciting.

And he wanted to hear about me. Not what I'd been doing, so much, because that was a big can of nothing. But he wanted to talk about *something* – had I seen *Hamilton*, what did I think about the casting choices, had I been skydiving like I had always wanted to.

And so I knew it was starting to look bad; I knew it would bother Luke. I knew there was something a little bit improper about it, a hint of something sexual. But I stayed. Because it was fun.

It was exhilarating.

And it had been a long, long time since I'd had anything exhilarating in my life.

But I also knew that I could claim to have just wanted to catch up with an old friend. That's all there really was there – as long as that's all I told Luke there was.

*

So, like we usually did, we went to bed and brought up “the fight” the next morning. I know people say you should never go to bed angry, but Luke and I realized somewhere along the line that hashing out a whole big argument at night was just exhausting.

Half the stuff you fight about, you won't care about after you sleep.

But I woke up still caring, and I could tell Luke did, too. We got up, and he went to the kitchen sullenly to make some coffee. I took a shower and, as he coined the phrase, “prepared my remarks.” The thing was, I didn't really know where to start.

I knew, even in the shower, that I had no intention of telling Luke the whole truth.

And that felt like I had swallowed a bunch of rocks. I'd always been honest in our marriage – provided that you didn't count the omission of this attraction to Wallace – about everything. And yet I knew I was going to keep something from him when he asked me about this.

“So,” I said, sliding into the bench seat at our breakfast nook and nudging his knee. “You want to talk about it?”

He slid a coffee over for me and handed me a milk pitcher.

“Milk pitcher,” I said, trying to keep things light. “This is some fancy conversation, I guess.”

“I was out of line last night,” Luke said abruptly. That's how he was: once he decided to talk about something he liked to plow through it and get it over with.

But then he stopped talking, and folded his arms, and sighed.

He made no effort to move the conversation forward. “Um... thanks,” I said.

“Did you sleep with that guy?”

I shook my head. “No. Of course not.”

Luke pressed his lips together.

“Look,” I began. “He’s just an old friend. It’s... that’s all.”

Luke tapped his fingers on the table. “Okay...”

But it seemed like he had something else to say.

“Okay,” he said, sighing. “I don’t want to be a dick here, but it seemed like an awful lot more than that.”

This cut right through me, because... well, it was true. There was a lot more to it.

I didn’t know what to say to him.

I knew, though, that I didn’t want to tell him the truth, whatever the truth was. I mean, where does “the truth” even begin and end in a story like this? What could I say? That I’d never had sex with this guy I starred in a show with like two months before I met Luke, but that I’d tucked him away as a fantasy and brought him out after we’d raised kids together?

Tacky.

That the only reason I hadn’t hooked up with him was because he was black and I was sort of afraid of him?

Racist.

That when I thought about him – and I did – I only thought about fucking him, about how big his cock would be and how we would have this really animal sex?

Racist *and* tacky.

Did I tell Luke that part of the reason I’d jumped into bed with him so early on was partly because I had chickened out with Wallace?

My mother always told me to run anything I was going to say through these three tests: is it true? Is it necessary? Is it kind?

Was it even true? How much did I think about Wallace? Was it even Wallace, per se, or just a prototype of a black man? What kind of person thinks like that anyway?

And how could I explain that this was the kind of thing I just fantasized about, and would never *do*?

And was it necessary to tell him? What difference did it make, now? I wasn’t going to see Wallace again, and so all of this was just an exercise in

pointlessness. It wouldn't change anything.

But why did I feel bad about it then?

And was it kind?

No. It would definitely hurt Luke's feelings.

He looked dejected right now. And angry.

And I was supposed to be saying something.

His expression was almost hungry. It's almost like he wanted to extract the most painful narrative from me that he could. It almost seemed like he wanted me to tell him I'd fucked Wallace and he was better than him. He didn't seem to believe me that it had never happened, and that pissed me off.

I might omit things, but I won't tell him a straight-out lie.

I know.

I know.

Omission is a kind of lying. It's the same damn thing.

And that's what Wallace had been, all along, a secret thought in my mind that burned and made me wet when I played with myself late at night:

A lie.

"Listen," I said. "I was attracted to Wallace when we did that play,"

I couldn't tell if Luke's face was lighting up or falling.

"I didn't sleep with him," I added quickly. "I didn't even hook up with him, not really -"

"Not really? What does that mean?"

I looked at Luke. I didn't like the expression on his face. It was strange, a mixture of emotions I'd never seen before. I couldn't tell what he wanted, or why he was pursuing this inquiry so doggedly. He could see where it was headed.

"Uh..." I furrowed my brow. "Just, you know..."

"What?"

I made a face. "I don't know, Luke. You want specifics?"

My voice was a little heated. For some reason this felt really invasive. I had no right to feel that way, I suppose, but I didn't want to sit there and detail what I'd done.

"Did you kiss?" Luke asked.

"The play was *Romeo and Juliet*," I snapped.

"Outside of the play?" he pressured.

I gave him an ugly look. "I guess," I said.

“You guess? Either you did or you didn’t, Lisa.”

“Oh, my God,” I said. “Yes, we kissed.”

Luke did this thing where he lowers his chin and narrows his eyes.

“And?”

“I think he felt me up once.”

Still, the look.

“I don’t *really* want to sit here giving you every single detail about it.”

That’s when I saw it for the first time. I didn’t know what it was; I had never really seen it before. But in retrospect, it’s so obvious:

The idea of me kissing Wallace was turning him on.

But I mistook it at the time for him wanting more details to... I don’t know. Fuel his argument, or his jealousy. To prove that I was lying about something. And I started to feel guilty, which in turn irritated me. Because I was sort of guilty – guilty for thinking about Wallace, guilty for harboring a secret interest in him.

But not guilty in whatever way Luke seemed to think I was. Or better stated, the way I *thought* Luke thought I was guilty.

So I snapped at him: “This all happened before we met, anyway. So it’s not like I owe you some kind of explanation.”

I could see that Luke knew this was true. He held up his hands. “No. No, no. That’s true. I’m just wondering why you never mentioned this guy, is all.”

And that was the core of it: right then and there, I suppose I probably should have told him about how I had harbored an attraction for him all those years. After all, that was the answer to his question. That’s why I had never mentioned him. It’s why I had excised Wallace Brown and any mention of him from my stories.

But a person is entitled to some privacy in their own mind, right?

I shrugged.

“It just never came up,” I said. “What was I supposed to mention?”

“That you made out, with a hot black guy.”

Here was an opportunity to turn the tables on him, and boy, did I take it. “Oh, so you’ve told me about every single girl you’ve ever made out with?”

We stood there, blinking at each other. I couldn’t help letting a little smile creep into my mouth when I saw that Luke realized how ridiculous he

sounded.

“I’ve told you... about everyone I slept with.” A very tight grin was working its way into his mouth.

I clapped my hands together. “Well, great. So we’re even.”

Luke put his head in his hands and let out a very exasperated sigh. It was really... disproportionate to the discussion. “God. Lis. I don’t know. I know. I know it’s so stupid. I just... this guy is from Bain and Frost. He’s probably going to ax my fucking job, and he’s also some... GQ fucker. He drives a Tesla. You know? And then I find out he’s dated my wife -”

“We never dated.” I felt the need to interject it but right away I could see it was the wrong thing to say. “Sorry,” I added quickly, but Luke was already sighing. “I’m sorry... I... okay, it was kind of insensitive. I mean, I just didn’t think about all that. Last night. While I was talking to him.”

Luke rubbed his head.

I reached out and touched him on the arm. “Listen. What does it matter anyway? He’s... gone, right? He’s leaving when Bain and Frost is done with their consultation. So... it’s not like I’m ever going to see him again anyway.”

Luke looked up at me, his mouth sort of open.

“Let’s just not worry about it, okay?”

He rubbed his face. Lately, he’d been so stressed out. I honestly didn’t know what was wrong with him. I knew things were sort of shady at his work, but I was kind of of the opinion that if he got fired, it wouldn’t be the end of the world. He hated his job anyway. The kids were out of the house. I was going to finish up school and go back to teaching. After all this time working so hard for us, who cared if he got a break?

“Yeah, you’re right,” he said. “I’m... I don’t know...”

“Hey,” I said, and I was trying to be sincere. “I get it.”

He turned on his chair and held his arms out for me to give him a hug. I didn’t get it. Not really. Not just then.

But we hugged it out and had breakfast, and I thought the whole thing could be put behind us.

CHAPTER 3

Luke

So of course I ended up in an interview with Wallace and his hatchet-man, Troy, on Monday. I got an email to “swing by” Steve’s office, where he dumped the news on me, asked me if I had great time or what at his party, and started shooing me out the door with a lot of white-toothed grinning and silly babbling.

The office they’d been assigned was all glass, but they were drawing the blinds these days. I guess in case someone started crying. I stiffened my spine when I saw that it was Wallace in the seat behind the desk.

They stood up to shake my hand, and then Wallace smoothed out his tie as he sat down. “SO listen, man,” he began, and that set me off right away. That had a very, very bad vibe to it. A “we’re-gonna-talk-man-to-man” vibe about it. “I think before we start this interview, it’s best we disclose...” he looked over at Troy, who was very theatrically “taking note” of what Wallace was saying - “that we have a little bit of a relationship. Now I’ve -”

“Sorry?” I said. “What relationship?”

Wallace leveled me with a look, and then he continued. “So, I’ve spoken to head office, about the matter of me being an old friend of your wife’s. They don’t see any potential conflict of interest here, but I’ve been asked to run it past you.”

“Run it past me,” I repeated. “What’s that?”

“Well, if you’re uncomfortable with me assessing your role and position here at Quantum, because I had a prior relationship with your wife -”

“Nah,” I said, and I was trying to make it sound cool. “That’s a little overboard, isn’t it? I mean, your relationship was not very...” I found that I was speaking for Troy’s benefit more than anything. He was hanging on every word with *supreme* interest. “Intimate,” I finished. “And it was ages ago.”

Wallace was nodding. “That’s what I assumed you’d say,” he said coolly. “I just thought I’d extend you the courtesy of asking. We don’t want anything to look improper.”

And then he reached across the table and poured himself a glass of water. Sipped it. And dove right in. “Now, as you’re aware, it’s Bain and Frost’s purpose to....”

I was there in the room, answering his questions, and all in all I think I did a pretty good job, considering that one full half of my brain was somewhere else entirely. Spinning wildly, drifting back to that fantasy. Picturing Lisa dropping to her knees, her hand wrapped around Wallace’s cock. Wallace looking down at her, kind of the way he was looking at me, at that moment: cool, professional. Ready to get his cock sucked.

“Well,” Wallace concluded, standing up and reaching over the table to shake my hand. “We really appreciate your input, Luke. I think it’s been very informative.”

I shook his hand and blathered some kind of corporate platitude while my mind reeled, wondering what the hell I had just told him.

I left the conference in a daze and settled into my tiny office, which was really a kind of cubicle with a sliding door. As soon as I closed the door, my mind was percolating with image after image of my wife and Wallace together.

I find it hard to remember now if I had the fantasy about Lisa with another man before Wallace Brown walked into our lives. I think maybe I occasionally entertained the idea; I would see her laughing with someone at a party, her hand on his arm, and my mind would briefly flirt around with the idea. I know I had liked to occasionally let the sting of jealousy gnaw at me, for a few moments.

And sure, I know there was always something there about black guys in particular – but it wasn’t like I ran into a ton of them. And more specifically, it wasn’t like Lisa ran into a ton of them. But I would be lying if I said I didn’t gravitate to porn with black guys on white women, and if I said I had never felt a queasy kick in my gut, passing some built black guy in the street with Lisa next to me. It gave me a peculiar thrill if they looked over at her, if I sensed they found her attractive.

But I am pretty sure I never fantasized about in it detail, not until Wallace. I know I never locked myself in my cubicle, failing to work for a whole afternoon because my mind was overflowing with filthy images of my wife together with a black man. Lisa on her knees, sliding Wallace’s belt through his buckle with a coy smile on her face. Lisa looking up at Wallace’s eyes as she opened her mouth and sucked on his cock. Lisa’s

tongue flicking in and out of her mouth as she lapped up the spurting cum he jerked off onto her face. Lisa moaning and holding her thighs open as Wallace lined up the gigantic head of his cock against her pussy, slowly sinking into her flesh while she squirmed beneath him in pleasure.

I looked at my computer screen. It was 12:37. I had wasted so much of the day, spacing out, my fingers hovering over the keyboard. Emails had piled up in my inbox; the phone had rung and I hadn't even noticed.

I wiped my brow, where beads of sweat had gathered. It was hot in my office, I realized. Just thinking about Lisa and Wallace, Wallace and Lisa, Wallace's big cock in Lisa's pussy, had heated the small room up to an almost unbearable temperature.

I didn't want to open the door just yet, though.

Jesus, I thought.

What the hell was going on? What was wrong with me?

You know how after you watch porn and get off, you sit there feeling like a bit of a jackass? That's how I felt, even though there was ultimately no satisfactory end to my train of dirty thoughts. Even though I'd be just as content sinking right back into them – but I already had the bad feeling of having done something sexual while thinking about something truly filthy. The kind of things I definitely wouldn't want to share with anyone else.

Especially Lisa. God. Especially not with her.

How could I ever tell someone I loved as much as I loved Lisa that I pictured her bent in half with her back propped up against the back of a couch, Wallace crouched over her and shoving his dick into her pussy?

And *why* was I thinking about that?

But by far the worst thought? The worst thought was not necessarily one of the pornographic situations I designed in my mind. The worst thought I had was that Lisa seemed to be attracted to Wallace. If I pushed in just the right way, if I tinkered with things just so... I could maybe actually nudge Lisa into fucking Wallace.

It burned to even think about it.

But in a good way.

Sort of.

"Fuck me," I said aloud. I picked up the phone and dialed my messages. For good measure, I threw open the door to the office and let some cool air waft in.

The messages went in one ear and out the other.

I decided to go get some coffee.

*

And what did you know?

“Fuck me,” I muttered again, when I saw him sitting at one of the sunny tables in the company cafeteria on the first floor. Quantum is one of those “lifestyle” companies, with a “campus” and a lot of constant pressure to eat healthy and get exercise.

Of course, it was a good thing, but people sometimes got so fanatical about it I wanted to punch them in the throat. We had a team leader once who made us do walking meetings. There’s nothing wrong with it, and I get the idea behind it. It just annoyed the fuck out of me.

The cafeteria was along the same lines, so I rarely went there.

Naturally, Wallace was sitting there the one time I went in over a year.

He wasn’t hard to see. Not only was he the only black man in the cafeteria, he was likely the only black man in the building, and he was probably the only black man to have been there in the past three months.

He even *sat* like a smooth player.

I bought a sandwich and a coffee and surveyed my options. There were a handful of people in the large, brightly-lit room.

Not sitting by him would probably look like a pussy thing to do somehow. Like I was afraid of him because he was a Bain and Frost consultant and likely going to hand me my ass in about two weeks. Sitting by him, however, might look like even more of a pussy thing to do, since it’d be sort of kissing his ass.

Jesus, I thought. Split the difference.

I walked by him, but in a way that made it possible for me to keep going, depending on how he reacted.

“Hey, Wallace,” I said, as I passed. He was deep into his food.

Wallace looked up. He didn’t hesitate even a minute. Almost like he had been expecting me. “Oh hey man, have a seat.” He kicked a chair out from under the table on my side, and motioned for me to sit down.

It was the kind of invite I couldn’t really refuse.

Warily, I sat down.

Wallace’s plate was piled up with green vegetables and tofu. He went back to eating it.

“That’s a really healthy meal,” I said, and then felt immediately stupid.

Wallace stabbed his salad with his fork violently, piling about thirty pieces of lettuce onto it. “Gotta keep it to lean proteins and leafy greens. I’m training for a marathon.”

Of course he was.

I scowled at my sandwich as I picked it up and bit into the carbs. Sweet, delicious carbs. I felt like my relatively small pouch of belly-fat grew as soon as my teeth touched the bread.

“So Lisa,” Wallace said, and my stomach felt like it turned to iron and fell through me to the floor. “She’s going back to do her Master’s now?”

That was fast.

I didn’t really want to have this conversation. And yet I did. And yet there was something delicious about it, even though it was cold and awful and burning inside of me.

“Yeah. She’s doing an MFA, actually.”

Wallace was destroying his salad with his huge mouth. He nodded. “That’s good,” he said, finally. He cut into a chunk of tofu and stabbed it just as violently with his fork. The guy was somehow eating tofu and salad with impeccable manners but like a fucking barbarian. “She’s such a talented actress. That’s good, I’m glad she’s doing that.”

I was quiet for a moment, and then it was like an alien took over my mind and my body.

Or maybe not, maybe it was just my subconscious.

Either way, one part of me, at least, was surprised, as I found myself saying:

“Hey, you know, if you’re interested... she’s in a production for the university. I think it’s in about three weeks. You should come. If you’re around still, that is.” Wallace looked up at me. “I think she’d really like it if you were there,” I added quickly.

A full half of my brain was screaming inside my head: *what the fuck are you doing?*

Wallace looked mildly surprised, but he didn’t change his expression much because, well, it was obvious that’s the kind of guy he was: unflappable. He held his tofu in midair. “Three weeks, huh? What is it?”

“Huh?” I said, still catching up with my own mouth.

“What’s the play?”

“Oh,” I said, and then I suddenly felt incredibly awkward, and awkward for feeling awkward. “Um... *Othello*.”

For some reason, and I know this was stupid, I felt like I’d dropped the n-word.

But this, Wallace Brown seemed to find amusing. “Oh, yeah?” he said. He wiped his mouth.

“She’s Desdemona,” I added, talking quickly to cover up the stupid, stupid way I was talking about this play. “I can get you tickets for opening night. I think she’d... uh, be really happy if you came. You could surprise her.”

Wallace was nodding. He crumpled the fuck out of his napkin and dropped it on his plate. He looked at me with an expression that indicated that I, at least, was surprising the fuck out of him. “Well then,” he said. “Yeah, get me one of those tickets. I’d love to come.” He looked at his watch. “Gotta run. See you later, man.”

And he left.

*

I wasn’t sure what I was doing. That much was for sure. It wasn’t as if I *liked* the idea of Wallace going to *Othello*, seeing my wife on stage, seducing her, and then having sex with her.

And yet I found myself imagining that very scenario, over and over and over again. I lost valuable work time, getting almost nothing done that afternoon, and I barely remembered the drive home when I almost passed my exit on the freeway.

Lisa was at class that night, something I’d forgotten. When I got home to the darkened rooms, the empty house, I’d gone right into thinking the worst: she was out with Wallace.

A ridiculous thought, but this was the state of mind I was in.

I made myself a cocktail and plunked into a chair at my desk in the new office we’d made out of Drake’s old room.

I started out fine; perusing news sites and the top *news* stories on Reddit. I checked my Facebook account but was daunted by the 111 notifications that had generated from my meager collection of friends in the past three or four weeks since I had last logged in.

I wasn’t much of a social guy, in real life or online.

Then I went back to Reddit. I fell into some of the usual traps (/r/cableporn (not what you think) and /r/AskReddit) before I had the idea to begin spying a little on my wife.

I hardly ever looked at Lisa's Facebook account, and I only know my Instagram from my SnapChat because it's part of my job. But I knew Lisa was a prolific user of all things social media. Curiously, I had just never been interested in what she did.

So my idea was to just go to her Facebook page, take a look at her friend list, maybe try to get some idea of what she was up to online.

In my mind, I wasn't necessarily accusing her of having an affair. It was far darker than that. I wanted to find something. I could feel the idea of it pulling at me, and it was strangely alluring.

I scanned her friends for a dark face. When I found pictures of smiling black men I looked them up, digging deeper into *their* accounts and *their* friends. Trying to find out when Lisa had made friends with them, how she knew them.

It was deeply unsatisfying. They all seemed – quite obviously – to be classmates from school. And there was no real reason to think that Lisa had been bonking all these guys in her classes just because they were black and she happened to spend two hours talking to a black man the other night.

In other words: Lisa wasn't fucking all the black men in the world like a slut just because I imagined she was.

This was the rational side of me, speaking to myself in a calm voice.

But I had really caught a bug of some kind.

So I broke into her account.

I used her computer, a laptop she kept next to her bed so she could watch Netflix while she was falling asleep. She liked to watch the most godawful things and only watched about two minutes of it, while the light and the vague noise of the voices penetrated my skull as I lay there sleepless with all my money anxieties. But it kept her happy, so whatever.

I tried her birthday, my birthday, Drake's birthday, and then each of our names. To my surprise, "Luke" was the password on her laptop.

"So insecure," I muttered, and I had no idea if I was condemning her password choice or myself.

And of course she was logged in to Facebook, not that it would have taken a genius mastermind to break into that account, either. Lisa rolled her

eyes every time I told her to make more secure passwords, saying she didn't have an identity worth stealing, anyway.

Naturally, this irritated me.

Back to Facebook. I was in her account.

Lisa had been up to a lot lately, and she had quite a few notifications. Up in the corner, a "Friend Request" glared at me. I wanted desperately to look at it, to see if it was Wallace, but I knew if I did, the notification would disappear and I wouldn't be able to make it look new again.

Not that, in all likelihood, that would tip Lisa off to anything suspicious – she was not a suspicious person about online activities or strange things like that, as I've just explained – but still.

I was able to go through her messages, at least. I felt like a real shit, spying on who she had written to, what they were saying. I started to hope I would come across some kind of juicy gossip or salacious pictures, but there was nothing in the messages but banter, plans for lunch, holiday greetings, and the usual stupid shit people message on Facebook, like warnings about formaldehyde in shampoo.

By then it was getting late, and I was getting increasingly – and surprisingly – dissatisfied.

I started to close the laptop, when I had a last idea.

Sure enough, her email loaded, the password was saved. And there in the spam I found it:

Trent Packer has sent you a friend request.

I closed the laptop, seething at myself.

Of course Wallace Brown was not on fucking Facebook. He was an executive at a consulting firm, he had an online image to protect.

And what did I think I was going to find, supposing he was, and he'd sent her a friend request? Being Facebook friends hardly meant you were fucking someone these days.

Steaming with private embarrassment, I returned to my own computer.

I looked at the clock.

Lisa would be home in an hour or so.

For some reason, I was getting aroused. Well... some reason. The reason was, I was thinking about her and Wallace. The jealousy was so cold it burned, but for some reason it settled in my balls and made my cock hard as a rock.

So I did what any man would do.
I started watching porn.

CHAPTER 4

Lisa

I have no idea why I snuck into the house that night.

It was dark; Luke hadn't turned on any of the lights. I could see the blue glow of his computer splotched on the hallway. I knew the glow; I knew where it came from and how it was made.

I parked in the driveway and went in through the side door. He didn't stir.

Was it because I had my own secrets and I felt guilty about them?

Maybe.

Was it just curiosity? A secret desire to have a window into what Luke did when he was alone?

Probably.

And it was unfair. After all, I had just spent the whole day thinking of justifications for why I didn't need to tell him every single thing I thought about. I had really heaped on the reasons for why I was entitled to some privacy in my own thoughts, entitled to my own sexual fantasies.

And yet, there I was, creeping down the hallway and hoping to get a glimpse of what he was up to.

Our house is eerily quiet. The floors never squeak. You can sneak around very easily, and in fact there were a few nights when one of the kids had scared the shit out of one of us because they were creeping back into the house after a party and we ran into each other at the bend in the hallway, as neither one of us had heard each other.

I don't know what I thought I was going to say if I got caught, but I supposed I would just say I was looking for him. Why hadn't I called out or turned on a light?

Just because.

I didn't expect to see what I saw though.

I heard the sound of him jerking off from a distance. It's the kind of sound that's unmistakable, and it sounds gross as hell to say this but.. you know... I'd lived through two teenage boys.

And so, I should have turned around.

I was a little scandalized, but I was also curious. Maybe in a little bit of a mean-spirited way, maybe in a way that made me want to justify my own fantasies by finding out that he had them, too. Maybe I would find him looking at Asian porn, like my friend Mika (a robust, Irish-Swedish woman) had found in her husband's porn stash. And then we would be even-Steven.

Maybe that's what I was hoping for.

By standing slightly off to the side and back, I was able to see the reflection of the computer on the window, and still stay out of his eyeline.

He had his headphones on, one ear off, presumably to listen for me. But he was engrossed in what he was watching now.

I stared at the reflection in the window.

No Asian girls. No busty Amazonian women. No women I could never be like.

No; in fact, the woman was blonde. Very much like me, except for her porn-star boobs.

She was bent over (I couldn't see too well) on her hands and knees, looking back at the man who was fucking her.

And the guy was a big, well-endowed black man.

I could hear her squeaking through the headphones from where I was.

I stared, got an eyeful, and then turned and went quickly back to the kitchen.

The image seemed to be burned in my sight by then.

And more inexplicably?

It had me really, really turned on.

I guess it wasn't that inexplicable.

But why was Luke watching it?

I steadied myself on the counter, my mind bursting with the possibilities.

I mean, it was just *porn*.

Maybe he had always been into watching black guys having sex with white women. Maybe that was what he got so upset about Wallace for.

But wait... that didn't make a lot of sense. Why would somebody watch something they found disturbing?

And he was jacking off to it, too... I didn't want to forget that.

What did that mean?

The image stayed in my mind. It was so lurid, so filthy, so... racist.

And it was making me think of Wallace.

And it was making me wet.

I turned on the kitchen lights and slammed the door. “Honey?” I said.

I felt like I was drunk, reeling around as I slowly walked back to the office, giving him time to make it look like he was doing something else.

“Hey,” I said, leaning on the door.

I could see he was flustered. The porn was off and he was typing into a word document. “Hey. Oh, hey,” he said, pulling the headphones off his head.

I realized then that I hadn’t given him enough time to... er, finish. I felt bad for a second, but then I felt my own desire.

And then I just went with it. I was more turned on than I had been in a long time.

I sauntered into the room.

Luke, truth be told, looked a little afraid of me as I did. But he turned in his chair and I sat down on his lap. I was really feeling desire at this point, like I hadn’t felt in an eternity. A real ache, and it was borne of such a confusing mix of things. But I didn’t want to think about any of that.

I just wanted to fuck.

Luke

Lisa scared the shit out of me when she came home.

I was deep, deep in the porn bubble.

It had started out pretty normal. Standard porn fare.

I am not a crazy porn guy. I enjoy watching a bit of anal from time to time, but that’s about as wild as I get. I don’t even think I like anal, not that I know because I’ve never been there (and furthermore, I can’t even imagine how I’d bring up the topic with my wife, let alone going through with it). But all the crazy fetishes that are out there? No thanks.

But, like any man who has ever been on the internet for more than twenty seconds, I was acutely aware that there was a lot of black man/white woman porn out there. And since Wallace had been on my mind, that’s the first thing I went to.

And that’s when I found this rabbit hole:

Black man gives it to wife brutal

I was a pretty innocent guy. I figured this was a black man fucking his own wife. But because my own demented mind was busy putting a black

man inside of *my* wife, my brain just directed me to click on it.

And then I discovered: there are a lot of people on the internet who like the idea of their wives getting fucked by black men.

Aside from a certain sense of relief (that I was not alone in my perversion), I was also genuinely thrilled. Totally turned on. And I just started going for it, looking for the perfect video. Watching the ones that were close, but not quite right, sifting through them until I found one of a petite blonde getting pummeled from behind by a huge black man.

I was almost... ehem, done... when I heard the door slam and the light from the kitchen came on.

The whole scene enveloped me like a door getting slammed in my face. Maybe I even heard an actual bang. Bang! The house was all dark. Bang! I had my dick in my hand and I was watching porn. Bang! Lisa was home.

I slapped at the keyboard to get rid of the image, while clumsily tucking my aching cock into my pants. The high I was on was making my ears ring, my balls throb, I couldn't get the image out of my head, and I was shaking.

Almost caught.

Lisa appeared in the doorway.

"Hey," she said.

She was wearing a clingy black shirt-sweater. The material was so thin her skin glowed through it, except where she had on a camisole beneath. But the curve of her breasts tantalized through it. She had on tight-fitting jeans, and she looked more luscious than ever.

My ears were ringing so loudly I could hardly hear my own voice as I blabbered away: "Oh, hey, hey..."

Something.

Lisa was holding the ends of her sweater sleeves in a... really? ... what seemed like a playfully seductive way.

Was I sweating? I wondered. I hoped she wouldn't notice.

But then Lisa did a very – very – unusual thing. She pushed herself away from the door frame with her hip and came into the room. I turned the chair a little, and glanced one last time at the screen to make sure the porno wasn't still playing on it.

Lisa sat down on my thigh.

"I was thinking," she purred, grinning.

She didn't finish the sentence.

I was actually a little afraid for a moment, and totally shocked by what she was doing. She moved her hand along my chest, over the bulge in my pants, down my thigh, then back up to my throbbing cock.

She didn't seem at all surprised to find my erection, but by then I wasn't really interested in what had just happened. I was just focused on the way her pretty white teeth were sinking into her lip, and the way her fingers felt on the outline of my dick. Scraping against the hard fabric with her nails. She was sending shivers through me.

I put a hand behind her neck and pulled her mouth to mine. Her lips were wet and plump, and she had a faint flavor of juice on her tongue. I stood up, and she dropped off my thigh and onto her feet without unlocking her mouth from mine. She was moving against my lips eagerly, exploring my mouth for more.

I pushed her backward into the hallway and across it to our bedroom. The images I had just viewed had me really wound up. I threw her onto the bed, and she bounced prettily, her tits shaking under her soft sweater.

She unbuttoned her jeans and I pulled at them from the cuffs to slide her soft skin out of them. She was wearing a plain pair of black underwear, and I reached for the middle of them to pull them down to her knees.

I was assailed by the sweet scent of her arousal, and it stunned me. Not enough to make me stop what I was doing, but enough to disorient me for a moment. Lisa was never this excited from just a kiss. I pushed her legs up and plunged my thumb between the lips of her pussy. Her very fine blonde hair was soaked and sticky, and between her outer labia, the insides of her cunt were a puddle of arousal.

I yanked on the panties until they went over her ankle and her legs were free to spread open. I pushed her shirt up and grazed her navel, peppering her skin with kisses as I moved down to her cunt. She worked her fingers into my hair, grasping it tightly. Her body rose from the mattress toward me, ready. She pushed her pussy into my mouth when I got there. The full wetness of her cunt splattered over my lips and chin.

My tongue wandered through the slick wetness of her flesh until I found her engorged clit, and I closed my mouth around it and began to flick at the raw nerves beneath the hood, teasing her. She went wild underneath me, her hips rocking violently.

I began to massage her with a steady rhythm. I could feel the shudders traveling through her abdomen in time with my tongue. The tangy taste of her cunt filled my mouth. Her thighs shook in my hands, and her breath became ragged, almost squeaky.

Lisa was an actress, and sure, I knew sometimes she embellished her performances, but this was no performance. Her pussy was so wet it was dripping down my chin.

When she came, she pulled tight on my hair and thrust her hips upward. She made noises she had never made before, and her legs shook with the kind of un-falsifiable tension of a muscle spasm.

I looked up at her, and she briefly looked down, before closing her eyes and rolling her head back.

I rose up on my knees and shimmied out of my pants and boxers. My cock was aching by now.

But by far the most erotic thing was to look down at Lisa, her legs flopped open, the glistening juices of her cunt smeared on her inner thighs – and see her eyes closed and her hand to her mouth. The pose was unmistakable, and I could see she had no idea she was even doing it: she was lost in her own thoughts, her own fantasy.

I guided my cock to her pussy, and then I sank into her flesh. She was so wet that I cut through her effortlessly. It had been such a long time since she had been so excited.

For a bit, she lay there, her mind so clearly elsewhere (which only turned me on even more), but suddenly, she became animated. She squeezed me with her thighs and dug her heels into my lower back. Her fingers dug deep into my back, and she bucked against me.

I fought to hang on until she came. It wasn't easy. The images of the filthy porn I had watched were so easy to montage with Lisa's face, when she was right there, underneath me. It was so easy to imagine her face looking back at the black man fucking her, so easy to imagine that at that moment, she herself was thinking of Wallace.

She came again, and her cunt squeezed my cock, sending me over the edge. I yelled and clutched her hair as I came. It was a little rough but she was miles away, her eyes were glassy and shuttered to her thoughts.

I rolled over and pulled her close to me. What would she think, I wondered, if she knew that the thought of her fucking Wallace actually squeezed my balls so hard it made me come?

I decided to say something else, of course.
But I did wonder.

* *Lisa* *

A ream of guilt went through me when Luke exhaled and said, “Wow. That was... something. What brought that on?”

Because of course the truth was something I didn’t want to tell him.

How wrong was it to be thinking of another man while you were having sex with your husband? I know there’s the popular culture myth that men do it all the time (think of other women).

Sometimes I thought about other things, for sure. Laundry. Car insurance payments I’d forgotten. It’s not like, after being married for so long, I thought Luke was just totally into it, thinking of me, passionately wrapped up in the moment. I mean, come on. And the sex between us was pretty uninspired.

I’d never, ever, ever admit it to him, but it could be a little bit of a chore. It wasn’t that it wasn’t pleasant, it’s just that in the end, I didn’t get a ton out of it. Like, I really would rather take a bath. But I loved Luke, so I tried to get into it, and most of the time it was okay. Sometimes it was great, like it used to be. (But that generally required alcohol.)

But this was, honest to jeebus, the first time I had ever actively imagined myself having sex with another man while I was *having sex* with Luke.

I had imagined it so vividly, too. With the help of the blurry porno reflected on the window, I’d been able to conjure up a great deal of detail about what I imagined Wallace to be like. While Luke was stroking my clit with his tongue, I was picturing the contours of Wallace’s body, the details of the shape of his cock, what his pubic hair would feel like – short and bristly? Curly and soft? - and the size of his dick. I imagined in great detail what it would be like to run my tongue along the rim of his cock, dipping into the hole in the center to taste his precum, opening wide to fit it all inside of my mouth. And all of that imagining made me come so fast and so hard that my head was spinning.

A wave of guilt came over me when the sensation of the orgasm ebbed. I had my hand in Luke’s hair and I found myself wanting to look

down and see Wallace's dark, intense stare looking up at me, instead of my husband.

But the guilt dissipated, to my own surprise. When Luke's body covered mine I found myself back at it again, imagining how Wallace's body would feel against mine. He was taller, he was more muscular, he always seemed to be hotter. The weight of him would feel heavier, my lips would only come to his nipples, and I could bite into them with my teeth. I wondered if he liked that kind of thing, if his cock would flex inside of me.

And his cock. I knew from the shape of his cock against my back, so many years ago, that he was bigger and thicker than Luke. Not that that mattered, right? But the idea of it, the idea of being filled even more, of my body stretching to accommodate him while his scent enveloped me and the weight of his muscled, ebony body pressed me into the sheets...

That's what I was envisioning as I bucked against my husband, and came again, just as Luke did.

As his cum filled me and I spiraled down from the high I was feeling, the reality of where I was and what I was doing set in. And the guilt, creeping up around me, like long, hot tendrils. It made my cheeks burn.

Was I crossing a line, imagining these things? Somehow, I felt that I was.

But you haven't done anything, I told myself.

I closed my eyes. I wasn't really able to look Luke in the eye. He rolled over and panted next to me, then pulled me close to him. I settled my cheek on his chest and traced my fingers over his body, trying to push away more thoughts that came barging into my consciousness. Like what it would be like to touch Wallace like that, lying on top of his muscled chest, his cum leaking onto my thighs.

So what could I say, to Luke's question?

I elected to say nothing. I mumbled a slightly incoherent "mm-hmm."

Luke lifted his chin to kiss the back and top of my head. He wrapped his arms around me and squeezed me. Then he stabbed an ice pick of guilt through my heart:

"I love you, Lisa."

I felt like my heart was going to kick through my chest.

I looked up at him. "I love you, too," I said.

And it was true. Absolutely true; I felt that as I said it.

But that didn't change how rotten I felt for the thoughts that were going through my mind.

CHAPTER 5

Luke

I chased Wallace down the hall sometime at the end of the week.
“Hey, Wallace,” I said.

It’s important to note that even as I was doing this, even *I* wasn’t really sure what I was up to. It’s almost as if some devilish part of me had taken over the command center of my brain, and started to plot something I couldn’t have explained for the life of me.

“Hey, Luke,” Wallace said. He turned toward me but kept up his quick pace. A master of the corporate: “I’m here for you, but make it snappy” routine.

“I keep running into a few snags getting those tickets for you, and, uh, Lisa has a bunch of questions like what seat do you want and which night... she asked me to get your number so she can just text you. I didn’t know if that was cool or not, since -”

Wallace stopped dead in his tracks and took out his phone. “Sure man,” he said. “You wanna just give me hers while we’re here?”

It remains difficult to explain the rush it gave me as I read off Lisa’s phone number to him. Part of the rush was adrenaline of the “what-the-fuck” kind: in the back of my mind I was now realizing that if Wallace were to, say, send a text right then, I would likely be caught in the strange lie I had just told.

Because Lisa wasn’t even aware I had invited him.

And the other part of the mix was the excitement. I was giving Wallace Lisa’s cellphone number.

I watched him type it in. Something seemed a little odd, though I wouldn’t put my finger on it until later. I entered his name into my contacts list. Wallace Brown.

“I hope this isn’t... uh, weird,” I said. “I don’t know if you give -”

Wallace held up his hand. “It’s my business number,” he said, grinning. “I think you have it somewhere anyway. So it’s cool.”

“Great,” I said. My smile was plastic. “So, um... just send her a text or something and she’ll work it out with you.”

Wallace smiled at me. He tucked his phone away. “Great.”

I held my hand up in a goodbye wave that I hoped looked as cool as I wanted it to.

Then I ran for my office, wondering what the fuck I had done and hoping Lisa picked up as soon as I called.

I wasn't sure exactly what I was doing, like I said. I think the idea I had was, loosely, to put Wallace and Lisa in touch with each other. To give his number to her, to put them into a situation where Lisa would be tempted, and facilitated, to do something naughty.

I called her, shutting the door to my cubicle-office with a slam.

"Hey-yo," Lisa said. "This is unexpected."

"Hey. Honey," I said. I lowered my voice to a loud whisper, realizing I didn't really want anyone overhearing this conversation. I plopped into my chair, hoping the computer would muffle my call from Troy's ears. "Listen, I, uh..."

"You okay?" Lisa said. "You sound out of breath. Are you running? Are you *jogging*?"

"Lisa," I snapped, and I sounded much more frantic than I wanted (or needed to).

I was acting like a fucking idiot.

Lisa cut herself off. "What?"

"I'm just... sorry, I'm just in a hurry and... anyway. I wanted to tell you, before I forgot, I gave your number to Wallace Brown."

There was a silence on the other end of the line. A big, long, delicious silence that sank right through my abdomen like lava.

"Wh- huh? What, did he ask for it or something?"

There was a funny tone in Lisa's voice. I took it for a flirtatious nervousness. Like someone had just asked her for her number at a mall in the early nineties.

"Kind of," I said, not wanting to diminish her excitement.

Silence again.

Then, a very strange: "Oh. Uh... so..."

"I mentioned that you're in that play," I said. "And he said he wanted to come. So, I, uh... I thought it'd be easier if you just gave him all the details."

Lisa sounded happier once she heard this.

Almost... relieved. "Oh. Oh, that. Oh, okay... well. Yeah, sure, that's fine. That's weird that he wants to come. But... yeah, okay, so, whatever.

So he's calling me?"

Words barely describe how much pleasure – perverse, filthy pleasure – I was getting out of the way Lisa was babbling like a love-struck adolescent right then.

But even better: I seemed to have accomplished my goal and wormed my way out of a potentially sticky situation.

"Yeah. Okay? I just wanted you to know before he called you out of the blue or something."

"Um... okay. Great. So... thanks. How's your day going?"

"Swell. A little busy."

"Okay, well, I won't keep you then..."

"Okay. See you around six?"

"Great. Yeah... no. I mean, yeah, maybe later. I promised to have coffee with this gal from my theater class."

And on it went, but I didn't pay much attention. My heart was beating too fast, and my mind had gone directly into the gutter.

CHAPTER 6

Lisa

The guilt was starting to get to me in a big way.

That call from Luke was *killer*.

You know what they say: guilty conscience sees conspiracy everywhere? I was like Lady Macbeth all of the sudden.

I was sure, when Luke told me he'd given Wallace my number, that I was being walked into a trap. My hands and feet went cold and I started to sink through the ground in shame. I was already imagining how I would explain things to Luke.

I had almost forgotten – and this was the absolute truth – that Wallace and I had exchanged mobile numbers at the barbecue. I had been pretty tipsy when it happened, and it was just one of those things that evolved. It had seemed so strange to just walk away at the end of the conversation and not have any plans to talk again. He made it easy, saying he didn't have Facebook. He could take my email.

I'm the one who said, oh, let me just give you my cell.

I knew it was over the line the moment I said it. But I figured, I'd delete it like two months from then, after never using it. It was just one of those things you do with a person you haven't seen in a long time. In fact, *not* taking his number would have been admitting that I had some kind of attraction to him, in my opinion.

Because what was I going to do with it? I wasn't going to send him a text. I wasn't going to call him.

It was just the way you wrap up an old meeting like that. And then you never talk to that person again anyway, but somehow leaving that door open just a crack makes it easier to do.

So when Luke called talking about Wallace's phone number, that's all I heard and all I could think about. I thought for sure I had been found out, and that Luke was mad about it, and he was tricking me into lying to him about it.

You can't be sure of that, though, can you?

I made one bad decision after another. It felt horrible, but I just didn't... want to get caught having done something that was so obviously

over the line. Not when I never planned to use it. Not when it didn't mean anything. I just didn't feel like having the argument about it.

Or hurting Luke. It would just hurt his feelings.

So I played dumb.

It cut right through me to do it, because it was so false, but I did it anyway.

The whole time, I was thinking of this political philosophy class I took. The teacher was obsessed with stories of ordinary people who slowly slid into awfulness, like Slobodan Milosovic. I know I wasn't murdering people here, but I was acutely aware of my slow march into grayer and grayer ethical areas.

I looked at my wedding ring while I lied.

I saw Wallace's face and my gut twisted.

Then, just like that, I was out of the trap.

And on a high.

Not only was I not caught, but Wallace had kept the secret of already having my number. Not only that, but he wanted to come see my play.

My insides melted and it would be a lie to say that I didn't get a little aroused.

Then I started blathering like an idiot.

It was actually impossible to control myself.

Surely Luke was going to notice this. Surely he would ask me what the hell my problem was.

But he didn't. And then the conversation was over.

I clutched the phone to my chest, and tried very, very hard not to feel excited. I tried very hard not to feel like I was floating from the knowledge that Wallace was coming to see me.

And then, almost too soon for my senses, Wallace texted me:

[WB]: *Hi beautiful. It's me. I want to come to your play. Any show, any seat. Does that work for you?*

I actually dropped my phone while trying to type my reply, because my hands were shaking with excitement. Or nervousness.

Shakily I picked it up.

There was nothing *wrong* with responding to Wallace, I told myself. My own husband had given him the number, after all. Nothing wrong with

Wallace coming to the show. It made sense; we were old friends, it's how we had met; we were interested in theater.

And Luke knew all about it. Luke was the one who'd invited him, evidently. Not me.

I started to really lay it on thick for myself. How it was all okay, everything I was doing, because Luke knew all about this whole thing. The fact that I had had Wallace's number before Luke obtained it wasn't relevant. *Now* he knew about it, and responding to Wallace was just fine.

I typed, and erased, and typed again.

The whole time I was doing this I realized I was trying very hard to walk the line between flirting with Wallace, and showing him that I was interested in him, luring him in, in a way...

And staying faithful to Luke.

I typed:

Hi. I'm flattered.

A good and faithful wife would have written the following:

But it's going to be a terrible show. And you probably shouldn't come.

Or something like that. I thought about writing that Luke wouldn't like it, but if he had "given" Wallace my number, that wasn't exactly true, was it?

It felt nice, in a way, to be off the hook for that. This was Luke's fault, after all. He had given him my number, he had told him it was okay for Wallace to come. Why the hell did he even tell him about it? I hadn't told him.

Or maybe I had.

Something was fishy.

But I didn't really want to know what that was. I didn't really want to think about what I was doing. I just wanted to do it.

I turned my attention back to writing the perfect text. I decided to play it cool. Playing it cool allowed me to both lure Wallace and tell myself lies about how I wasn't doing anything improper.

[Me]: *Hi. I'm flattered. I hope it doesn't disappoint. You really want tickets?*

Then I waited, and I felt like a teenager, waiting by the phone for a call from a boy. Wow. That was a long time ago, another whole lifetime ago. My own kids were old enough to be doing the same thing I was.

But it felt good. I won't lie about that. The last eighteen years had been so lacking in excitement of this kind. Lacking in this particular kind of thrill.

When the phone buzzed against my chest I almost fell over a bench because I looked down to read it. I was walking down the campus parkway now, headed to class.

[WB]: *One ticket. The best seat in the house.*

And then:

[WB]: *You won't disappoint.*

A pang blossomed in my chest, spreading down through my body and right into my core.

It wasn't a love-dovey kind of feeling. No, I was too old for that, too realistic about what was really going here, even as I careened through the stratosphere with excitement. It was true that I was practically skipping down the parkway, and that it felt sunnier than it was and I was flying on my feet. I was enjoying the feeling of pretending like I was eighteen again and there were possibilities in my life.

But I knew it was just a feeling. An indulgence, a costume I was putting on, a role I was playing.

I also knew it was wrong to be doing it.

I just couldn't stop myself.

And I had plenty of excuses, thanks to Luke arranging the whole thing himself.

It took me a long time to write back to Wallace. This itself, I knew, was a sure sign that I was crossing even further into the grayness. Why would I care so much what I wrote back to him if I wasn't doing something a little over the line in my mind?

And let's get real. Wallace? He wasn't writing any innocent texts here.

The subtext was clear.

You won't disappoint.

That sent me straight to thinking about his hands moving down my body.

In the end, I typed my message. I sent it, and as quickly as it was gone my breath caught in my throat and I almost wanted it back. Almost.

I deleted the messages.

But it was out there, scrambling in space, coming back through the atmosphere in tiny pieces to be assembled in Wallace's phone, innuendo and all:

[Me]: *I'll try not to*

CHAPTER 7

Luke

Something was eating at me all afternoon, and all evening, though I couldn't say precisely what it was. Something about the way Wallace had taken Lisa's number, something about the conversation with Lisa.

Maybe I was just on edge because Lisa had become so twitterpated about Wallace coming to her play.

And that was what I wanted, wasn't it?

I wasn't sure.

When I fantasized about Lisa and Wallace, it was purely sexual. It was filthy and pornographic, and in that way it was a blunt-force, crushing betrayal. It burned through me as I thought of it, arousing and sickening in equal measure.

But when I thought of Lisa having another, different kind of relationship with Wallace – the kind where she got flustered and excited just talking about him – that hurt in a different way. It was not as pleasurable. In fact, I preferred not to even think about it.

But who the fuck did I think I was? And what did I expect to happen if I went around machinating this kind of thing? Did I really expect Lisa to just jump into my fantasy-world and let Wallace perform truly depraved sexual acts on her without her having any emotional involvement with him?

Well, yes, I did actually fantasize about it that way.

But realistically, that was not how it was going to happen.

I was setting my wife up, and then I had the audacity to get annoyed that she was doing what I believed I wanted her do – just not the right way.

I felt ill driving home.

I was glad Lisa wouldn't be home until seven. I wouldn't have been able to eat; my stomach was in knots.

I opted for exercise and took off on a run. I regretted the decision about halfway down the block. I was out-of-shape and heavier than the last time I'd run. My knees were getting crushed and I felt like my lungs were in a vice.

But I kept going, even as I felt all the tissue in my upper thigh shredding like a cheap taco. I'd be damned if I was going to have my wife

stolen by a fit black man. I'd get in shape. I needed to do that anyway.

I ran about five miles. After a while, the pain went away (either that, or I got desensitized to it and I was going to die any minute). I got into that pleasant state of exercise where your mind gets clear and dull at the same time. A perfect state of mind for thinking about my wife and Wallace, and what the hell I was doing.

And *that's* when I realized what it was that had bothered me.

*

"Oh!" Lisa said, looking me up and down. She took in the sweat and the puffing with a wary eye. I knew she was about to say something like "You okay?" but graciously changed it to: "Out for a run?"

I just looked at her. What the fuck else could I possibly be doing in this state of distress with running shoes on?

"That's great," she said cheerfully. "What brought that on?"

She chose that moment to peer into the grocery bag she had set on the table, like she didn't want to look me in the eye.

That was nice of her. Because she knew, like I did, that Wallace Brown was what brought this fit of exercise on, and it was embarrassing for both of us.

I exhaled. "Doctor's on my ass," I semi-lied. My doctor was not really the kind of guy to get on anyone's ass about anything, and I hadn't been for a check-up for three years.

Lisa took a bottle of wine out of the bag. "You interested in a bottle of red tonight?" she said.

I arched an eyebrow. "On a *weekday*?" I made a face, pretending to be scandalized. Lisa laughed.

"I know," she said. "It's perfectly sinful. But I can't help myself."

I patted my stomach. "Good thing I'm fit as a fiddle now."

Lisa gave another appreciative laugh.

Well, Wallace Brown might have been serious and good-looking and made all women's panties wet as he walked by, but could he make Lisa laugh like I could?

"I have to take a shower," I said. "Meet you back here?"

"Hmm," Lisa said. "I wonder if *I* should go running, too."

I raised my eyebrows.

“Well, you can’t be the only one in shape.”

We looked at each other.

I had to wonder if she was inspired to go running for me, or for Wallace. I shrugged. “It’s up to you sweetie. I think you look great, though.”

Lisa grinned. “Go take a shower. I might go really quick. You’re inspiring.”

She went to the room ahead of me, and I followed her, wondering what kind of woman I had married, and if I knew her at all. Her hair swung along her back; she was walking cheerfully. Nothing on her mind.

I was probably being paranoid. Of course I knew this. But now the idea had taken hold of me. The memory of the way Wallace had typed in Lisa’s number on his phone, the shifting of his eyes as he did it.

The quickness with which he had done it.

And Lisa’s strange, strange reaction to it.

Lisa turned and smiled at me, giving me a strange look. A look that meant, “What’s up?” I realized my face probably bore a slightly-psychotic expression, because I was thinking slightly psychotic thoughts.

I wiped my brow to indicate that I was just soooo exhausted from running, and Lisa made a face and then shrugged, turning to her dresser to get some workout clothes.

I went to the bathroom. I needed some private space to think.

I heard her leave.

I got the idea about five minutes into my shower. I wouldn’t ordinarily take such a long shower (unlike Lisa, who would spend the whole day in there if she could), but I figured my muscles were toast and it was probably a good idea.

I slammed the water off abruptly and walked through the bedroom, drying off as I went. I left a trail of wet footprints through the hall.

I flipped on the light in the kitchen and scanned the room.

It occurred to me in that moment that I wasn’t even sure what I was looking for. Sure, I wanted Lisa’s phone, but I didn’t know if I was looking for a handbag, or a purse, or a backpack. What did Lisa carry around with her?

There was a computer bag on a chair by the table. I unzipped it, going through the pockets quickly, my heart racing.

It wasn't just because I was spying on my wife, it was because, as I went through her belongings, I was starting to realize how distant we'd gotten. How she was living this other life I knew so little about. I pulled out her wallet – the last wallet I remembered her having was a somber mom purse; leather with practical pockets for all things and a magnetic protection sleeve for her credit cards. Now she had a silver, youthful looking, single-zipper wallet with all of her stuff crammed into it.

Forgetting my mission, I looked at all like it was the contents of a total stranger's purse. A loyalty card from a smoothie place, a ticket to a movie, a piece of candy, a student ID card, in which she looked as young as most of the kids on campus, if you asked me.

I sat down, half-wrapped in a towel, the ID card in my hand.

It was a weird thing, looking at her card. This was the same woman I had spent eighteen years with, and yet she looked like she had the first time I'd met her. Young, optimistic. Her whole future full of possibilities. Possibilities with men, careers, acting, travel.

I remembered the night I'd met her, she'd gone on and on about all the things she wanted to do with her life and see. She had talked so excitedly about her plans that for half the night I was sure she was on something, a half dose of ecstasy or *something*.

I felt a pang in my heart, looking at her picture. Here she was, beaming again, back in school again, just as optimistic as ever.

But now there weren't endless possibilities in her future.

Her phone buzzed, reminding me of what I was looking for. I stuffed the ID back into her wallet and crammed it into the bag, then searched for the buzzing phone. I was hoping it would say "Wallace" but it didn't. "Anna B" was calling.

I dismissed the call and then groaned with dismay as I got into her phone (no password, no lock) with ease. I scanned through her messages.

My heart fell. Nothing yet from Wallace.

I started to slide the phone back into her bag.

And then, almost without knowing why, all the interlocking pieces of things that had bothered me lately coming together in my mind, I slowly pulled it back out.

My fingers swept to her contacts.

And there it was.

"WB"

Wallace Brown.

I stared for a moment at the screen, trying to make sense of what I was seeing.

It was what I wanted, wasn't it? To catch her in a lie of some kind? But what kind of lie was this? Even as the cold pain of jealousy seeped through my torso and my ears rang with adrenaline, I realized I wasn't really looking at anything.

But how did she have Wallace's number if he'd never sent her a text? Of course.

Of course. They had exchanged numbers at the barbecue. Wallace already had her number when I offered to give it to him. That's why he had tapped on his phone in such a peculiar manner: he already had it.

It occurred to me then, and I wasn't entirely sure if it was relief or disappointment, that "WB" might not be Wallace Brown.

Naturally, the coincidence would be extraordinary.

But here you have it.

I tapped on the contact to expand the number. While I was reading it – the area code was the same, then 424 -

"Hey there beautiful."

My heart felt like it actually stopped cold, as in frozen.

The voice was unmistakably Wallace's.

Hey there beautiful.

"Hello?"

I stared at the phone. Part of my mind was still working on committing the number to memory, for some inexplicable reason. 424-8313... I recited it, while the rest of my body remained as it was, frozen.

I jumped into action before Wallace said hello again. I dumped the phone into Lisa's bag and fled the room. My heart was pounding, but a clear, logical idea was making its way to my conscious mind: Wallace would think she had pocket-dialed him and eventually hang up.

I had the jitters. A feeling of guilt, and creepiness was coming over me, mixing in with the jealousy, mixing in with the rage. I was scrambling to sort out what had happened here, but at the same I was also trying to...

Trying to what?

I went back into the shower, because I felt like it might calm me down.

I felt like not getting caught.

Or rather, I felt like not catching Lisa.

And why the hell would that be?

I stuck my head under the stream of water while it was ice-cold. It gave me an immediate headache and a much-needed dose of clarity.

Lisa had lied to me. There wasn't really any other explanation than that.

Okay, maybe she hadn't *outright* lied, I reminded myself. But she had definitely obfuscated the truth. Taken Wallace's number and let me believe she didn't have it.

And Wallace. That fucker. He was really coming in hard. Who called another man's wife "beautiful" as a nickname?

Did that mean something was already up? How would Lisa have reacted to that?

I put my hand on the wall and pushed water away from my mouth and eyes with the other hand.

What would Lisa have done if Wallace had answered the phone that way when she called?

I found I was getting an erection thinking about it. Thinking about her answering the phone and hearing him say that, and her heart beating faster, her pussy welling up with sticky desire.

"You're still in here?"

I gave a start. Lisa was standing in the doorway. She had stripped down already, except for a sports bra she was peeling off her skin. "That's the longest shower I think I've ever seen you take."

She opened the shower door and looked me up and down, her eyes pausing for a moment on my erection. The gaze of her eyes made me flex; it was incredibly arousing to see her linger on my erection, the erection borne of my discovery that Wallace Brown answered her calls by saying "Hey there, beautiful."

She lifted her gaze to meet my eyes, and gave me a strange smile.

Then, before I could even think about what was happening, she leaned forward, and grasped my cock in her hands.

I was taken by surprise, but because I was so worked up already, she had no way of knowing that. She seemed to almost expect that my cock would be hard, and she moved her hands over it as though she was exploring it, feeling around in new territory...

My cock flexed. My mind had leaped from that thought to the thought of Lisa doing this very same thing with Wallace. In the real world, in our shower, she was looking down at my cock now, her teeth denting her lower lip slightly, her hands making smooth motions over the length of my shaft, slipping through the water. She was using both of her hands to grip me, and she squeezed back when the muscles of my cock tensed with every dirty thought I had of her with Wallace.

Because this is surely how it would be, wouldn't it? Lisa, admiring the fat, dark length of his prick, biting her lower lip, savoring the heavy feel of him in her hands before she...

I sucked in my breath as Lisa slid down, pushing me back slightly to get me into the shower and accommodate her own body kneeling on the floor. She was still gripping my cock with one hand, and she brought it to her lips with the other. She looked up briefly at me, with a strange little smile on her lips as she moved the crown of my cock over her partly-open mouth.

Then she dropped her eyes, and started to explore my cock with her tongue.

The wet blade flicked out to the crown and made a wide circle around the dent in the center, where I could see a pearly drop of precum oozing out. Her pink tongue swept it away and inside of her mouth, before circling again, slimier now, in wider and wider circles until she was running the tip of her tongue in a feathery graze along the side of my cock.

I pictured her doing this same thing for Wallace, and again my muscle tensed in her hand. She smiled as she tipped her head to run her tongue along the underside of my shaft. I sucked in my breath when I felt her tongue flat against the skin of my scrotum working its way into the sensitive crevice between my balls, back around the base of my shaft, and back up.

A new pearl of cum had percolated onto the head of my shaft, and Lisa rubbed it over her lips, smearing it over them like lip gloss.

Then she looked up at me again, and ran her tongue over her lips to clean it off.

I felt her hand around my cock starting to move. She opened her mouth, her eyes still on me, and pulled my cock toward her, into her mouth. I steadied myself on the wall, my blood raging, trying to fight back the climax that was rushing up inside of me. It was being propelled by my

imagination, the image of Wallace's cock inside Lisa's mouth, her eyes on his the same way they were on mine just then I was wondering if Lisa, who hardly ever sucked my cock anymore, was imagining the same thing: that the dick she was exploring with her tongue and opening her throat for was not mine, but his.

Maybe she was even using mine to practice for his.

I put my hand down to her head at that moment, to warn her that I was very near coming. But instead of continuing to look at me, or pulling away, Lisa lowered her eyes and leaned forward, swallowing even more of my cock.

I felt the crown of my dick against the soft back of her throat, and she kept going. Her muscles spasmed with a slight gag, and it rippled through to my own flesh as an erotic massage. I found myself wanting to dominate her suddenly, to press her head forward and get her lips all the way to the base of my cock.

But she was already going there – she released her hand and brought her lips all the way to the very base of my dick.

I knew I was going over the edge soon, and I tried very hard to contain the orgasm that was spilling over inside of me to enjoy more of the blowjob she began to give me then: she bobbed her head back and forth and sucked on my cock at the same time. But this only served to drive me further over the edge, and my mind was my own worst enemy.

Probably, a filthy voice whispered in my ear, she's just practicing for Wallace.

It was hard not to believe that voice, too, because when I came, Lisa did not do the usual thing she did and pull away from me; instead she pushed forward, and my seed overflowed into her throat. She swallowed my cum, and she wound her tongue in semi-circles as she released me, licking up every last drop from my meat.

I stared at my wife as she rose to standing on the floor of the shower.

It was as if another woman had entered her body. Even when we were younger, we had never really had a very adventurous sex life. There had never been any time for it really. Lisa had gotten pregnant, we guessed, like the third time we had sex. And then suddenly it was all about being grown-ups and accepting our fate. It had sort of killed any kinky vibe that might have gotten going (along with any alcohol consumption to lubricate it).

So I could firmly say that Lisa had never dropped to her knees unexpectedly – least of all in the shower, which she considered a *highly dangerous* location for sex – and given me a blowjob. Out of nowhere.

And certainly not one like that.

I was too stunned to speak.

She smiled at me.

“Finish your shower,” she said. “But I’ll be waiting. You owe me one.”

Lisa was looking right into my eyes when she said that, but I could have sworn that her gaze somehow seemed distant. A little like when she was rehearsing lines, thinking two or three lines ahead, memorizing instead of feeling the moment.

Doing two things at once: moving her body in one plane and her mind in another, completely different space.

She slinked out of the shower and into the bedroom, and I turned to face the white tiles of the shower with my mouth hanging open. I steadied myself again, leaning on the tiles.

Was she thinking of Wallace?

My cock responded by swelling a little, twitching back to life.

I washed my face and left the shower, almost forgetting to turn it off.

CHAPTER 8

Lisa

I knew that what I was doing was *technically* wrong.

But only technically.

Also, I couldn't really stop myself from doing it.

The guilt felt bad, and it was definitely in there, lurking around and popping into my thoughts every now and then. But guilt was like a cough – when it came to sex it would just disappear for the time being.

Which is exactly what happened. I should have felt guiltier than I did for giving Luke the kind of blowjob I didn't think I'd ever given in my life. Not even drunk, back when I was twenty, not ever. Sure, it was my *husband* I was blowing, but I was thinking about *Wallace* the whole time. Thinking about what it would be like, after so many years having sex with the same partner, to suck on another man's cock.

And then, with my eyes closed, I started to imagine that my tongue was traveling over new territory. Tasting a different bead of pre-cum, feeling a different thread of veins along the shaft. I imagined it until I almost believed that I was doing it. I imagined taking Wallace into my mouth, imagined him grabbing the back of my head and pushing himself inside of me. And when I imagined that, I imagined him *taking* me, making me take his whole cock in my mouth, not letting me get away with sucking him partially off and then giving him a hand job.

And my mouth started to water, and then I went further than I ever had before. And I had this thought – a terrible thought – that maybe, someday, I would actually suck on Wallace's cock, and if I did, I wanted to get the whole thing in my mouth. I'd want to swallow his cum.

When Luke put his hand on the back of my head, I was so deep in my imagination that it felt like Wallace's heavy grip, and I pushed myself forward on his cock until I gagged, imagining the whole time that Wallace was gripping my hair and pushing me down on him. Down until he came inside my mouth.

By then I was good and worked up, and I'd had no release. I went into the bedroom and got onto the bed, but I rolled over and onto my hands and knees before Luke came out of the bathroom.

I looked over my shoulder. He was surprised when he saw me, but I was too deep in my own world and my own imagination to really care. I slid my fingers under my torso and up into my pussy, and I played with myself while Luke watched.

But really, I was thinking about Wallace. Performing, in some weird way, for him.

Luke stepped forward, staring at my fingers, and it felt so good to be finally reeling him in like that. To be doing something different, naughty... making him hungry for more. His cock was twitching back to life.

He moved closer to me and I turned forward, gyrating my hips. I closed my eyes, and when I felt his hands on my hips I thought of Wallace's hands. They would be bigger, stronger. How big was his cock? How much would he fill me?

Luke pressed the head of his cock to my pussy, climbing onto the bed to line up behind me. And as he slid into me, I had an entirely different image going on in my mind: the image from his porno, an image of me, doing this exact same thing – but with another man.

With Wallace.

The idea of feeling someone different inside of me made me wild. I was already worked up from the blowjob I'd given Luke (shamelessly, thinking of Wallace), so it was just a matter of minutes before I was careening spectacularly over the edge of another climax.

And just like before, with this new idea, these new elements in my mind: the orgasm was mindblowing. It rocked me from head to toe. I felt my knees get weak and I fell forward onto the bed. Luke kept pounding away at me until he came, but I was miles away. By the time I felt him thrust deep inside of me and come, my orgasm was fading and guilt was creeping in like a rising flood.

I stared at the headboard with my fingers to my lips as Luke pounded his cum into me.

Who was I? What kind of person had I become? What was I even doing or thinking about?

When he finished I had a desire to go immediately into the shower, less because I wanted to get rid of Luke and more because I just wanted to be alone, to cleanse my mind as much as I wanted to cleanse my body. What I was doing was wrong.

So wrong.

Wasn't it?

Luke collapsed on the bed and I curled up next to him, lying on his chest. I bit my fingernail. Luke was talking to me, but I didn't really hear what he was saying. I traced my fingers over his chest absentmindedly.

"yeah," I heard myself saying, without knowing what I was agreeing to.

Luke looked down at me, and it was clear my answer had been inappropriate.

I rubbed my face. "I'm sorry," I said, feeling guiltier with each word that came out of my mouth. "I'm just so out of it... after that."

Luke kissed me. I got up and headed to the shower. "I think I need a shower to clear my head," I said.

I turned the water on extra-hot, hoping I could steam my thoughts away.

But they were still there, plaguing me.

I wiped Luke's shaving mirror clean.

"You haven't done anything," I whispered to myself.

And I hadn't – yet.

But it almost felt as though I already had.

But would I? Was I capable of such a thing?

The idea of hurting Luke like that packed a punch to my gut. I let the steam take over the mirror and then I leaned my head back into the water to wash my hair. The stream was scalding hot and I cursed it and myself.

I needed to get a grip.

CHAPTER 9

Luke

I wish that I could say that I stopped digging into Lisa's business from that point on, but the truth is far from it. Far, far from it.

After we had that sexual encounter, I convinced myself that Lisa was thinking of Wallace all the time. His voice answering the phone kept ringing in my head, all day long, waking me up from a sound sleep:

Hey beautiful.

And there was something that bothered me, something nagging me in the back of my mind about his phone number.

So, I did what I think any man would do, even if he wouldn't admit it. I kept getting into her phone when she wasn't looking. And then I did something really, really terrible.

*

Lisa looked distracted as she came into the kitchen fifteen minutes after I did it, toweling her hair. Her face was screwed up into a frown.

A delightful feeling raked through me. I honestly hadn't expected her to notice so early. That she had meant she checked her phone more than I thought she had. Was it possible she was checking it more often now? Because Wallace messaged her in the early morning?

Hey beautiful. I woke up with a hard cock and I was thinking of you.

Lisa opened a drawer and a pang of guilt seized my chest. I shook out the community paper we could not get them to stop delivering to our doorstep and held it up, feigning total lack of interest in what she was doing.

I heard more drawers opening and closing. The roll of them licked at my insides, making me feel terrible.

It's *wrong*, after all, to take your wife's phone.

Even more so because you want to read her messages.

Even more so if you were actually hoping, as I was, to find her sending messages to one Wallace Brown.

"Huh," I heard her say.

I lowered the paper and tried to sound natural.

I'm not a great liar. "Something wrong?"

Lisa did not seem to notice how false I sounded. She was chewing on her thumbnail. "Shoot," she said. "Can't find my phone."

She hurried out of the kitchen.

I was left in there alone, pondering what I would have done if Lisa had *actually* lost her phone and I had nothing to do with it.

I was discovering, along the way in this adventure, that I was kind of an asshole.

The truth is, what I would ordinarily do in this situation is mumble, "Uh, that sucks. Hope you find it," and head for work.

It was the kind of thing I would have done unthinkingly, and even though it made me cringe, I knew it was exactly what I would have done. But now that I was thinking about it, I felt like a dick.

Still. I had to make it look authentic, or Lisa might figure me out.

The idea of having to admit not only to swiping her phone, but explaining *why* I had done that, gave me the courage to stand up and get my briefcase.

"Babe," I called down the hallway. "I gotta run. Hope you find your phone."

"Yeah, I will, it's probably just somewhere stupid," Lisa called back.

Then she came down the hallway, jogging lightly. She kissed me on the cheek. "Have a good day at work," she said.

And she went back to looking for her phone.

I went to the car, holding my briefcase, her phone tucked away inside.

I'm not proud of it.

I had even turned down the volume.

"Try calling it," I called out, at the last minute.

"Good one," Lisa said. "See you tonight."

I left, before I got myself into trouble.

*

I put Lisa's phone on my desk and surveyed it all day. It was mostly a disappointment, which I told myself I should have realized would be the case. A call from home. Another call from home. Lisa looking desperately for her phone. A message from a friend about a homework assignment.

I felt like an ass.

And then, I hit paydirt.

I had set the phone on “vibrate” and had lost interest in it, so when it rattled loudly on my Formica tabletop, I jumped slightly. I leaned away from my screen to look at her phone.

The letters “WB” sent a knife through my heart.

I swiped the app open.

[WB]: *don't worry*

and then, moments later:

[WB]: *it's better anyway. I have some time after if you want to go for a drink*

My whole body went cold.

Just what the hell did that mean?

And then there was this other thing: there were no messages from “WB” before that one.

Which meant only one thing: Lisa was deleting them.

And that meant only one thing. There was something so terrible in those messages that she had to delete them so they couldn't be read by anyone.

Anyone being me.

I sat back in my chair, and the reality of what I was seeing on Lisa's phone felt like it was punching me in the face.

And the balls.

Was my wife cheating on me?

Was my wife actually fucking cheating on me? With Wallace Brown?

A tide of blood-red rage seemed to fill my head. It was practically like being a cartoon. I could feel it rising inside of my mind like a liquid, glug glug glug, until my right eye actually felt like it was burning.

Was I going to sit here and stroke out over this?

I set the phone down.

I stood up.

I pushed my chair in.

In my mind, I stormed out of my cubicle-office (piece of shit “office,” joke of an office), into Wallace Brown’s big luxurious office, real office, and I turned his desk over, told him to fuck off, and threw my tie out the window on my way home. There, I found my wife and told her to fuck off, threw her phone at her, called her a cheating whore, grabbed two beers from the fridge, opened them, and chugged them on the freeway on my way out of town.

What the fuck had I been working at this piece of shit job all this time for? At this marriage, at supporting these kids? Slogging away, just so that everyone else could be happy, and then this smooth-talking black bastard comes along, fucks my wife, fires me from my job, and ruins my life?

I was heaving, my fingers digging into the back of my chair, when I heard a knock on the door and the cheap shitty thing rolled open.

Tom Michael Ryerson, the fucking asshole. He looked me up and down, and his expression changed.

“Jesus man. You having a heart attack or something?”

Was I? Was I actually having a fucking heart attack?

I looked at the phone.

I wasn’t going to go home and tell Lisa to fuck off, I realized.

I wasn’t even going to march out of here, overturned desk or no.

I pulled my chair out and sat down in it, feeling like I’d just run a mile all of a sudden. “I think I got food poisoning,” I said, flipping some papers listlessly around on my desk. “What do you need, man?”

Yep. That was me. Fucking Loyal Luke, the Middle-Management Guy. The guy who got a cubicle with tall walls instead of an office. The guy whose wife got seduced by hot black men with real careers. The guy who claimed to have indigestion when all this happened to him.

“I... uh...” Tom waved some papers around. “You know, it isn’t... a big deal. I’ll just... come back...”

“Great,” I said, and reached over to slam the door shut on him.

I stood up again, gripped the chair, and stared down at my desk.

I wish I could report that I just left.

But I sent out a responsible email telling everyone I felt sick before I did.

CHAPTER 10

Lisa

The responsible thing to have done, or maybe better stated, the *most faithful* thing to have done, would have been to not have responded to Wallace. To not have engaged in the conversation at all.

After all, no one was five years old here. He knew what he was doing, and I knew what he was doing: guys you haven't seen for almost twenty years don't just start sending you friendly texts because they want to have some totally platonic re-connection.

And married women like me don't start answering them unless there's an element of wanting to flirt with danger.

It was hard to explain, even to myself, what it was that I was doing. I felt bad for every single text I answered. But I started checking my phone compulsively, getting a little rush of adrenaline and pleasure each time it buzzed against my thigh or from inside my computer bag. I started being one of those awful students who slipped my phone out and looked at it under a desk, and the instructors in my classes glared at me and added to my shame.

I was acting like a freshman.

In high school.

They were all banal texts, I told myself. There was nothing explicitly sexual about them; far from it, in fact. Wallace started it by sending me a picture of something disgusting he got in the cafeteria, and I sent him a picture of something equally gross. Silly questions, little statements. They were not affectionate, they were entirely clean.

But I knew there was more to them than that. I knew because they gave me a thrill, I knew because I waited for them with excitement. And I knew, in the back of my mind, that this was all just an elaborate game of foreplay. Certainly, I was going to stop it before it turned into anything else... but I kept going, a little further every time.

And I deleted the texts, which only heaped guilt on what I was doing, and made it impossible to deny to myself that I felt guilty about what I was doing.

Innocent texts don't need to be constantly, immediately deleted.

Just in case someone sees them.

A practice I was certainly glad I'd engaged in the day I lost my phone.

It sent a panic through me at first, because I imagined Luke finding it as it buzzed, seeing a text from Wallace, and then having to explain myself. The thought was so scary that I decided, after he thankfully left for work without finding it, that I needed to stop texting Wallace that day. I would put an end to all this, and I would have to suck it up and do it officially.

I spent the morning composing the text in my mind:

I think I need to stop texting you, I would write.

I imagined what Wallace would say, and how I would respond. I ended up playing defense for myself,. I created responses from Wallace that excused my behavior, arguments in favor of our “platonic” texting relationship.

Excuses for what I was doing.

And then, as the day wore on and I didn't find my phone, I found myself in a panic. I tried to tell myself it was good: it was good that I'd lost it, good that it would seem like I was ignoring him. It was a good excuse to give to Wallace when he came to my play (“I lost my phone,”) and it forced me into closure.

But all day long I just wanted it back. I had sent him a new date for the play, because I'd gotten better tickets (and, secretly, secretly, I wanted him to come on a night there was no chance that Luke would be there.) Lies, deception, bad wife... I knew it. It wasn't going to go any further than that.

But I was dying to know if he'd gotten the message,
Dying to know if he was going to come.

Dying to hear from him again, feel that little flutter when he sent me a text. It felt good to have something exciting, something that gave me a rush. That's all I was doing.

Really.

The day wore on and I discovered how much I depended on my phone. I knew it had to be at home, I just hadn't had time to tear it apart. I tore apart the car on a break between classes, even though I knew it had to be somewhere at home because I had sent Wallace a message last night. And then I had hidden it under my computer bag on a dresser, very deliberately, the sound off so it wouldn't make Luke suspicious.

I hadn't misplaced it. When you're flirting with someone, like I was, the location of your phone is burned into your mind. It was all I could do not to call attention to myself by checking it.

I ditched the second half of a class to drive all the way home to look for it in the afternoon. I started to tear the house apart, and I think I realized what had happened somewhere in the middle of my search. I mean, there wasn't any other explanation. But I didn't want to face the truth.

And then, suddenly, Luke was there.

I was in the living room, lifting up piles of magazines and then dropping them, then lifting them again. I was muttering, “where are you? Where the heck are you?” and so caught up in what I was doing that I didn't even hear Luke come home. I don't know how long he was standing there. It could have been minutes. But when I turned around and saw him I shouted and clutched my chest. “Jesus!” I yelled.

My face burned. It was obvious that Luke had been standing there a while, watching me.

And something in his expression told me that he knew what I was doing.

And then there was the fact that he was home at that hour. That I was home at that hour.

All of it was very unusual, and Luke's face told me that it was no coincidence.

Like I said, I already sort of knew in the back of my mind what had happened, so it wasn't shocking when Luke extended his hand and my phone was in it.

“Looking for this?” he said, his voice dry, his expression icy.

I stared at my phone in Luke's hand. My face turned hot, and my stomach felt like it dropped through me to the floor. I had been caught, and the full naughtiness of what I had done was crashing down around me.

You haven't done anything, I reminded myself.

But the jig was up, and I knew it. Whatever I had been telling myself – that I hadn't done anything, not really, that I wasn't going to do anything, not really, that I had only switched the dates for Wallace to come because I couldn't get tickets – the truth was obvious now. Red-hot and obvious, creeping all over my skin.

I had fucked up.

I felt tears welling up in my eyes. I shook my head; it was all I could do. I knew Luke had looked at my messages. There was no point in making everything worse by pretending I didn't know why he looked the way he did.

"So what's the deal with you and Wallace?" he said. His voice was calm, but there was an underlying tone to it that seemed a little dangerous.

"There's no deal," I said, suddenly feeling defensive. I reached forward and snatched my phone from his hand. "You're the one who gave him my number."

I knew I was saying the wrong things, taking this in a bad direction, but I really had nothing to say for myself. In that moment, confronted with the awful possibility that Luke thought I had betrayed him, I just wanted to deny it, or make it his fault instead of mine.

Luke pressed his lips together. "Now Lisa," he said. "You know that's not true."

I looked down at the phone and swiped at the screen, pawing through apps, seeing nothing. "No," I admitted. "It isn't. He gave it to me at the barbecue. But you gave it to him later, and you didn't know that."

"What are you playing at, Lisa?"

I looked up at him sharply. "What are *you* playing at?"

And then, my mind filled with all the curious facts that might somehow absolve me of at least of the guilt for this situation. The porn with the black man fucking the white woman. The fact that Luke *had* given my number to Wallace, and suggested he go to the play.

"It's almost like you're setting me up, here," I said.

I didn't really mean it; it was a desperate, last-ditch effort to pawn some of the guilt about my thoughts (and my text-messaging actions) off on Luke.

So I was surprised when his expression changed from confrontational to something... well, a little more like mine.

Contrite?

He shrugged.

We were silent for a moment.

"Just tell me something," he said. "Do you want to have an affair with this guy? IS that what you were thinking of doing? Or have you already done it?"

“No!” I said sharply. Then I softened my voice, and I sighed. I looked up at the ceiling.

Might as well just plunge in.

“No, I didn’t already. And... no, no I wasn’t... I wasn’t planning on it. Not seriously.” I started to pick up speed while I was talking. “I was just sort of... playing around with it, playing around with the idea. Walking close to it. But I wouldn’t have actually done it.”

“But you wanted to,” Luke said.

I cocked my head. His tone was strange. Almost like he was prodding me to say that, almost like he wanted me to agree with it.

I shook my head.

“I don’t know,” I said, finally. “Not really, okay? I just... it was just something I thought about. Thought about like, thought about, in my head, as a fantasy. Not thought about doing.”

As I said all this, I realized it was really true. I never would have gone through with it.

Would I have?

Now that I was being confronted by Luke, I guessed that I might not have. I wouldn’t have risked our marriage for something this fantastical.

Luke hadn’t said anything for a long time, and I was looking at my shoes. I looked up at him, half-expecting him to be angry, or sad, or both. How could I get him to believe me? I supposed there was only his faith in me, and he probably didn’t have that any more.

But what had I really done? Just exchanged pretty neutral texts with Wallace, all of which I’d deleted...

I narrowed my eyebrows. What was he asking me about anyway?

I folded my arms. “Look, nothing happened between us.”

“But you wanted it to.”

So that was it.

I was suddenly a little bit angry.

Well, a lot angry. It was like a volcano I had condensed into a tiny ball deep, deep inside of me exploded. I opened my mouth and what came out of it was surprising even to me.

“Yes. Yes, okay? Yes, I wanted to! What - you’ve never thought about *anyone* else or anything else in our whole fucking marriage? I never got a chance to do anything, I never got a chance to go anywhere or be anything or try to have another life or another lover or any of the things I wanted to

do. And you know what? All this time, all this time I thought, oh, well, I should just be grateful that I have Luke, that he stood by me, and that's true. It's true all the way. But all this time I thought I didn't have a right to think about how *my* life got smushed up into this small little space, just as much as yours did. Because it was always like, 'oh, I'm the one who *got* pregnant,' like it was *my* fault, and you just did some noble thing, so whatever I lost didn't matter. But I didn't get to finish school, I didn't get to be an actress, I didn't get to do anything either."

All this stuff was coming out of my mouth, and it was awful, and I could see it was just pummeling Luke. But I couldn't stop.

"All these years, listening to you, listening to you..." I wiped angry tears away from my eyes, "listening to you go on and on about your job, how much you hate it, and I just sat there, feeling guilty. But you know what, that's bullshit. That's bullshit because... this was just as much your fault as it was mine. And I had things I wanted to do. And... and... Wallace doesn't have anything to do with any of that." I sat down on the floor, cross-legged, and put my face in my hands. "I don't even know what the hell I'm saying."

There was an awful silence.

"I love you," I said. "And I love our family. And I wouldn't take any of it back. Ever. I wouldn't even... you know... risk it. I just... I just wanted to... I don't know. *Pretend*. Just be close to having something, I don't know, a chance to do something I would have done when I was young. If things... were different."

A sob escaped me.

Man, what a meltdown. I wiped my eyes with the back of my hand. This was going to take forever to clean up, and I didn't feel like dealing with it. Everything I'd said was true, but it would probably have been better left unsaid. Now Luke was going to get defensive, and we'd end up talking all night or all morning. But I just wanted to go to bed, take it all back, move on with our lives.

At the end of the day, even though everything I had said was true, it didn't mean I didn't love Luke. Or that I wanted to change anything. Really, I had just wanted to get it off my chest.

And I had just wanted to have a little fun.

Now he was going to take it all wrong.

But Luke surprised me by sitting down on the floor across from me. I felt his hands take mine and peel them away from my face.

“Hey,” he said, and his voice was gentle.

I looked up at him. His expression surprised me.

He looked down at the floor. “You know something?” he said quietly.

“I just never thought about it like that before. You know?”

I sniffed. “What?” I said.

Because holy heck, did *that* take me by surprise.

CHAPTER 11

Luke

So Lisa stood there in the living room, and all of this stuff started pouring out of her mouth. Literally *pouring*, an actual deluge. And at first it felt like getting gasoline poured all over me. I was going to go up in flames. She was bawling, I was getting hot under my actual collar, and Wallace Brown was looming over all of it.

So for the first half of her rant, I was just preparing what I would say back to her. Especially when she got to that bit about me complaining about my job.

I don't know exactly what it was that she said, but it was like the world turned inside out in an instant, and I was through the looking glass. A paradigm shift.

It had honestly – honestly – never even occurred to me to think of everything that Lisa had to give up. I mean sure, in passing. I gave it some thought, the way you give it some thought to say “How's it going?” to someone in the elevator.

But I really had always thought of everything exactly the way she described it: ultimately kind of *her* fault. She *got* pregnant.

And I had dutifully stood by her. Worked this stupid job.

She was right: it wasn't really fair to think of things that way, was it? Lisa had dreams, Lisa had a life. I had been the one to knock her up, after all. It took two to tango.

I had just never given it any real thought. Lisa had thrown herself into the role of loving mother, loving wife, with such gusto. I had just never thought for a moment that maybe she had wanted other things from her life.

Whereas, it was clear, Lisa had given a lot of thought to what I had done, how much I had wanted other things.

Then she fell down to the floor and started crying.

I sat down next to her.

And I found myself being a little bit less of a dick than I might have been five minutes before.

“You know something?” I said. “I just never thought about it like that before. You know?”

Lisa's expression was shocked and grateful.

She wiped her nose. Then she looked at the floor. "I think we need some wine," she said.

So she hopped up and got it, and I got the glasses, and we sat back down on the floor. We started talking about all the stuff we never talked about. All the things we had given up, all the stupid things we did as young parents. We walked to the liquor store at the end of the street, arm in arm, laughing (Lisa was still crying a little) and bought two more bottles of wine. Lisa bought some cigarettes and shook her head at me when I looked at her. "I smoke sometimes. Like every two years. Don't bug me about it," she sniffed.

It got dark in the living room. We sat on the floor again – I don't know why. It just seemed like the right thing to do. Lisa lit a candle and a cigarette.

She took a drag. There was lull in the conversation.

"I'm going to tell you the truth," she said suddenly. "I didn't really love you when we first got married."

We had each had a bottle of wine apiece, so this hit me in the face but in a sort of dull way.

And then I found myself laughing.

"Yeah," I said. "I don't think I did, either."

Lisa laughed, keeling over onto her legs. "I liked you," she said, laughing and crying at the same time. "But I didn't love you until later." She put her hand out on my arm. "That feels so good to admit," she said.

I nodded.

"But I love you now," she said quietly, suddenly serious. She took a drag of her cigarette.

I loved Lisa, deeply and without any reservation, I realized in that moment. Whether she wanted to fuck Wallace Brown or not. It seemed sort of irrelevant, given how long our marriage had lasted and everything we'd done.

But it also filled me with joy to hear her say that she loved me.

"This thing with Wallace," she said, "It was just a fantasy. Just a..." she waved her hand in the air. "Nothing else."

"A fantasy, huh?" I said.

"Really. Promise. I don't think I'd have had the guts to do it."

I took another sip of wine. I was going to feel terrible tomorrow. I stared at Lisa, who was smoking like a pro. How had I never found out about that?

Then I found myself blurting out:

“It kind of turned me on, anyway.”

I looked at my fingers when I said this. I was lying on my side.

Lisa leaned backward, and I looked up at her. She had a funny sort of smile on her face. “Okay,” she said, taking a deep breath. “Let’s just tell all tonight. I, um... I kind of knew that.”

“What?” I said. I sat up to pour her some more wine. I was shocked but I was so drunk it was taking a while for my body to react.

“Okay, don’t get mad,” she said. She leaned forward on her legs. “I totally caught you watching some porn.”

“What?” I said. Then I laughed. It was funny, after all. Everything was sort of funny, and I was still on a high from Lisa’s most honest, most tender profession of love ever. “When was this?”

“Like two weeks ago. You remember...um, when I came home and we, uh, had that really hot sex?”

I did.

“Damn,” I said.

Lisa leaned back again. She put her cigarette out.

“But you don’t *actually*,” she said, after a long silence filled the room.

“Actually what?” I said, playing with the corkscrew. “Actually want you to sleep with another man?”

“Right,” she said. Then: “Right?”

But both of our voices were leading. Open-ended in tone.

I looked down at my fingers.

“Since we’re telling all tonight,” I said. “Then I might as well tell you... I’ve given it some serious thought.”

Lisa spit out her wine. “Seriously?!” Then she laughed. “Oh, okay, I get it.”

Like it was a joke.

I almost let her believe that, because it was the easiest thing to do. But we were so drunk, in such a soul-bearing mood, and I was starting to have a more intense feeling about it after this conversation.

I shrugged, and Lisa’s laughing mouth turned serious.

She opened and closed her mouth, and I saw her eyes glimmer.

“You can't be serious,” she said, finally.

I shrugged again. “Maybe I am, a little.”

Lisa made another funny noise. “Uh... you can't be just a 'little' serious about something like that. That's like... that's... serious.”

“People do it,” I said.

“I know,” Lisa said solemnly. She took another big swig of her wine.

I waited, watching her think. I could see that her mind was wandering away from the living room, away to the what-ifs.

I pushed myself up, groaning a little at a pain that had developed in my side from sitting so awkwardly. “I'm going to be really honest,” I said. “It's a big turn-on for me. And I can see that it is for you, too.”

Lisa's eyes came back into focus in the room with me. “Huh? Wha-”

“Just...” I held up my hand. “Just, before you deny it, let's just... concede that these are the facts. Okay? You're attracted to Wallace, and I have a fantasy about you with another man.”

“A black man,” Lisa added.

I shrugged again. “So... if you want to know what might have happened, and I want to know what could happen... then maybe we have a win-win here. Is all I'm saying.”

Lisa's jaw dropped open.

“But that's cheating,” she said, finally.

“Not exactly,” I said. “Not if we agree on it together.”

I could see my answer appealed to her. In fact, the idea itself so obviously appealed to her that it was making her skin glow. She let herself sink into a moment of indulgence in her fantasy.

But then, as was typical of Lisa, she came back to reality. Her “mom-face” took over.

“That would never work,” she said, and she gave a nervous laugh before pouring some wine down her throat.

“Why not?”

Lisa looked at me incredulously. “Why *not*? Why *not*?”

“Yeah. Why not?”

She lowered her chin and her eyes moved quickly as she searched mine. “You're serious.”

“Yeah,” I said. I was gaining momentum. Why not, indeed? The drunker I got and the more I pictured it... why not?

“Because... because of... jealousy, and... I don't know. It's just...wrong.”

I almost gave up hope.

“Right?” she asked.

I put my hand on her ankle and stroked it. Then I leaned down and kissed it. “Is it? I think it's only wrong if we think it's wrong, or we have secrets. But what if we say... you have an affair with Wallace as long as he's here? In town?”

Goosebumps traveled up Lisa's calf and she shivered visibly, from the word “affair” on.

I moved my mouth up her leg, enjoying the way her body was reacting. I knew it wasn't just the way I was kissing her – though it had been a long time since we'd done anything especially different in bed (at least, until Wallace appeared on the scene). And it had certainly been a long time since we'd had sex in the living room, or I'd taken the time to warm her up with kisses along her leg.

In the end though, I knew that she was turned on, mostly, by the idea of doing something illicit. By how close it was to being within her reach. And that excited me too.

“I can see you like the idea,” I murmured into the crook of her knee. She was wearing a flowered skirt and I pushed up to continue my journey up her leg. My hand traveled ahead of my mouth to find her panties and pull them down.

The scent of her excitement was powerful, sweet. I could tell by how strong it was that somewhere in the last few moments I had driven her wild, or her ideas of Wallace had blossomed in her imagination and made her pussy well up with tangy juices.

I slid my fingers into her soaked slit and wiggled her engorged clit. She squeezed her thighs together and gasped.

I rose to my knees and pushed her legs open. She dropped her wine glass and then pushed her hands between her legs, her mouth open, her sensitivity to my touch extreme. “Oh, Luke,” she said breathlessly.

“It's okay,” I said, pulling her by the ankles toward me, her skirt getting caught on the floor and riding up to above her waist. “It turns you on, thinking about Wallace. That's okay.”

Lisa's expression was one of helplessness as she leaned on her elbows until her head was away from the brick mantel.

I unzipped my pants and wriggled out of my boxers.

I reached down and put my hand on the back of her neck, bringing her face up to kiss me on the mouth. At the same time, I used my other hand to guide my cock to her drenched slit, and work the head into the folds of her pussy. She was hot and so slick that it felt like liquefied velvet over the head of my cock.

I played with her clit, rubbing the crown of my dick over it. Her button darted this way and that as I pressed against her, and her legs trembled in excitement against my outer thighs. I pulled on her hair to turn her face upward, and she gasped and closed her eyes.

"There we go," I said. "That's okay with me, if you want to think about Wallace's big, black cock inside of you. Is that what you think about?"

She didn't answer, just gyrated her hips and tried to push herself up and onto my cock.

It was difficult to resist, but I pulled my hips back a little, and tugged on her hair. "Is that what you're thinking about?" I repeated.

Lisa bit her lip. She nodded.

I teased her opening with my cock, burying just the crown in her pussy. "Tell me," I said. "I want to hear you say it."

Lisa's eyes opened in surprise, and her jaw dropped a little, but when she met my eyes she must have seen something about how much I need, or wanted, her to say the words.

"I'm thinking about his black cock in my pussy," she said, her voice deep and raspy.

I pushed into her, using all of my willpower not to fuck her senseless, and then I paused as she squirmed around my cock. Her pussy pulsed. I tugged gently on her hair to indicate I wanted more.

"I think about how much he would stretch me out," she said.

My cock throbbed inside of her at her words, and surprise registered on Lisa's face. There it was: the undeniable proof that I was serious when I said it turned me on.

To my delight, she seized upon this. "I think about sucking his cock," she said, and my cock flexed again. This made Lisa smile. "I thought about it while I was sucking your cock in the shower."

"Oh, fuck," I said. I couldn't stop the words from escaping my mouth.

“It turns me on,” Lisa continued. “I like thinking about him fucking me. I like thinking about his cock.”

I started pounding into her then, unable to control myself. She bucked against me, and I gripped her by her hips. We were staring into each other's eyes when we came, Lisa first, and then me. It was as intimate as we had been a long time, and yet somehow, at the same time, it was purely filthy and sexual. I hardly know how to explain it.

After panting for a bit, with Lisa still on my lap and my dick still inside of her, I seized her by the back of the head to kiss her violently. I realized it had been a long time since we had kissed at all – anything more than a perfunctory kiss on the cheek.

“I love you,” I whispered.

“I love you, too,” Lisa said.

And that, also, was a much more genuine “I love you” than we had exchanged in a long, long time.

CHAPTER 12

Lisa

I went shopping for a dress the next day. The dress, *the* dress. The dress I was going to cheat on my husband in.

I mean, with permission. But still.

Surreal.

I floated through the store. I had to check several times that I wasn't in a dream, because my mind felt as clouded as that.

Reflecting on it now, I'm not sure I really knew what was happening at the time. Or that I thought it was real. I was heading toward it, deliberately doing things to make it happen, but I didn't really believe I was going to follow through with it.

Not really.

Luke and I had made love that night, several more times – and “made love” was actually what I would call it, and I mean that. It wasn't the typical, stale, “get-it-done” kind of sex we'd been having for... gosh, years in our marriage.

There was that time by the fireplace, and that was wild. I came so hard it made me feel faint. But that time, it wasn't just the idea of Wallace – which definitely contributed to it – it was also Luke, Luke's cock throbbing inside of me when I told him my dirty fantasies. It turned him on, but like... *really* turned him on. And that drove me wilder than any private fantasy I could have had.

But after that, when we went to the bedroom, we made love in a different way. A way that was just about us, and all the dirt we'd shared, all the intimacy we'd rebuilt after all those years of being disconnected.

I felt good getting all that stuff off my chest. Better than good. Liberated.

And Luke's reaction had made me love him all the more.

Well... and then there was this. This thing with Wallace. Which I have to be honest, I couldn't quite believe. But in the morning, we talked about it again, lying in the bedroom together. I asked him if he really wanted me to go ahead with it, if he really meant it.

And he told me he thought it would make our marriage better and stronger. Look at how it already had, he said.

So, I remembered saying, *what's the plan?*

And then, there I was, in Nordstrom's, looking for a fancy, sexy dress for a date that was going to end with sex. With someone other than my husband.

At first, I got pretty overheated with stress. It was overwhelming in there. I hadn't looked for a dressy-dress in a million years. And I was 37 years old. So, you know.... some of the shiznit these ladies were wearing these days.

I pushed through endless frilly dresses, frowning. A woman came up behind me.

"Something for prom?" she said.

I turned around.

Woman. Girl, more like it.

Her face looked confused, then brightened, then soured again. "Er... or... are you... is it for?"

I looked around. Without even realizing what I was doing, I was in the junior's section.

I used what Luke calls my kooky voice. "Whoo," I exclaimed. "Having a little bit of an existential crisis there. Thought I was eighteen for a minute."

This made a terrible impression on the sales lady, who was probably twenty.

"I need a frumpier lady-dress," I said, making my voice as practical as possible.

I thought of adding: "Just kidding, I need a really hot dress for my date with a hot black man who is not my husband," but decided she might collapse.

She showed me to some really dowdy dresses.

"Oh..." I said. "Not, you know, literally old-lady dresses. I meant, like, still hot."

I wondered if these phone-swiping kids these days still said "hot."

"Oh, gotcha," she said. Evidently she knew what I meant, because before long I was among some risqué dresses for...well, women. All the sequins were gone.

That must be the hallmark of my age group, I thought.

I gathered about five and headed for the dressing room, where more despair awaited me.

In and out of dresses, I reflected on the pact Luke and I had made, and on the fact that I was actually standing in a dressing room, trying on dresses to see which one I would wear to commit adultery.

They all looked terrible.

Discouraged, I went to put the last one on. The lighting was awful and my skin was pale underneath it. The light wasn't doing me any favors, but I had to say, I wasn't looking all that bad, either.

And I must have still had it, or Wallace wouldn't be chasing me around.

I paused to turn sideways in my underwear. I only had to suck my stomach in a little to make it flat. Well... almost flat. But the roundness of it was not unseemly, like some women got. It was a smooth, small curve. My breasts were still pretty pert, and I still had a bottom, which I'd also noticed a lot of women my age seemed to have lost to a dull flatness.

"Lookin' good, Healy," I cracked to myself.

I almost didn't put the dress on, I had so little hope for it. But it was already tangled up in my arms so I thought, what the hay.

It looked awful at first, but then as I pulled and tugged the tight material into place, I had to admit it looked hot.

It was a halter top made of a thin nylon overlaid with lace flowers, so it looked like the lace just barely covered my breasts and crawled up and around my skin. There was a deep plunge in the center of my breasts, and it hooked up at the top with a vintage clasp.

The dress was black at the bottom and flare out a little. The reason I'd had no hope for it was because the material was an unforgiving satin. But somehow, miraculously, on my body, it looked sensual and did not bring out any unwanted curves.

I held up my phone and took a picture. I sent it to Luke, and then I looked at the price tag and gasped.

I typed a message right after:

[Me]: *never mind its like 700*

Luke had already replied.

[Luke]: *oh god. Its so hot, u look amazing get it*

I waited. I slowly started to slip the dress off and step out of it, My phone buzzed.

I stared at Luke's reply.

[Luke]: *just get it*

[Luke]: *and some shoes*

There was a long pause.

[Luke]: *and some new lingerie*

I stared at the phone, not really able to believe this was happening.

[Luke]: *actually, ill get the lingerie. You get shoes.*

An electric thrill went through me, and I felt myself getting that queasy, sea-sick excited low in my abdomen. It was unexpected: even as we were making plans for this adventure the night before, I had been thinking of it as a separate thing. An affair with Wallace, outside of my marriage. But now a new reality entered my mind: that it was something *inside* our marriage, that Luke was participating in. If he bought the lingerie, it was like he was in on it somehow. More than just an observer.

And it turned me on. It surprised me that it turned me on (if someone would have told me a week before that I'd be doing what I was doing and feeling what I was feeling that week, I'd have fallen off a chair laughing).

A new thrill was traveling through me now. I was excited to get a text, like before. But now I was just as excited -maybe even more so – if it came from Luke.

It felt kind of wrong, to be sure, to be enjoying having two guys on the hook, to be engaging in a sexual game with each of them, and for that game to be illicit in one way or another for each of them.

But it was giving me a high as well.

As for Wallace, I had felt a little bad when we came up with the plan. In the end, I think I wanted to believe that he was more interested in me as a

person than a sexual conquest. So when I started to text him deliberately, to lure him deliberately, I felt a pang of guilt. Like I was using him.

Luke had noticed. "What's wrong?" he had asked.

"I don't know," I said. "I feel bad. I mean, what if he's like... really only trying to be friendly. Or something?"

Luke had rolled his eyes, and of course I knew he was right: that was preposterous.

"Yeah," Luke said. "Look, Lisa, come on. You're married. You're hot. You're the one that got away. He's not texting you to have a new BFF. He's trying to get in your pants."

"I hardly ever wear pants."

This made Luke laugh. I liked the way we had something together to work on and be complicit in. It was renewing something that had been slowly lost over the years. First, we'd had the kids, and then we'd all slowly drifted into our own orbits. Coming back together, to make this plan, absurd as it was, was bringing our "marriage" back to life.

I laughed back at him. Luke was right, of course, but I still felt a little bit bad as I led Wallace on.

Bad... but I'll be honest:

It was also kind of fun.

I had composed my text to him with Luke's help. Luke had to go to a Quantum office in Jersey and stay overnight in the upcoming week. Wallace would of course know about this, so he would read exactly what we wanted him to read into the text I had sent him:

[Me]: *you wouldn't want to go for that drink this week maybe?
Like Thursday?*

If I had had any doubts that Wallace was just in it for the sex, they dissolved when he replied enthusiastically:

[WB]: *I'd be more than happy to keep you company that night
[WB]: dress up. We'll do something fancy*

So dressing up I was. My heart took another giant plunge when I handed the credit card over to the salesgirl, but once I had the dress in a box and was leaving the store, I was on a high again.

I spotted the shoes from a mile away: slinky, high-heeled black pumps. I went in, tried them on, and left without really ever thinking about the price.

It was like it was meant to be.

CHAPTER 13

Luke

The scene was surreal. Watching Lisa brush her hair in front of the mirror, trying on different styles. She twisted it up and pinned it with the expertise of someone who had done a lot of hairstyling, something I'd never noticed before or thought about. But of course she would have done it so many times, for so many plays.

It was strange that so many things I'd always *known* about Lisa were coming into stark relief because of this decision we'd made.

My stomach lurched when I thought of it: it seemed that we were really going to do this. Someone else – and not just anyone else, *Wallace* – was going to feel the unique contours of Lisa's body. Someone else would know what it was like to be inside of her, to have her all around him and to himself.

And what would Lisa think of that? Would she do what we had agreed, have her experience and get it out of her system? Or was it true, as they say, that once you go black you never go back? And why would she come back? Back to what?

I started to feel down again. Wallace was better looking, had a better (and far more secure at the moment) job, knew more about the things Lisa cared about, probably had a better dick and a better apartment. Our life with our kids had wrapped up; there was no reason for her to stay with me – except for me.

And I was risking our marriage, and Lisa's love, just to... what? Prove that?

I had a sudden urge to reach out and stop her, to tell her I didn't want to go through with this after all. To take it all back.

Lisa unscrewed a stick of lipstick and leaned forward toward the mirror to apply it. It was a deep red color. Her ass curved out as she leaned over and I admired the shape of her bottom, her lean legs. The line of her dress rode up slightly and revealed more of her thigh than I really would like anyone else to see...

I opened my mouth to say something, but my voice was caught in my throat.

Lisa leaned back and pressed her lips together. She gave a slight turn of her head to admire her up-do. Some kind of twist.

It was now or never, I thought. I felt like I should say something, but there was something gripping me inside, daring me not to break apart the daring plan we'd concocted.

"I think you should wear your hair down," I found myself saying.

Lisa turned to me, and met my eye. "Oh yeah?"

Her voice sounded small, almost child-like.

I nodded. "You nervous?" I said.

Lisa unpinned her hair and her golden locks fell to just above her shoulders, lending her the fifties femme-fatale look she so dominated. "Of course I am," she said. Then she looked at me in the mirror. "Are you still sure you want to do this?"

My gut felt as though I was getting impaled by an ice-cold pitchfork. "Sure," I said, managing to sound convincing.

Lisa turned her eyes back to her own reflection. "Okay," she said. "Well... I think I'm ready."

She stood back from the mirror. The black dress cut sharply between her breasts, showing off the best of her figure, the plumpest flesh of her breasts and the narrowness of her waist. She looked, in fact, not much older than she had when I had met her. Age had only done better things to her body and her face, making her more sophisticated, more pulled together. Even the change on the shape of her hips and the slight thickness of her waist were improvements to her once-gangly figure. She looked less like the tomboyish adolescent I had met, and more like a screen siren.

"You look beautiful," I said.

Lisa smiled, almost a hint of shyness in her grin.

I stood up and walked to stand behind her. I put my arm around her and viewed us together in the mirror.

Not bad, I thought. We looked like we had something. I almost looked like I deserved to have a woman like her. But I was plain where Lisa was stunning: I looked like an average, ordinary Joe. I would blend in anywhere. Lisa would not, especially not in this get-up.

So much more suitable to a man like Wallace, his rich chocolate skin encased in his stylish silk shirts.

I took Lisa's left hand in mine and brought it to my lips. I could feel that my kiss electrified her, and it was a gratifying sensation.

I twisted our wedding band – a simple, gold ring with a single diamond that I had actually bought five years after we got married because that's when I was able to afford it. I started to slide it off her finger. I did it without really thinking. A subconscious urge took over my hands, and the gesture was, I think, symbolic.

But Lisa brought her thumb to her knuckle and stopped me.

“Leave it on,” she said, meeting my eyes in the mirror.

I stared at her finger.

“I don't want to take it off,” she said, dropping her eyes to the floor. “I want something to... you know. Remind me of who I am.”

It's hard to explain the thrill her words gave me.

Maybe it would all be okay.

I kissed her on her earlobe. She blushed, and then she wriggled away. “Don't mess up my make-up,” she said. “And anyway, aren't you going to be late?”

I looked at the clock. “Shit,” I said. I tried to grab her, but she pushed me back and blew me a kiss, pointing at her lips. “Okay,” she said. “So...”

“Text me when you get back,” I said.

“We're really doing this,” Lisa said, half-question, half-statement.

I paused. Lisa's expression started to crumple.

“Yes. It's fine. We're really doing it. I love you.”

“I love you, too,” she said.

Then I hurried out to the car, almost leaving my suitcase by the door.

I called out to her as I popped back in the door. “Call me as soon as you're back,” I said.

To tell me all about it.

That was the agreement.

CHAPTER 14

Lisa

The night was so cool it was almost cold. It gave me a vague wave of nostalgia for when I arrived in the city for the Braylee Scholarship. I remembered noting the cold, feeling the excitement of the city. I had always lived in the suburbs. There was no vibe like that there, ever. No lights, no cold cement, no constant, excitement-filled wind blowing around.

But almost as soon as I felt that rush of nostalgia, I felt like a fish out of water. I stepped out of the cab and almost lost my balance: what was I doing?

The apartment building where Wallace lived seemed like a five-star hotel, but without the bustle. It was eerily silent inside. I tried not to gawk at the marble, the floor-to-ceiling mirrors, the chandeliers. It was all pretty ritzy.

But it felt cold, and it made me feel disoriented. I was unsteady as I approached the front desk and gave the man there my name. I caught my image in the mirror behind him as he looked something up on his computer. I felt a pang of deep embarrassment: I wondered if I looked like a prostitute to him. I wondered how many prostitutes came and went here – I mean, did that kind of thing even really happen?

I played with the band of my wedding ring, almost unconsciously. When the attendant looked up, I felt a stab of cold through my chest. He motioned me to the elevator, politely, and told me to go to the eighth floor. Had he seen me twisting my wedding band? Did I see a little smile crack on his lips because he knew the score?

My cheeks flushed as I walked across the lobby. My footsteps echoed loudly in the empty cavern of marble. I looked behind me and the attendant gave me a wane smile. I supposed there was no turning back at this point; the decisions had all been made.

The inside of the elevator was full of mirrors, so I had plenty of time to look at myself. I adjusted my black dress. I suddenly worried that I looked cheap; my lipstick too red, the cut in the dress too low. I was trying

too hard. The heels felt uncomfortable, like I was going to fall out of them. This wasn't me.

I quickly reached out and pressed “7” before the elevator made it to the eighth floor. The ding was loud and I almost jumped, like I was going to get caught doing something I shouldn't. I crept into the hallway and crossed the carpeted floor. I steadied myself on an expensive-looking table, also in front of a mirror. I avoided looking at myself and fished into my purse for my phone.

I was practically hyperventilating. My fingers were shaking as I swept over the screen, looking at my messages, my contact list.

Who did I want to call? Who did I want to talk to right now?

My stomach was in knots.

I tapped on Luke's icon and felt a pang of guilt looking at his picture: it was from a trip we had taken back to visit his parents. They had been driving us crazy, so we had snuck out to go to a bar, the only one in town. It had been a pretty redneck place and full of football fans who had insisted we cheer for the Packers and wear these ridiculous hats. Someone had offered him face paint, and he had taken the guy up on the offer. It was the funny, loose side of Luke, right in the middle of the storm of our marriage.

What was I doing?

I started to type to Luke, but I couldn't find the right words. What did I want to say to him? Was I backing out? Did I want him to talk me out of this, or talk me into it?

I typed and erased several times.

My phone buzzed in my hand, scaring the crap out me and making me almost drop it. It was Wallace. No icon, just a blue dot.

[WB]: *You find it okay?*

Reading his initials, I felt another stab of emotion run through me. This was hot, exciting. It took me out of the moment, away from my brief trip down memory lane to Wisconsin. I looked up at my face in the mirror.

I looked good. The dress looked amazing on me. I plumped my breasts inside the fabric and gave my hair a toss.

Luke and I had agreed on this. Hell, Luke had even put the whole thing in motion. He had seen this dress, he knew where I was. So what the hell was stopping me from getting something I wanted, too? Because there

was no denying that the ache between my legs was pushing me to get back in the elevator and go on up.

I started to type, "I'm here," but something inside of me wouldn't let me commit.

I walked to the elevator and pressed both buttons. Up and down.

I'd let fate decide, I told myself.

I stared at the arrows above the elevator door. When the elevator dinged, the "down" light came on. The doors opened. I stared into the elevator.

That was it: go down. Go back home, forget this whole thing. I was a married woman and the universe was telling me this was a bad idea.

I stared at my reflection in the mirror as the doors closed.

The elevator dinged again, and the doors re-opened. The elevator was going up now.

I stepped inside and pressed "8."

My stomach fell through the floor as the elevator lifted me through the air.

*

Wallace was wearing a charcoal-colored suit and a white shirt. Without his tie, his shirt unbuttoned slightly, he looked more like an athlete or a movie star. I felt the burn of his gaze traveling up and down my body as he leaned on the door frame and took me in. I could feel the back of my neck getting slightly sweaty, and somewhere else getting damp as well. I tried not to blush, but I knew I did.

He pressed his lips together and made a slight popping sound. "Damn," he said. "Don't you look good." He stood back and motioned to me to come inside.

I wasn't sure where to look or what to do. I was gripping my purse like it was the last thing tethering me to the real world. I mean, we all knew the score at this point. I wasn't here for dinner and catching up; Wallace knew it and so did I.

And so did Luke, though Wallace didn't know *that*.

My stomach twisted. Again, I wondered what the hell I was doing.

The apartment was as nice as the building; expensive furniture, expensive fixtures and décor that looked like it belonged in the pages of a

magazine. But it was all a little too-perfect, a little sterile. Rather than putting me off, the sterility of the apartment was sort of a comfort. Like I wasn't really going into Wallace's world, or even a real world.

Wallace had something going on in the kitchen that gave that room a slightly more cheerful aspect, but the rest of the place somehow looked dark, even though there were many lamps illuminating the vast space.

I crossed the room and looked out of the floor-to-ceiling windows.

"You've got a great view of the city," I said nervously.

Then I felt stupid. We were on the eighth floor, and it was just an okay view.

Wallace came up behind me; I saw his reflection in the glass. He swung his arm around me, and I thought he was going to hug me or something. I could feel my skin tingling with the desire for him to touch me, to enact the fantasies I'd been having.

But his arm never touched me, He was holding a glass of white wine in his hand. "It seems like you need a drink," he said smoothly.

I laughed nervously and took the glass. I fingered the necklace I was wearing, making sure it was still there as I turned around to face him. I sipped my wine – a little too quickly. I had to put my hand up to my lip to stop it from dribbling down my chin.

Wallace pretended not to notice. "That's some dress," he said. "Now, where should I take a girl all dressed up so pretty?"

I gulped several swallows of the wine, which tasted expensive and was probably not meant to be thrown back like a shot. And then I found myself saying:

"I was really thinking... we could stay in."

It seemed to me like Wallace was already nodding, already pressing his lips together that way he does, already reaching for my wine glass to take it out of my hand and set it down, before I even finished my sentence.

I finally dared to lift my eyes and look at him directly, and once I caught his gaze, I was a prisoner of his stare. It held me riveted, working on me almost like hypnosis. I could feel my body moving, but I didn't feel totally in control of it. My insides were a mass of hot shudders. When his fingers brushed over mine on the wine glass, it sent a ripple of pure erotic energy straight through me to the center of my legs, and I forgot everything except the moment I was in.

I heard the wine glass clank gently on a glass table-top and suddenly my hands were empty. Wallace reached out and placed his fingers on my shoulder. His skin was hot and dry. The pads of his fingers traveled down the front of the dress, over the swell of my breast, right to the center of the dip, on my sternum.

The heat of his touch was radiating through me and I felt a puff of air escape my lips and then I'm pretty sure I stopped breathing. I was getting so wet at that point – just from him touching me like that – that I couldn't see straight.

“Why don't you unclasp that dress?” Wallace said softly.

I reached behind me to do what he asked. I remember feeling grateful that he was going to take the lead, tell me what to do, take this whole business out of my hands. That was what I wanted, I realized. For someone to tell me what to do, to not have to make the decisions about it or even keep it moving along.

I started to step out of my heels as I reached behind my neck with both hands, but Wallace put his hand on the outside of my leg and shook his head. “Leave those on,” he said.

I pushed my foot back into my shoe with a shudder.

I twisted the clasp of the dress and felt the gentle pull of the fabric on my neck release. I could feel the shiny fabric sliding down my shoulders, the material slipping away from my breasts.

Wallace kept watching my eyes, but he moved his hands to the tips of the halter and followed its descent down to my waist.

I was topless then, and I had to fight the urge to cover myself up. Wallace brought one hand up to my lips, rubbed his thumb over my mouth, and then slowly moved down my body again. This time his eyes went with his hands, down to my breasts, and I had a flush of satisfaction course through me as I recognized pleasure on his face.

His hands traveled down and then back up. He cupped my breasts and played with the weight of them, then pinched my nipples between thumb and forefinger. I felt my nipples turn hard in his fingers, and another rush of liquid welled up in my panties. Another ragged puff of air escaped my lips as he squeezed again.

Then he moved his face close to mine, his eyes still locking me in place. His lips swallowed my mouth up in his. They were soft and dry, but soon our mouths were wet, entangled tongues darting around. His teeth bit

gently into my lower lip, then he leaned back to watch my face as he moved his hands over my body. But soon his mouth was pressed to mine again, probing deeply.

His hand moved to the back of the dress. The zipper was opening next, the fabric falling away from my body. His hot hand was on the bare part of my bottom, and he twisted his fingers to hook them under the lace of my panties. I shuddered as he stroked the place where my ass met my thighs.

When he felt my reaction he leaned back to smile a little, and did it again.

I remember thinking, in that brief moment, that this was it, the final moment in which I could escape. Yes, I'd already gone this far, but there was a way out of it -

But suddenly it was too late. Wallace's fingers slid beneath the fabric of my panties, and over my swollen clit. I felt one thick finger dip inside of me, and it felt so good that I forgot all about whatever it was I had been thinking up until that point.

I leaned it to him, and he walked me backwards. I stepped out of my dress.

He jerked on the fabric of my panties, and for a second I was alarmed as I didn't realize what it was that he was doing. The fabric cut upward, into the soaked lips of my pussy. I made a sound, but my mouth was still covered by his, and he bit me gently so I couldn't pull away.

The fabric, rough at first – and unexpected – exerted pressure and then started to feel good. Wallace took one of my hands, which I realized only at that moment had been hanging listlessly at my sides as I played the rag doll, unable to decide what to do. He guided it behind me, tucked it under the fabric of my panties, and then twisted the material. He did the same with my other hand, and only halfway through the process did I realize what he was doing.

A little bit of fear fluttered through my chest as I realized that he was tying my hands behind my back, with my own panties, but I could feel that no matter what my mind was committed to doing, my body had given in completely to him. So when his hand went up to my hair I let him. His fingers worked their way slowly into the mane of hair I had worn down for him, like the massage of a hairstylist, but I wasn't surprised when he gripped my hair with sudden force.

I had been expecting it, I realized.

I *wanted* it, more importantly.

He pulled my hair back and his lips traveled down my neck, sending shivers through my body. His lips were wet with the saliva from our shared kisses, and he was sucking on my skin, doing more than merely kissing me. He was claiming me.

I looked down at my fingers at the moment I had that realization, looking for my wedding ring, grateful I had put it on in the end. However strange that may seem, I was glad to see it there. It was a reminder that I was only stepping out of bounds, not leaving them forever. It made it possible for me to give in to the next sequence of events completely.

His lips went all the way to my collarbone, then he made his way back up my neck to my left ear. A shudder went through me as he breathed into my earlobe: “Turn around,” and moved my body at the same time.

He kept his grip on my hands, twisted in my panties, and the fabric rubbed against my clit. I was soaked with excitement now, so it didn’t hurt; it was more stimulating than anything. The danger of being of tied up was exhilarating, but it was also comforting. Releasing control to Wallace gave me the kind of distance I wanted from the act of actually violating my marriage vows.

He walked me through the living room, kissing my neck and prodding me forward, his hand on my left breast, fingers rolling my nipple into a hard ball. The pressure on my nipple was gentle, his kisses hungry, his grip on my wrists strong and forceful.

I knew that we were headed to the bedroom, and I didn’t take much in before he had picked up speed and pushed me onto the bed, face-first. The silky covers slid against my skin and I started to lift up to get into a dignified position, but since my hands were tangled behind me (and I didn’t want to untie them), it was hard.

But Wallace stepped in, grabbing me by the thighs to push me forward on the bed. The top layer of fabric slipped over whatever was underneath, so I slid easily and then into the pillows. Wallace propped my knees up beneath me, and kept pushing, so soon I was doubled over in a totally submissive position, my ass in the air.

He took his time from there. I was pushed into the pillows, unable to see what he was doing. I could only feel him as he started to make slow, warm circles over my ass. He slipped a finger under the panties that were

now tight against my clit, and then he pulled back on them and let them snap lightly against my throbbing button. I made a noise as the unfamiliar feel of that slightly painful, yet highly erotic, pinch traveled through me to the center of my body. My hips were starting to move of their own accord, and the ache between my legs was as strong as I could remember it ever having been.

He hooked a finger under the twisted part of the panties that rested above my bottom, and slid it down, following the material through the crack of my ass. When his fingers brushed over my asshole I felt a wave of humiliation but a roll of pleasure as well. He kept going, down to my pussy, down to the sopping-wet hole. I felt my muscles contract with the desire to feel him inside of me, even just his fingers.

But not yet. He tantalized me by sliding his fingers expertly over my clit, and then traveled, with wet fingertips, back up to my asshole. There he tugged the material of the panties away and drew a circle around my pucker.

I had never in my life had a man do this to me before, and had anyone asked if I'd want someone to, I'd probably have said no.

At the same time, it would also be a lie to say that in my private fantasies I'd never imagined or wondered about anal sex. But I didn't know how I would respond to it – or even this little bit of ass-play, because no one had ever done it to me before.

He didn't stay long, though.

I felt him pulling on the material my panties again, and I awaited another mild snap against my clit. But it didn't come, and I was left breathless and craving his next touch, wondering what it would be.

I felt the moist, hot air of his mouth near my pussy before anything else. Maybe he lingered there, enjoying the smell of me. He waited until I made a noise again, and then he flicked his tongue out to merely tease me. On my outer labia, on the inner lips so close to where I wanted to feel his cock deep inside. Near my clit, and then nearer to it again without actually touching it.

I heard myself moaning. The ache between my legs was so intense now that I could only think of it being released.

Wallace made a delicate sweep around the hood of my clit, avoiding the center where I wanted him to lick me so badly. I felt his tongue traveling around, out to my inner-most thighs, down my leg, into the crease

behind my knee. This made my legs shake and more sounds unlike any I'd made before in my life escape my throat. I started to twist my hands out of the panties but he reached up and held them.

He traveled back to my pussy, flicked at my clit, and then up to my ass again. There he took his time, the very tip of his tongue traveling around the circle of my anus, barely touching me. The sensation I experienced was like nothing else in my life; at first it was almost uncomfortable, then it became worryingly pleasurable. Then I started to have the same throbbing craving as I did in my pussy – except now it was a craving for a thing I knew nothing about.

When he dipped his tongue – just the very tip – into my ass, I almost screamed. I shifted, thinking at first I was uncomfortable. And I was. Half of me wanted him to stop. But the other half wanted him to go further. Maybe even...

But his tongue was back to moving again, traveling down to my pussy. Flicking at my clit.

Then, very suddenly, he grasped my legs and pulled me toward him. His tongue pressed against my clit and began to massage it rhythmically, finally sending me up closer to the high that I wanted so badly.

It's hard to describe how good this was. Like nothing anyone had ever done to me before. The pleasure reached a feverish pitch, places that would have ordinarily been a climax, but then he went beyond that. When my legs began to shake and I thought I was going over, he slowed what he was doing, or stopped.

The first few times he did this I only moaned in desperation. But the third time, he rose up onto his knees and pushed the pillows away from my head that had fallen onto my face. I was sweaty, and I felt like puddle: I could only writhe beneath him and hope he would let me finally fall over the edge. I heard myself whining.

I felt his finger on my clit again, and my lower body shuddered.

Wallace made a sound, a low “mmm” of appreciation. “You wanna come?” he growled at me. “Hmm?”

I heard his zipper, felt the weight of the bed shifting, but I was too lost to know what, exactly he was doing, and his fingers never left my body, never stopped their teasing.

Then the smooth, rounded bulb of his cock was against my clit. He pushed my legs apart with his knees, so that the fat object could fit between

the outer lips of my cunt. I strained to look back, but it was impossible, thanks to how he had me held by my hands and my panties.

I felt him tug on my panties, and then I heard them rip. But I was so focused on the size and shape of his cock – just the crown of it – rubbing against me. It seemed enormous, like it was covering my whole pussy.

Had I not been so wound up, so close to coming, I might have been afraid. But I was so wet, and my pussy ached so much from being brought up and down and so close to the edge of an orgasm, that I didn't fear the size of him at all.

The shredded material of my panties unwound from my wrists and I tried to reach back and grab his shaft, to size it up before he impaled me with it, but he stopped my hand and placed it on my ass, palm down to my buttock. He did the same with my other hand. "Now be a good girl, and I'll give you what you want," he said, in a low voice.

I felt a wave of juices gush out from inside of me.

He moved the crown of his cock against my clit, pushing forward slightly to give a precise and delightful amount of pressure to my swollen button. I went sailing high again, getting so close I started to feel dizzy, and my ears rang.

"Beg me to make you come," Wallace growled. "Let me hear you beg me."

I would blush later telling Luke about this, and I was never some kind of dirty talker in bed, but I didn't hesitate this time. "Please," I said, and I wasn't acting. He had stopped massaging my clit and it was so full and throbbing so hard I felt like it might burst. I was begging. "Please, please let me come."

"That's what I like," Wallace said. "Beg me some more."

"Please," I moaned. "I can't take it anymore. Please, just let me come."

"You gonna be a good girl and take all this big cock?"

"Yes," I said. "Just please, please. Don't tease me any more."

He moved his dick over my clit one time. I moaned and practically sobbed into the pillow.

And then, the crown of his cock slid down to my pussy. And he started to slide inside of me.

As I had known, and expected, his cock was huge. I was so wet, though, that he slid in and started to push outward on the walls of my cunt

without any hint of pain, just a cold, aching throb that stretched me and filled me. He went in slow, and the new sensation of his dick inside of me ignited a new ache, even as he abandoned the rhythmic treatment of my clit.

Now I ached two kinds of ways, and my body was screaming to be released. I turned my face into the pillows and sobbed.

“You okay?” Wallace said, but it came out as only half a question. “You’re okay,” he affirmed. He kept going, until his fat cock was so deep inside me I could feel it against my cervix. His balls swung against me. He pushed a little more, and my insides throbbed around his cock.

Then he started to fuck me.

I went over the edge after only a few thrusts, and it was such a shattering orgasm that I have no idea how long he was fucking me after that, or through it. I dropped my hands to the sheets and clutched them as wave after wave of pleasure that was almost too much too bear racked through me.

When my climax subsided, he was still inside of me, still fucking me, and now I was so sensitive that it almost hurt. I squirmed beneath him, but he gripped my ass with his hands and began to pummel into me with my legs half-lifted from the bed.

I could feel his cock getting steelier, the muscles straining against the skin of his dick, and I clenched my hands. Just as his muscles started to flex, I could feel my own needs building up again. I was mildly disappointed when he slammed deep inside of me and ceased fucking me to dump his seed in the depths of my pussy. He pulled me by the legs and pushed in deep. Then he gave a few more thrusts in the hot wetness of my filled pussy.

I could hardly believe that I was ready to go again – and not like I could just deal with it. A lot of times I didn’t finish with Luke. Just as he finally got to his own climax, I would be just reaching a state of arousal that made me want to keep going. But I often just gave up at that point.

Now, as Wallace knelt behind me with his still-hard cock twitching in my pussy, I didn’t want to just let it go. I wanted him to fuck me again.

He slid his cock slowly from inside of me, and the emptiness that was left behind ached horribly.

I twisted around and got onto my knees. Wallace grabbed the back of my neck and pulled me to his mouth, kissing me. “Good girl,” he said.

I slid down his torso; he had removed his shirt and was naked from head to toe somehow. His cock was still hard, pointed up in the air, and I couldn't help but raise my eyebrows when I saw it.

I put my hand around the girth of it as I moved my lips down his torso, and his cock flexed in my hand.

"Oh, you're ready again, huh?" he said.

I answered him by opening my mouth and taking the fat bulb of his crown inside of me.

I could taste my own juices, and the briny taste of his cum. Secretly, I knew that I had swallowed Luke's cum the other day in anticipation of this moment – so that I could perform this filthy act on Wallace without screwing it up. His cum was sharp and bitter, but I found I liked the taste of it as it filled my nostrils and my mouth.

But my lips were already stretched to what felt like the maximum by the time I had taken a few inches of his cock into my mouth. It was so thick it seemed unreal, and, with my hand on the throbbing veins of his shaft, I could not imagine going further.

I tried anyway, lowering my jaw and trying to open my throat.

The sensation of having my mouth filled, all the way to my throat, was also stirring a new feeling inside of me. I'd have never have told someone that before that night, but I liked the way I was getting gagged, stifled, filled up in my mouth with cock.

I pushed further.

Wallace grabbed my hair and shifted underneath me. He pushed gently to help me along, and I managed to get another inch or so into my mouth. But then I jerked my head up, needing to gasp and breathe.

He let me breathe, spit sliding down my chin, for only a moment. Then I felt his hand twist in my hair and he used his free hand to tip his cock slightly toward me, slapping my chin with his meat. "Come on," he said. "You can do it. Take it all."

I struggled later to tell Luke about this, to explain what it was inside me that made me want to actually comply with Wallace's order. But I wanted to. His musky scent filled my mouth and my eyes watered as I tried again, stretching my mouth and my throat to open up for him.

Wallace pushed a little on the back of my head as I reached what I felt was the furthest I could go. But I could only get a little further, and then I had to breathe again.

“That’s good, now just clean it off, get me ready again,”

I started to lick him, turning my head to run my tongue down the saliva-wet length of his shaft. On the top inches of his cock, little remained of the taste of our mingled juices, but the tangy scent of my own pussy and the briny taste of his cum crept into the flavor as I moved down to the base of his cock. I pulled his scrotum into my mouth, pressing the loose skin between my lips. Wallace was clean-shaven, or waxed, not a hair anywhere, and I was glad I’d done the same for him. I moved my tongue over his balls and felt his cock twitch against my cheek. Then I made my way back to the big crown of his dick.

I rolled my tongue over the bulb of his head, much like I had with Luke that day in the shower, noting the size of it, the different shape, the dark color. Wallace was circumcised, and so his cock felt strikingly different in my hand as I pumped him and licked the ridge of his crown. Meatier, more raw. I could feel tension in the veins that snaked around his dick as my tongue brought him back to the same arousal I felt.

My pussy was dripping by then, I could feel my excitement and the hot, wet load that Wallace had fucked into me dripping onto the sheets. It was so bad, so wrong, and yet I wouldn’t have had it any other way. Part of what I wanted was the explosion of wet seed, the danger of it, the wrongness of it.

I took the crown of his cock into my mouth and played with the surface inside my mouth. I heard Wallace make a sound and I knew that it pleased him.

But almost immediately after that, his hand was on my shoulder and pushing me up and back, tossing me like a rag doll into the pillows at the head of the bed. I landed on my elbows, giving him a coy look.

He grabbed my ankles and pushed my legs up, both ankles clasped in the grip of one strong hand. He pushed my legs to one side of my head and then plunged his fingers into my slit.

“Oh!” I heard myself saying, as he curled his fingers up and into my g-spot. He plunged two, then I felt another, and then I felt his fourth finger stretching my pussy to the same large size that his cock had reached. I could hear my cunt sloshing with all of his cum and my own juices. The moisture was draining between my legs and down to my ass.

I felt a craving then, again, to go even further, but it also gripped me with fear. Would he try that? Tonight? On our first ... er, date?

But I didn't have time to contemplate it, because he was clawing forward inside of me and he struck the bundle of nerves at the base of my clit and the sensation traveled through me like an electric shock. His thumb pressed on my clit from the outside, and he used his nail to scrape gently at the nerves on the face of my clit.

This time, my orgasm seemed to come out of nowhere. I opened my mouth to scream, but I was unable to make a sound. I felt my legs shaking and trembling, but I couldn't suck air into my lungs to make a sound.

I felt dizzy, like I might faint, and the climax had me in almost a seizure, the grip of it was so intense.

I barely knew that Wallace let go of my legs, and that they flopped open, and that he flipped me over onto my hands and knees. My limbs were shaking so hard I could barely stay upright like that, and I felt him push me back into position several times. Then he was back inside of me, his fingers were drawing liquid from my pussy up to my ass.

I barely recognized any of this. A high-pitched tinny sound was blocking my hearing, and my pussy was spasming around his cock. The pleasure was too intense again, only this time so much worse than before, but I lacked any control to stop or say anything, or even make a sound. I could only think of my full, full pussy and the way it was clenching his cock and sending shocks through my whole body each time it did. But none of this was under my control.

I felt his fingers on my ass, and the distraction might have been welcome, if it could have made its way through the excruciating pleasure of my cunt.

So when he plunged his thumb inside of me, the information reached me slowly. I didn't feel pain, just a strangeness, and then when I realized that he had a finger in my ass and that he was fucking me with it as he pumped his cock in and out of my pussy, I felt a new arousal building up inside of me.

I started to push back against him, to arch my back to get to the feeling of his knuckle pressing outward, then back down, against his cock. All the sensations were so new they almost hurt as well as being incredibly erotic. It was like the first time I had tried masturbating with my left hand – it still worked me up, but the raw sensation of it was almost uncomfortable, because it was new.

I realized I wanted more, but it wasn't going to happen just then. Wallace seemed to get overcome by something, and he roughly pulled his thumb from my ass to grip my hips and thrust his cock deep inside of me. He fucked me roughly until he came a second time. But this time he pulled out and pushed me onto the bed, roughly flipping my legs again and commanding me to roll over.

Thick ropes of his cum splashed on my stomach, my tits, and my inner thighs. He stared down at me, his gaze unyielding and satisfied, dominating and hard. Each hot stream of cum sent shivers through me: it should have been humiliating. In fact, it was.

But I liked it.

CHAPTER 15

Luke

I had no idea what to do with myself after I got to the hotel. My flight had left on time and I was there in the hotel room by 9:30. Ready for a bright and early day at Healy Company the next morning.

All I could think about, at any moment in the flight, was where my wife was, right at that moment. She had been planning to meet Wallace at eight at his place.

I wondered if they had gone to dinner. Wallace probably had some huge expense account. He had probably taken her some place really fancy, to ply her with expensive, aphrodisiac food. Oysters, strawberries...

I wondered if Lisa would even eat an oyster.

I wondered about a lot of things about Lisa, all during that flight and the hours in the hotel room that followed. About what kind of person Lisa really was, when she wasn't being Lisa my wife. I discovered that in many ways, I didn't know the answer to a lot of questions about her.

Did she eat oysters?

What were her secrets?

What was her favorite movie?

Wallace was new to her. Wallace would get the chance to ask her all of these things, to find out who she was *now*. While I had been sleepwalking through my life with her for the past decade or so, and knew nothing about these simple questions.

And how would Lisa be with him? She wouldn't be the same. She would fuck differently, kiss differently.

OR would she? What if she was the same with him as she was with me? Would she dig her heels into his lower back the same way, make the same sounds, rake her fingers down his back just like she did to me if she was really excited?

Which of those two possibilities was more painful?

Thinking about all of this, I was treated to the awful sensation of being both turned on and sick to my stomach. Not an ordinary sickness: a ball-breaking sickness. My guts hurt like someone had taken a vice to my kidneys.

10:00.

Surely by then they had eaten and gone back to his place. Maybe he had his fingers under the straps of her dress right now, his dark brown fingers against her skin, moving down, along the curve of her breasts. The back of his knuckles would scrape over her nipples and they would turn to pebbles beneath his skin.

Or maybe she had gone wilder, unable to wait until they got back. Maybe they were in the back of a taxi right then, their contrasting skin tangled together, Wallace's hands under her skirt, groping for her panties, pulling them away from her freshly shaved snatch and dipping inside.

Or was Lisa's head in his lap, her lips around his cock?

I clutched my stomach when I thought of the scene: my wife taking his cock into her mouth and swallowing it all up. I pictured Wallace's smug, self-satisfied face as he grasped Lisa's blonde hair and tugged and pushed on her head, working her mouth up and down the length of his shaft. Using my wife for his own pleasure.

I was sweating. I took a cold shower, both to calm down the raging erection I had and to cure the queasiness that was threatening to make me throw up.

You did this, I told myself. Whatever happened, it was all my own fault.

Eleven, Twelve. No call from Lisa.

How long would they go on?

Why hadn't I told her to call me the *minute* she was done?

I got into the booze. When another hour went by, I gave in and jerked off in the shower, picturing Lisa giving Wallace the same filthy blowjob she'd given me. On her knees, her eyes locked on his, her sweet pink mouth stretched wide to accommodate his thick brown cock.

Nothing. No word from Lisa at all.

I got drunker and drunker.

At last, when I was bleary-eyed and losing my mind, my phone lit up.

"Lisa," I said.

There was a little pause. "I did it," she said, finally.

I gulped. Actually gulped: it felt like I had a rock in my throat.

I didn't know what to say to her for a moment.

"Are you... is it..."

"I'm really tired," Lisa said.

“Are you okay?”

Lisa paused again. The time passed by as though years were unfolding in the distance between us. “I’m fine. I’m... what about you? Are you okay? I mean... you sound... weird.”

The worry in her voice brought me down to earth. It actually gave me a little thrill, as perverse as it sounds and as perverse as it is. There was a little dusting of guilt in her voice.

That was good, right?

“No, of course. Of course, I’m just... I got a little drunk.”

Another pause.

“You’re still okay, right? This is what you wanted, after all.”

“Honey, of course,” I said.

There was another long pause.

I wanted, desperately, for her to tell me about what happened over the phone, right then and there.

“Listen, I’m really, really tired,” she said, and my heart fell. “I, um... can we talk about this when you get back?”

“Yeah of course,” I said, trying not to sound disappointed.

“Okay,” Lisa said. Her voice sounded strange. “I love you.”

“I love you,” I said.

And when I hung up the phone, I felt terrible.

Maybe this had all been a mistake.

CHAPTER 16

Lisa

After we had sex, I lay in the dark with Wallace for a while, my hands on his muscled chest. I realized, as soon as I came down from the high of my orgasm, that I hadn't thought any further ahead than actually going through with having sex with him. I hadn't thought for even a millisecond about what I'd do afterward, or how I'd feel.

Wallace was fairly silent. His demeanor changed a lot: he seemed sleepy and got that sort of distanced attitude that I heard my female friends talk about men getting after they had sex. For me, it had been such a long time, and only one time other than with Luke, that I didn't have any personal experience with that.

If I had thought about him behaving like that before we'd had sex, maybe I wouldn't have gone through with it.

The strange thing was, I was actually grateful for his silence. I was also grateful that he dropped his seductive act. Grateful that we didn't seem to have some kind of sticky love connection after what we had done. I didn't need complications. And, I realized, lying there in the dark: *I didn't want them.*

After about half an hour, I told him I thought I should go home.

He sat up and kissed me on the shoulder. "You can stay here," he offered, and the offer seemed genuine.

"I just like sleeping in my own bed," I said, and as soon as I did, I realized it was pretty much true. "I'm old," I added. "Set in my ways."

Wallace laughed and threw back the covers. I watched him retreat into his bathroom and I felt a shiver of pleasure, followed by a wave of guilt, as I enjoyed the sight of his sculpted ass and his dark, sinewy muscle from head to toe. I had this thought go through my head, that he was really a *specimen* of man, and it was almost scandalous to myself.

I mean, what kind of *person* was I turning into?

I never acted like this.

"I hear you," he said, and I heard him peeing through the open door. "I'd rather be in my own bed any night of the week. But with this job, I'm only home like three months outta the year."

“Where is your ‘home,’ anyway?” I asked, relieved that the conversation was turning to something sort of neutral and boring. Wallace came back into the room and I stared at his naked form before quickly averting my eyes. I didn’t want to get involved in... anything... again.

“Chicago. If you want a shower, you’re welcome to it,” Wallace said, leaning over and kissing me. Then he plopped into the bed next to me. “I hope you weren’t up for another round, because I think I’m beat.”

I laughed and got out of the bed. “Yeah, no,” I said. I didn’t think I would be able to take it. My pussy was sore, and so were a lot of other places.

I took a shower, and by the time I came out, Wallace was nearly asleep. I considered kissing him goodbye, but it suddenly seemed strange, and unnecessary.

I collected my clothes, called an Uber driver, and crept down to the lobby.

The same attendant was at the front desk, and he barely gave me a glance. Even so, his face said he had me all sized up.

For a second, my cheeks burned with shame.

But then I thought, *frack you*. I wished I had a cigarette and I dug through my purse for one. I’d been sneaky-smoking for a couple of years, and I hardly ever craved one all by myself. It was more to hang out with the backstage people at rehearsals.

No dice. The Uber driver came and I sat in the back of his car. He was lively Iranian who wanted to chat, so I made a good listener for him. He didn’t seem to even notice that I was a woman in a slutty dress going home at three am to the suburbs where I obviously was not single.

I called Luke when I got home, just like I had promised, but I didn’t want to talk about anything just then. In fact, the call itself was hard to make.

I was really tired. Luke’s voice made my heart ache, because I knew he wanted more details, more assurances from me that everything was okay. I could hear the need in his voice, even through his drunkenness, and I just couldn’t give him what he wanted at that moment.

CHAPTER 17

Luke

Lisa sent me a text the next day, while I was in meetings at Healy.

[Lisa]: *sorry I was so tired last night. Call me when u want to talk.*

And then quickly afterward:

[Lisa]: *maybe we should wait until you get home? Do it in person?*

I clutched the phone to my chest and my insides turned to iron and sank right through me. I had to excuse myself and hide in the restroom, because I was hyperventilating a little.

That's an exaggeration. But I knew I looked like a mess.

She was right, of course. She was right that it would be best to hear about it in person. But there were so many paranoid paths for my mind to go down. Why did she want to wait? Why was she putting off talking to me? Did she have regrets or had she fallen in love with Wallace?

"Stop being an idiot," I said to myself in a low voice.

I typed a message:

[Me]: *lets wait until I get back. Ill see you tomorrow night?*

I had to wait hours for her reply.

[Lisa]: *that's perfect*

And then my heart ached because she didn't say anything else. Later in the evening she me a text saying goodnight and she loved me, she was going to her late evening class.

The whole night was torment, and the next day.

*

I got home at seven-thirty.

Lisa was home: her car was in the driveway and the lights were on.

I could feel my heart racing more and more the closer I got to the door. She wasn't in the kitchen when I opened it; I threw my briefcase down. Desperation was clutching me: I needed to see her, then, at that moment. To confirm that she was still here, still mine.

She came into the kitchen within moments, and her face fell into a slight grimace of worry when she saw me. "Hey," she said, her voice tender. "You okay?"

I crossed the room and grabbed her. The compulsion to do it was fierce: I needed to kiss her and feel with my mouth and my hands that she was mine, in my kitchen, still here for me.

She responded to my kiss by melting into my mouth, her body relaxing and letting me hold her. She lifted her arms at last to put them on my shoulder and pull back to take a breath. Her eyes met mine.

"Wow," she said. "I was... sort of wondering how to start this conversation -"

I cut her off by kissing her again. Then I started pushing her toward the bedroom. She was wearing a little white skirt and a yellow blouse, I pushed her blouse up and over her arms and tore her bra down to her waist as we walked. I found the zipper of her skirt in the back and tugged it down. It fell off and she somehow stepped out of it as we walked. I freed myself from my own clothes as we went, I can barely remember how.

Lisa fell backward onto the bed and crab-walked until she was lying on it. I was right after her, naked then, kissing her.

I slid my hand down between her legs, and brushed my fingers over her freshly waxed slit. She was silky-soft, and I ran into a little wetness as I cupped her pussy. I curled my fingers into her folds, where her excitement was hot and sticky. I went further, climbing inside of her with my fingers, exploring the pussy she had given to Wallace Brown two nights before.

But her body felt the same as ever. I don't know if I had been expecting something else. All that had changed is that she was wildly turned on, and she squeezed my fingers as I explored deeper. Her body jerked when I brushed over her g-spot, and she dug her fingers into the back of my neck.

My face was close to hers now, and she was looking me in the eye. This was something we had only just started doing again, and the intensity of staring at her was almost too painfully pleasurable to bear. I pulled my hand out of her pussy and grabbed her arms, pinning them on either side of her head.

My cock was rock solid and I maneuvered myself into her pussy, sinking in slowly, enjoying the way she gasped.

“You feel so good,” she said. “I missed you.”

My cock throbbed inside of her. Of all the things she might have said, all the things I wanted her to say, that might have been the most unexpectedly hot.

I started to fuck her slowly, enjoying the feel of her as if it were a completely new experience.

And in a way, it was. Lisa was not the same woman I normally had sex with. Not anymore. Not just because she had fucked Wallace, but because she was more present than she had been in such a long time. Something was different about her, too, something I chalked up to Wallace but couldn't put my finger on.

We made love without talking about him, or what she had done. It was slow and tender, and intense.

When I came, I lay on top of her, not wanting to leave her body. We held each other for a long time, kissing.

Finally, I rolled onto my side and she spooned into me. We cuddled for a while and I stroked the length of her body.

I kissed her shoulder. “So I guess you're still mine,” I said, a little drowsily.

Lisa craned her head back in surprise. “What? Of course I am.” She smiled and turned her head back to face the other side of the room. She kissed my hand. “Don't be crazy.”

I kissed her shoulder again and trailed my hand down the curve of her waist, over her firm bottom, down the length of her thigh.

“So,” I said. “How was it?”

My cock was against her lower back, and I knew she felt it coming to life again.

I moved my hand up to her bottom and slid my fingers in between her legs. Looking down at her face, I thought her eyes seemed a little glassy and distant as she stared straight ahead. Her mouth fell open and she gasped

as I pinched her clit. She rubbed her bottom against me and my cock was rock hard again. "You promised to tell me," I whispered into her ear.

Lisa's eyes were open. I knew she wasn't much of a dirty talker, so I decided to help her along.

"Did you suck his cock?"

"Yes," she said.

"Was it big?"

Lisa trembled as I stroked her clit. "It was really big. I didn't... I couldn't get it all the way in my mouth."

My cock flexed. "Tell me more," I said.

"I didn't do that at first. First he pushed me onto the bed and um... he, you know...."

"Did he lick your pussy?"

Lisa nodded. I lifted her leg a little and guided my cock to her hole. She bent forward slightly to get me inside of her, and then pushed back as I slid in. Her pussy was hot and practically liquid. Beneath that layer of excitement and cum, I felt her smooth muscles, pulsing around my cock.

"What else did he do?"

Lisa bit her lip. "I can't... it's so..."

I pulled gently on her hair and gnawed on her neck. "You promised," I growled.

"He licked my... ass."

"He played with your ass?" I said, and my cock twanged again.

Lisa smiled in reaction to this. Suddenly, she seemed to get momentum. "He licked it," she said. "And it felt incredible."

I thrust inside of her and bit into the back of her shoulder. "What else?"

"So, then he fucked me. I was on my hands and knees."

"Did you like it? Was his cock big?"

"His cock... was so... it was so... oh! It was so... big that I... that it..." Lisa started to lose her train of thought, so I slowed what I was doing and held her chin in my hand.

"Tell me. It was so big that what?"

"It was just really big. It felt..."

"Did you come?"

"It was amazing."

"Did he come? Did he come inside of you?"

I waited in agony for the answer.

“Yes,” she said, her voice breathless.

My cock pulsed and I started to fuck her. “And then what? Did you suck his cock afterward?”

“Oh, oh...” Lisa was starting to climax, and she tried to fuck me, pushing back against me. I held her firmly and stopped her. “Tell me,” I said.

“I sucked all the cum off his cock. And then he... then he... he fucked me again.”

It was too much for me. And her. I wanted more details, I wanted to listen to her tell me every single thing he had done, but I was going over the edge. She had painted images in my mind of Wallace’s tongue lapping at her pussy, dipping into her ass. Of her own mouth being defiled by his huge black cock, and then her pussy getting filled up to overflowing with his seed.

In seconds, I was fucking my own come wildly into her slutty hole, images of Wallace’s cock inside of her clear as if it was right in front of me.

We lay there panting for quite awhile afterward.

Then Lisa put her hand to her face. “Holy cow,” she said.

Her laugh seemed to be needed to release some kind of tension inside of her.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t... um... you know. Be more...”

She rolled over to look at me.

“More what?” I asked.

Lisa put on her kooky voice. “I don’t know... like, dirty talker.” She turned away again and bit her knuckles. “I tried. It just doesn’t come naturally to me.”

I kissed the back of her neck, smiling. “You’re not embarrassed about what you did or something are you?”

She shrugged. “I mean, a little. Maybe. I don’t know.”

A streak of red was creeping over her cheeks.

“Was that it?” I said. I propped myself up on my elbow and stroked her arm. “Or did you do something else?”

Lisa bit her fingers again and shook her head.

I didn’t really know which question she was answering, but I could see she was getting flustered.

“Hey,” I said, kissing her shoulder again. “Everything's okay, okay? You know that right?”

She turned back to look at me. Her eyes seemed to search mine.

“I really love you,” she said, unexpectedly. “You know that, right?”

I kissed her. “I know,” I said. “I love you, too. This is all just... a fling. And it was hot.”

Lisa turned onto her side again.

Then she smiled.

“Well,” she said. “It *was* hot.”

There was a silence.

“Are you going to see him again?” I said. My fingers were on her smooth abdomen, stroking her. I struck a nerve and she giggled and coiled up.

She rolled on to her stomach and propped herself up on her elbows. Her hair fell around her shoulders. She was still a little flushed, and sweat beaded on her forehead. She was stunningly beautiful, an otherworldly creature.

How was this woman my wife?

How did she come to be mine?

I touched her cheek.

“If you think... I... we... should,” she said.

Then we spooned again, without really answering the question. For that moment, I didn't want to think about Wallace Brown or Lisa with him. I just wanted to hold her, and know that for that moment at least, she was mine.

CHAPTER 18

Lisa

I made up my mind to do it sometime in the afternoon a few days after Luke came home.

Since that night with Wallace, I couldn't stop thinking about him. And not in a way I'd expected. That night had made me realize that I wasn't in need of some kind of companionship or attention. I had thought maybe that was what I wanted before I went through with it, but afterward, when my thoughts were so entirely centered on sex, I knew it was something much more carnal than that.

I couldn't shake the really dirty thoughts out of my head.

Maybe it was hard for me to say what had happened to Luke, but it wasn't hard for me to *think* about it in detail. It wasn't hard for me to reenact in my mind while I masturbated in the middle of the morning.

And it wasn't hard for me to get creative and have thoughts about taking things further.

There was one specific way I wanted to take things further.

I just didn't know if I'd be able to do it.

Naturally, I *thought* of enlisting Luke. After all, this was a shared adventure and it seemed like he'd be okay with it.

But the thought of actually talking to Luke about it just didn't work for me. This was my husband, the man I had kids with and shared all of my thoughts and hopes and dreams with.

But... in a clean way. A much cleaner way.

I didn't really want to get this filthy with Luke.

It was thinking about all of that that made me realize what I was doing, what this fling was for. I needed – well, I wanted – something sexual that I just couldn't ask for with Luke.

I would never tell Luke, and I would never tell Wallace – I would never even dream of telling anyone – about what I did. But I wanted to be ready, I wanted to be able to take Wallace's cock in my ass.

I don't know why I was so certain that he would try, so sure that the next time I "saw" him he would want to take me like that. There was something about the *way* he wanted to dominate me that seemed like some

kind of natural sequence of events, some natural submission on my part, an integral part of my nature.

I had gone to a sex toy party when my friend Maggie had decided to start selling them (she'd since given up). To support her, and because everyone else was doing it, I'd bought a vibrating dildo.

It was still in the box.

I unearthed it in the closet – really well tucked away where no one would ever see it but Luke, who had also laughed at it and never once suggested we use it. I took it out of the container, It still smelled like fresh rubber.

Shaking, I fell to my knees in the closet and put in the batteries.

Then I turned it on.

The item – slightly floppy, started to vibrate in my hands and I dropped it.

“Oh God,” I laughed.

I even looked behind my shoulder to see if anyone was there.

I touched the crown of the dildo.

It was way too big. My plan was to work up to things, to get gradually bigger and bigger until Wallace's cock didn't seem so big. But this was too big to start.

I bit my lip.

Okay, so here's where the story gets... well, cringe-worthy for me anyway. And I mean, I will go to my grave before I tell Luke about it.

I stood up and looked through the shelves for something that would... well, provide a step-up to the fat dildo. Which I *did* want to get to, because the idea of that thing vibrating inside of me had made me wet already.

I picked up several items, and then I settled on a container of lotion about one inch in diameter. That should be a good start.

I dug up some old condoms we had tucked away from when I had to go off birth control for an infection. These things were ancient, but I supposed it didn't matter. In the same box was some lube we had used for the same purpose. Old, but usable.

And then, really not believing what I was doing, I prepped the bottle.

I knew if Luke could see me he'd want to know what the hell I was going about things like that for, and I'd have been hard-pressed to explain it exactly. But it was just like I said: I didn't want to disappoint Wallace. And

I didn't want to be this dirty with Luke. And I wanted to know, ahead of time, if I could do it.

I got into position on the bed as I imagined Wallace would want me – chest on the bed, arms under my body, ass in the air. But it was hard to reach my ass, so I brought my arm up and over to go down. Then I pushed the cap of the bottle against the pucker of my hole.

It was cold, and the sensation was a huge turn-on. I pushed, and gave a little yelp as the bottle cap went in.

But when I reached the bigger, thicker part of the bottle, I had trouble going any further. The ring of my anus was protesting the pain, even as much as my insides craved to be filled.

I started to sweat as I tried to push it in, but I couldn't do it.

I moved the bottle in and out a few times. How had Wallace done it? How did people do this?

And then I remembered some almost-forgotten show or conversation with someone (I couldn't even remember which) in which someone had said that you have to push out to relax.

I took a deep breath, and tried it.

And sure enough, as odd as it seemed, I felt my hole open and the object slid in. I gasped at first; it was a little painful.

But almost as quickly as it sent a sharp pain to my mind, the pain went away. As the inches of bottle went in further and further, the pleasure of being filled, even by the tiny bottle, overwhelmed me. The soreness and the ache it produced was like nothing I'd even felt before.

I kept one hand on the bottle to keep it from popping out, and used my forefinger to push on it gently when it slid out. I learned quickly that I could simulate thrusts this way, and so I did that while I slid the fingers of my other hand into the soaked folds of my pussy.

I stroked my clit while I pushed on the bottle, and my climax built quickly. My ass was sore, almost like I wanted relief from the bottle, but I also craved it, craved more. Soon I was going over the edge.

But what happened was so different, so incredibly good: my ass clenched tightly on the bottle, sending an exquisite shot of near-painful aching through me, and then again and again as my clit burst and my orgasm rained over me.

I yelled without being able to stop myself and slapped my knees together, falling over. I felt the bottle squeezing slowly out of me and my

pussy spasming wildly.

It was incredible.

From that moment on I couldn't stop thinking about anal sex. There's something I can't say I had ever thought I would think or say. I wanted Wallace's cock, and I wanted it all the way to the base inside of my ass when I came, so I could feel that same ruthless orgasm times a hundred.

The idea would come to me in the most banal moments. Washing dishes. Sitting in class. It was almost as if I could feel it inside of me before I had even experienced it, and the ache made me have to squirm. In class, I started sweating because I couldn't move my hips to alleviate the pain.

I had to excuse myself to go masturbate in the bathroom, where I came in a few seconds, sitting on the toilet, imagining Wallace's cock in my ass.

Completely and totally out of control. Sweat ran down my cheek.

I knew I needed to get things under control. Right then, at a moment right after some episode like that, my hand on the metal stall, sweat snaking down my back, panting and throbbing on a toilet seat in a university bathroom – right then, I would have clarity. This was crazy. Out of control.

But that clarity faded so fast it made my head spin. Within minutes I was just back to wanting Wallace's cock, and not caring what I had to do to get it.

CHAPTER 19

Luke

I'll never know if there was something planned about the evening or not. Lisa told me that it was all just coincidence, and I believed her at the time because she seemed genuinely surprised when she walked into the restaurant and saw him.

This was maybe a week after she had slept with him. We'd been busy all weekend with long-ago promised social events, and we'd just kind of avoided the question of when she was going to see Wallace next. I didn't even ask her if she had texted him. I was working late, she had classes, and soon it was mid-week.

We decided to go out to eat at a pretty trendy, high-end restaurant downtown.

"Oh!" she said, in an almost panicked, low voice seconds after we entered. She stopped in her tracks and I bumped into her.

But, my wife is an actress. Who will ever know if it wasn't all just an act?

"Lis," I said, grabbing her arms and trying not to push us both over. "Jesus."

Lisa started walking again, and waved her hand nervously. She mumbled something over her shoulder at the same time a hostess smiled at us. The hostess took two heavy, leather-bound menus from a container and brightly asked us to follow her.

"What?" I said, not having heard Lisa.

Her voice was like a razor through the air. "Shht!" she snapped. She whacked my hand. "I'll *mmmmfmmmmrrrrmmm*."

"I can't hear you," I said loudly.

One of Lisa's pet peeves about me was that I was notoriously slow on the uptake when she was trying to be discreet. That was a fair observation. I really was. So, whenever she was trying to indicate that I should look at someone, or say something in a low voice, I was always shouting "I can't hear you?" or repeating half of the sentence really loudly ("The man with the pink shirt has a *what?!*")

I was, however, getting slightly better by that time, and what I mean by that is, I still shouted “I can’t hear you!” but as soon as I did I had the good sense to shut up.

Lisa threw herself into the booth we were shown to and looked anxiously at the hostess, who began giving the restaurant’s standard speech about how the food came from free-range otters or whatever it was. Lisa nodded frantically, urging her forward, and then ordered two glasses of water and said we’d think on the wine.

The girl left, looking annoyed. Lisa leaned over the table and grabbed my wrists. “He’s here,” she whispered.

“Who?” I said, looking around the restaurant.

Then I realized what an idiot I was. My heart went cold and thumped hard against my chest. “Where?” I whispered.

“Don’t look,” Lisa said sharply. “But he’s at a table in the bar area.”

I looked at the wine list to keep myself from looking around. “Did he see you?” I said.

The bar area was about fifty feet from where we were, and the restaurant was hopping, so I wasn’t sure why we were whispering. But it was kind of fun.

I looked up at that moment, to see Lisa better when she gave her answer.

What I saw sent a dagger through my heart, but also excited me: Lisa’s face was flushed. So flushed she could never have denied it. Not the flush of embarrassment. It wasn’t red and splotchy. It was a glow, a pink hue that tinged her cheeks. I looked at the soft indent in her neck, where her pulse was fluttering even more wildly than her breath. She was taking uneven gasps. I would have bet money that her pulse was 180.

“Did you know he was coming here?” I growled.

Lisa shook her head.

A waitress returned with two glasses of ice water and introduced herself cheerfully as Maggie. “Have we decided on drinks yet?”

“Rum and coke,” Lisa said. “Diet! Sorry, Diet Coke!”

She had the jitters.

I tried to be suave. I snuck a glance at the bar area, around the curve of the waitresses’ ass. I could only see Wallace’s dark arm, his fingers tapping a beer.

“Whiskey, neat,” I said.

The waitress nodded, with the kind of look that told me she was going to have to run that one by the bartender, because she looked about twelve and was cheerful enough she couldn't have worked more than two shifts as a waitress in her life.

She fluttered away.

Lisa and I looked at each other.

Then I had a sinful idea.

"Send him a text," I said, devilishly.

Lisa's eyes went wide. "What?! Huh?"

But I could see that she was excited by the idea. The flush was turning into a fever. Like it or not, my wife was excited by the black man at the bar, and like it or not, I was excited by her excitement.

The idea was forming in my mind like a wild storm. "Sure," I said. "Text him. Tell him you're here. Pretend like it's a secret."

Lisa's mouth turned up a little at one corner, but she feigned scandal. "I couldn't," she said.

"Do it," I encouraged her. "It'll be fun."

She took out her phone and turned it over and over in her hands. She bit her lip.

"And then what?" she said.

I took a sip of my ice water. "Tell him... you're here with me but..." my mind went wild, and my cock got hard before I even spit out my idea. I leaned forward and grinned. "Tell him you're here with me but you have to touch him. Tell him to meet you back by the restrooms or something."

Lisa made a face. She opened her mouth in disbelief and shook her head slightly, and cocked it to one side. *Such a crazy idea*, her expression said. *No way*.

But beneath the performance she was giving me, of reluctance, I could see the glint in her eye. I could see it while I was talking. When I said "but you have to touch him," I could almost see her blood moving more quickly beneath her skin. Her eyes dilated like someone had just shot her full of a wild drug.

Because I was saying what she wanted to say. Telling her to do what she wanted to do. She wanted to just touch him.

"Do it," I said again.

Lisa shook her head again, but her fingers were working on her phone.

She typed, and then she looked up at me, as if questioning whether I was for real. The waitress came back with our drinks and set them down.

“You get a chance to look at the -”

“Not ready,” I hissed, not taking my eyes off Lisa. “Come back in about five minutes.”

The girl looked horrified but said she would, and took off.

“Send it,” I said to Lisa.

She pressed her screen. And then her eyes dropped to her phone as she brought the rum and Diet Coke to her lips.

We waited in agony. Maybe he wouldn’t look at his phone. He could be with a client, and not want to be rude -

The phone lit up, rattling softly on the heavy wood table.

Lisa read the message, and I watched her eyes as she read it again.

She looked up at me.

I raised my eyebrows. *And?*

She started to hand the phone across the table to me. I shook my head. “He might be able to see us,” I said. “Pass it under the table.”

[WB]: *I saw you. You look hot. Meet me in five by the men’s. Tell hubby you don’t feel so good.*

The screen lit up in my hands again.

[WB]: *you might not be back for a while*

It was Lisa’s turn to raise her eyebrows. I handed the phone to her under the table, and our fingers touched. The touch was electrifying, and I felt my cock stiffen.

She read the message in her lap. Then started to turn in the direction of the bar, and then changed her mind.

I picked up a menu. “Look. Maybe he’ll see you.”

I had to strain to focus my eyes on the menu and not look at Lisa, in case Wallace was looking over here. I had to look clueless, like I didn’t know at all that my wife was trying to cast a sneaky signal at a black man sitting at the bar.

“Should I really do it?” Lisa said.

I looked up at her. I could see that every fiber of her being wanted to do it.

I wanted her to do it.

We looked at each other. I couldn't find anything to say.

"I don't feel so well," Lisa said, at last. "I'll... be right back."

"Sounds good," I said, my voice flat.

She smiled at me, and I smiled at her. Half of me felt like doing that, and the other half did not. My stomach turned in my abdomen and I chugged my \$7.50 well whiskey. Then I looked for the waitress to bring me another. I'd busy myself by teaching this dizzy chick how to up-sell.

CHAPTER 20

Lisa

I didn't want to hurt Luke, and it was hard to tell what he was feeling. He was the one who suggested it, not me, so I felt like it was safe to say he really did want me to text Wallace.

And go back to the restrooms to meet him.

And to be gone for a really long time.

But still: I thought I saw something in his expression that wasn't quite right.

And I felt guilty because, in the end, I wanted to go back there. I really did just want to touch Wallace. My hands had been itching to do it since the moment I saw him sitting there at the bar as we passed by. I knew it was him just from the back of his neck, the shape of his muscles in his shirt. And almost instantly I was wet and thinking of his cock.

Which, let me tell you, was a holy-hell new one for me.

I was unsteady when I stood up. For one thing, it was the heels. But for another, my whole body was pulsing with the danger of what I was doing. The lies I was telling Wallace, the omissions I was making to Luke, the way I was overriding Luke's possible hurt feeling with my own need, which was nothing more than a purely carnal desire to have a black man's cock inside of me.

And I was about to do it in public, it seemed.

I tugged the skirt down to try and cover more of my legs. It wasn't a slutty skirt by any means, but I felt like a slut as I walked toward the hallway.

Along the way though, I had a realization:

I kind of liked that feeling.

I turned the corner to where the restrooms were most likely to be, and ended up in a labyrinthine hallway of dark wood. I saw the men's restroom door, the ladies... no Wallace. I slowed down, fishing in my purse.

I turned around.

His body came into contact with mine instantly, too quickly for me to realize what had happened or what he was doing. I only felt the heat of his

body through his shirt, his hands pushing me backward, my feet scrambling to keep up. My mouth fell open but I was too shocked to make a sound.

I realized that we were in the men's bathroom, but only vaguely. It was one of those nice jobs that had only one stall and a nice area in it, but Wallace didn't pause to check any of that before he reached behind him and locked the door.

I didn't have time to object, he was pushing me backward again with his mouth covering mine and his hands pulling my skirt up.

I slammed into the wall, felt the cold marble against my exposed skin. Wallace's fingers were on my inner thighs now, sliding upward, encountering the slick juices that had spilled out of my panties and onto my thighs. Finding out just how hot he made me, he was pleased with himself, I could tell.

He released my mouth and placed his hands on the back of my legs. Then he hiked me up, pushing me against the marble, taking my breath away. My pussy was throbbing, and my mind was scrambled. I was in a public place, I was less than 1000 feet from my husband, I was about to get fucked against a wall in a men's bathroom...

Wallace pushed aside my panties and dipped his fingers into my pussy. When he stroked my clit I shuddered. He teased me for a bit while I stared at him, his lips, his cool gaze devouring me.

Then his fingers went further down, touching my ass, making another circle on it.

I felt his finger inside of me, and I closed my eyes. He plunged his forefinger in and out of my ass, the sopping juices of my pussy lubricating it enough that it slipped right in. He pushed against me with his weight while he did this, and his body moved against me as he unzipped his pants.

He kept finger-fucking my ass as he lined his cock up with my pussy.

Then he pushed inside of me, and I was filled up by his enormous cock.

But the sensation I could not get out of my mind, that was driving me the wildest, was the tiny pulse of his finger inside my ass. He hooked forward and pressed against the inside of me, squeezing the skin of a place no one had ever explored against the hardness of his own cock.

And then he dove inside of my ass deep with two fingers and clutched my thighs. He started to fuck me.

The way he fucked was just... so hard. So animalistic, so wild. He thrust in deep, probing where I had never been probed before, his thick cock stretching me out. And he fucked me intensely, hard and fast. All the while his fingers moved in my ass and sent an electric pulse through me in a place I'd never felt before.

My eyes were closed.

In truth, I was thinking of how it would feel if he slid his huge cock into my ass, and the ache it inspired sent me over the edge.

Wallace put his hand over my mouth as I came, and I bit into his palm. Again, I felt like I was losing control; I could hear myself squealing and I couldn't actually think of how to make the sound stop. The only thing I could feel was my pussy and my ass, clenching around his cock and his finger.

Wallace thrust up hard inside of me, and I felt the explosion of his hot cum between my legs.

He let my thighs drop after a few moments of panting together, the sticky smell of our bodies mingling in the air between us. His cock slid out of my pussy, and I felt his cum draining between my legs.

Wallace puffed and smiled. He tucked my hair up and back, then did that thing where he popped his lips. "You're a mess," he said tenderly. "You'd better clean up before you go out there."

I was shaking. My heels had come off and I stepped into them. I tucked into the bathroom stall and wiped Wallace's cum from between my legs. I wondered how I would feel if I had actually done this – sneaked in here while Luke was outside, unaware of his wife's slutty infidelity? How would I have hidden things? How much guilt would be piled up on me.

I also wondered if I would have done it anyway, even if he hadn't known, even if he hadn't given me permission.

My pussy was sore, throbbing, aching to be filled again.

I flushed the toilet and walked out to the mirror, where Wallace was straightening out his shirt. He smiled at me as I looked aghast in the mirror. I leaned forward and wiped the mascara from underneath my eye, and dipped into my purse frantically for some make-up.

Wallace watched me as I did. He turned around and leaned against the counter.

When I was done he touched my mouth, clearing a little smudge of lipstick away. "You look beautiful," he said. He brought his hand to his

nose and inhaled.

It sent a shiver through me. I leaned forward and kissed him.

I checked myself in the mirror again, and Wallace strode over to the door. He unlocked it and peeked outside. “All clear,” he said.

Unsteady again, my legs sore, my pussy throbbing, my panties soaked, I clicked to the hallway and looked quickly up and down. Wallace slid his hand around my waist and over my crotch, leaned in and breathed: “I can’t wait to fuck you again,” as I left.

It sent shivers down my spine.

Just as I popped out of the bathroom, a man turned the corner of the hallway. His eyes raked over me, then went over my head to the door, and he grinned.

I wondered briefly what he’d think when he saw Wallace in there, washing his hands.

But I was on to other things, and I was too hotted up to care about the embarrassing fact that I’d just been caught sneaking out of the boys’ room – a nearly 40-year old woman with two kids.

Jesus.

When I reached the turn at the end of the hallway, I looked back, and the guy gave me a quick smile. He had opened the door and seen Wallace, and the whole story (well, maybe not the *whole* story) was clear to him.

The look he gave me, curiously enough, sent a thrill through me.

And that’s when it hit me: the feeling that was creeping all over me when that guy looked at me, when I was pressed against the wall in a public bathroom looking at the door lock and hoping it would hold, when I was standing too close to Wallace backstage where anyone could see me – the feeling was uncomfortable because it was unfamiliar, but not because it was a bad feeling.

All along, I had been mistaking it for guilt, mistaking it for a feeling I didn’t like.

As I turned the corner and went into the restaurant, it was like the whole place was lit up with a different kind of glow. Like being high, even if that was something I didn’t know anything about. The dishes clanked more crisply, the waiters seemed hotter, the lights twinkled with a particularly pretty glow. I felt like my feet weren’t touching the ground.

I caught a glimpse of myself in the mirror, and I looked *hot*. Not like the frumpy mom I’d been for so long, not like a mom at all. I felt liberated

from that image, liberated from that person.

I was a slinky woman in a black dress, with mussed hair, because I'd just done something very naughty in the bathroom. I was the woman this table full of guys were turning around in their seats to look at.

I winked at one of them, and it sent a thrill through me again.

My eyes floated over the scene until I found Luke.

You might have thought that seeing him was going to kill the vibe I had going on, but in truth it didn't. I was on far too much of a high for that. It's like my body was getting taken over by another person, except it wasn't a totally different person. It was a "me" from a long time ago, a "me" that never had the chance to exist. A "me" that had wrapped herself up in a cocoon 17 years ago and could finally come out.

I slid into the booth across from Luke, and I didn't even try to hide my excitement. Somehow, the guilt I'd been feeling (about the first night with Wallace, about the dirty things I had been doing alone and thinking when I was with Luke) had evaporated.

I could see that Luke knew something had changed. He opened his mouth to say something, but he was too transfixed by my change in demeanor, I could see, to get the words out of his mouth.

I grinned, summoning all of my *femme fatale* roles, leaning across the table to take his hand. Except they didn't feel like roles any more. It felt like being myself.

My real self.

I took Luke's hand, and he continued to stare at me, astonished.

I kissed his fingertips, but not in a friendly, married-people kind of a way.

I did it in a very deliberately sexual way, and I was pleased as I watched the reaction ripple through him. I met his eyes and grinned.

Then I had an idea, and I acted on it as soon as I had it.

I scooted over to him, sliding along the booth, my thighs sticking to the leather. Just to be sure that Luke was on the same page as me, I slid my hand over his thigh. His cock was hard; I gave the shape of it a good feel and a squeeze.

And then I told him my idea.

CHAPTER 21

Luke

To say that Lisa was transformed after she went into the bathroom with Wallace was an understatement.

She had obviously made some effort to fix herself back up, but that didn't change the fact that her hair was decidedly looser, strands of it flowing in the breeze she was creating as she walked back to the booth.

But it was the *way* she walked. Taller, chin jutting out, eyes big and wet and taking in the whole room like she'd taken mountains of X back there.

I almost asked her if she had.

And then she slid into the booth, did something to my fingertips with her mouth, slid over to me and grabbed my cock.

Her words shaved years off my life as she whispered into my neck, just below my earlobe:

"I have a pussy full of his cum, and I want you to feel it."

My eyes moved all over the restaurant. I felt like everyone was looking at us, and that was probably only partially true. They were probably looking at Lisa, her slim figure in her black dress, the way she was linking her arm around mine and cozying up to me. She was acting like a teenager in an adult's body, and it was fairly obscene.

But I didn't make a move to stop her. After all, I had been sitting there burning up, my cock hard as rock, my stomach turning like the tide... one minute sick, the next full of aching desire.

Lisa's fingers were working on my belt, slowly sliding the leather through the buckle. She had turned her head to look out into the restaurant, as though she were just sitting there, thinking, next to me.

The waitress appeared. She had come by earlier to ask about dinner, and I had ordered something. I couldn't remember for the life of me now what that had been. Her mouth was moving and I was staring at her.

Lisa's fingers were sliding my zipper down, and that was all I could feel or think about.

"Hmm," Lisa said. "Well, in that case... I'll just have whatever he had."

The waitress looked confused. "A filet mignon?"

Lisa's fingers raked the open zipper of my pants, and I heard the *tic-tic-tic-tic* as though it were jackhammer in the room.

"That'd be great," Lisa said. "Rare."

"And what kind of -"

"You know what," Lisa said. "I like everything exactly like he does. So just, double the order. All the same."

The waitress seemed confounded, but she nodded and left.

Lisa's hand, warm and dry, slipped into my boxers.

The restaurant, luckily enough, was fancy enough to have a tablecloth covering up what she was doing for the people sitting thankfully on the other side of a very large walkway and facing the opposite direction. And anyone else who might see that Lisa was digging into my pants, deeper and deeper, her finger hot and playful.

I sucked in my breath when she scraped my balls.

Lisa suddenly produced her phone from her purse. I had been so distracted I didn't hear it buzz. She opened her messenger while holding the phone up so I could see. She seemed to know that the message would be from Wallace.

[WB]: *that was hot*

[WB]: *tell me u can get away tomorrow for lunch*

My cock throbbed in Lisa's hand, and she grinned as her hand swept quickly over her screen.

[Me]: *when and where?*

Then she looked at me, and smiled devilishly. "Should I write something even more.. you know? Dirty?"

"Like what?" I breathed. Her fingers were driving me wild and my cock felt like it was going to burst.

She shrugged. Her screen lit up with Wallace's message, but she was already leaning toward me and her teeth sank lightly into my lip. She ran her tongue along my upper lip, and the tickle of it turned to fire and went straight to my aching cock. She squeezed me back, smiling. "I don't know," she said. "Something like, I want to try something new with you..."

I could barely keep myself together. “Like... like what?”

Lisa turned her head and placed her lips close to my ear. “I want him to fuck me in the ass,” she whispered.

Oh God. My stomach went cold, my balls turned to fire. My cock jerked wildly in her hand. She turned her attention back to her phone while I tried to compose myself. I could feel sweat pouring from my temples. Lisa continued to massage my cock while she typed. I read the screen.

[WB]: *my place. I work from home tomorrow. Come over when you can get away*

And Lisa’s response:

[Me]: *hmm. How about the evening? I can skip class.*

Lisa mused out loud, setting the phone face-down on the table. “It just seems like more of an evening activity.”

I sucked in my breath sharply again and squirmed in my seat.

“So,” Lisa said, taking a sip of her wine and sliding her hand from my pants at the same time. She was looking ahead of her, like she was telling me something boring about the weather. “I’m going to go back to the ladies’ room right now.” She turned toward me. “I think you should follow. Maybe in a minute or so?”

My mouth fell open. But there was no time to discuss anything, or protest, or think about the plan, because Lisa was scooting around the booth already. She mouthed: “See you there,” stood up, and disappeared in swish of her little black dress.

The minute I waited, fumbling to gracefully zip up my pants and organize my cock enough to walk with some dignity to the bathroom, seemed to last an eternity.

Then I stood up, and practically ran to where my wife had turned the corner.

The hallway was long, turned several times, and after a bit I was worried I would end up in the kitchen, looking like fool with a big erection and nowhere to go.

Then I turned and saw the bathroom doors, and Lisa, leaning against the wall, holding her phone. She was typing something, probably to

Wallace. She lifted her eyes lazily and motioned for me to come and stand next to her between the men's and ladies.'

"Someone's in there," she said. So just look like we're talking. And then we'll go in."

Who was this woman? I wondered.

She slipped her phone into her purse, and then she looked around the hallway. Her eyes were on fire with a deviousness I could remember seeing in her long ago, long before any of this had ever happened. I felt the same rush of excitement I had felt then, back when I first met her: this girl, her face said, can get a little wild.

I stared, mesmerized and frankly a little afraid of what I'd created, as Lisa shimmied her panties down her legs – right there in the hallway – and stepped out of them.

We both started, as a woman came around the corner and walked toward the bathroom. Lisa leaned calmly against the wall, her eyes locked with mine and full of mischief. The panties were still hooked around the heel of her shoe, wet and perfumed with her sex. I could tell Lisa was close to losing it as the woman walked by, and when she entered the bathroom, Lisa covered her mouth and leaned heavily on my shoulder, a wet snort escaping her nose. Then she bent over and picked the panties up, to stuff them into her purse.

I caught a whiff of the scent of her juices, mingled with Wallace's cum, and I started to feel dizzy.

Behind me, the bathroom door whomped open and closed, and Lisa took me by the hand and into the mens' bathroom.

I entered awkwardly, looking around, in a bit of a daze. Lisa locked the door behind me by leaning into my body.

"This is where we did it," she said, her voice sultry. Her breath raked over my lips and she brought her knee up to my crotch, pushing against my aching balls and my hard dick.

I was gripped by a feverish desire. The fact that we were in a public place flew out of my head and I lunged forward, turning Lisa around and pushing her over the counter in front of the mirror. She put her hands on the mirror, and looked at me through the reflection. I hiked her skirt up and stared at her bare ass, her dripping thighs, her engorged gash where Wallace had been just minutes before.

I unzipped my pants and wriggled out of my boxers. I lifted my gaze to meet her eyes in the mirror again. "Is this where you did it? Right here?"

I guided my cock to her pussy and rubbed the head on her clit. Lisa's face went red with pleasure, mingled with guilt, and she squirmed and pressed back against me. She was ready to go again, ready to have more cock inside of her, even after all that.

"We did it up against the wall," she said.

I raised my eyebrows.

Lisa's voice dropped to a whisper, but every one of her next words was clear as a bell:

"He held up me up with his fingers in my ass."

The picture crystallized in my mind, clear as her words: Wallace finger fucking her in time with the thrusts of his huge cock, stretching her holes open, taking my wife like a dirty slut in a bathroom.

I shoved myself inside of her. She was still full of Wallace's cum; it was warm, her juices were hot, and her flesh was tight but so wet that it felt loose. I heard a gush as I pressed in, and I felt the cum that had rushed out of her cunt roll down my balls as I pushed inside her until she nearly swallowed them up. Lisa squirmed.

"And you liked that, didn't you?" I said.

Lisa's mouth fell open as I slowly sawed at her pussy.

"Didn't you? You liked that big black cock in your pussy and his fingers in your ass, fucking you like a little whore."

My filthy talking was going to send me over the edge if I wasn't careful. I clenched my ass and leaned forward to push back against the rising climax that was threatening to burst.

Lisa's mouth quivered. "I loved it," she said.

I grabbed her hips and started to pound into her, no longer caring if I came before she did. I couldn't control myself, and anyway she was so ripe and filthy I knew she would be fine. "You dirty little slut," I growled.

I heard Lisa moan as I fucked her hard and good, my cock sloshing in Wallace's cum, her own juices welling up and spilling down my thighs and onto the bunched up pants and boxers at my knees.

I started to go over the edge, and I looked up from Lisa's ass, which I had been watching as I hammered her, thinking of Wallace's big fingers digging into her ass. When I looked Lisa in the eye, and she saw that I was going to explode in her pussy, she gave me a sultry grin.

I yelled, not able to stop myself. I looked down and groaned as my seed spilled into Lisa.

She continued to bounce up and down the length of my shaft, her hands sliding down the mirror, her eyes still locked on my face. She was still smiling up to the moment that her orgasm overtook her. Her pussy clenched hard around my cock and made me almost jump. She screwed up her face and expelled a sharp gust of air as her legs turned to jello and trembled against my thighs. Around my cock her pussy felt like it was being electrocuted, it shook and trembled so much.

Lisa's head was hanging down as we panted, spent, trying to recover.

She lifted her head, and looked at me in the mirror. My mouth was open and I had a flabbergasted expression on my face.

Lisa grinned again, and reached back to push me away. My cock flopped out of her and she stood up, straightening her dress, pulling it down and over her ass.

"Well," she said. "That was something."

My heart was beating so fast I couldn't catch my breath. So I just gave her a smile.

She went into a stall while I stood there fumbling with my pants. My ears were ringing, and I felt like I was having an out-of-body experience.

She led the way out of the bathroom, back to our booth, then she paid the bill and led us to the car, as all while I stared at the world around me in a kind of a daze. Stared at her, as though I was seeing her for the first time.

Because it was amazing, incredible, everything I'd ever wanted, what had just happened.

But I also felt like I was on a runaway train, heading into a dark tunnel, and there was no way I could stop it.

Lisa shook her blonde hair and flirted with a waiter as we left, and it seemed her ass had more shake to it, like she was a foot taller. Men were turning their heads to look at her – more than they had just hours before. Because now she radiated something, something was different.

It was terrifying.

Lisa was terrifying.

CHAPTER 22

Lisa

I knew it was getting out of control as soon as I came in the bathroom with Luke.

Well, scratch that: seconds after I came in the bathroom, and I started planning my next adventure with Wallace.

That wasn't me, thinking about sex so much. Thinking about sex at all really wasn't me.

And thinking about it in the dirtiest ways possible, thinking about how I could make another dangerous night like that night at the restaurant happen again.

I had loved doing something naughty. And then I had loved how wild it drove Luke.

But it was out of control, and there was an element of it I didn't like too much. I didn't like that Luke looked slightly frightened of me – and that I didn't much care. I cared, sure, somewhere deep inside. But I didn't care enough to stop. I didn't care enough to dare to ask him what he was feeling, because I didn't want him to say something like: "I think we need to slow this down."

So I pretended I didn't notice.

I told myself if he really wanted to put the brakes on he could grow a pair and just say it.

That's how out of control I was.

And then there was the element of just how carnal it was. I wasn't thinking about going on a date with Wallace, or having some kind of sensual sexual encounter with him where we drank wine and went out to dinner and he seduced me with some Barry White before we got it on.

No. I was planning an evening where he twisted my hands into my panties the moment I walked through the door, and then pushed me down onto his cock to get it hard with my mouth before he bent me over on his bed and filled my ass.

It was like my personality had split in two. There was Lisa-Lisa, who was horrified by the things I was thinking. I mean, truly I can be kind of a prude. I was a mom, for frack's sake. I didn't even cuss that much. I was G-

rated fun, like if you needed someone to invigorate a game of charades or be really funny when she smoked a joint once every five years on New Year's Eve. I rode penny-horses at the grocery store and made people laugh by being a slapstick comedian.

I wasn't the kind of woman who craved getting fucked in the ass by a hot black man who wasn't my husband. Who craved it so much it was all I could think about.

But I couldn't stop. Not yet.

So I found myself in the bathroom in the morning, putting lipstick on for a morning class, while Luke stared at me in the mirror with the kind of miserable expression on his face that should have prompted me to ask him what was wrong. And instead of doing that, I said:

"Hey, find a way to tell Wallace you're going to have a guys' night out sometime this week." I traced the lipstick seductively, making as much sexual innuendo as I could out of the way that I smeared it on my lips. I did such a good job that I got myself worked up, thinking about Wallace's cock smearing his precum over my lips. "And then that way, we can hook up. Maybe Wednesday?"

I was wearing the full lingerie set he had purchased for me, so that the bra half got some use. I knew he had a nice view of my butt, framed by the lace, and the bra really pushed my breasts out into two plump and enticing pillows.

I primped my hair and trotted past him, and I could see that he was being torn in two by his discomfort and his arousal. It should have bothered me, but I had a fever. I ignored it, and I slipped into the closet to dig out a tight pair of jeans and a tight black shirt. Then I slipped into the high heels I had bought and stepped out of the closet.

I glanced in the mirror. I looked great, I had to say. I *felt* great.

"Are you seeing him today?" Luke said, his eyes traveling up and down my body.

I wasn't. I couldn't even say what was inspiring me to dress like that, to get lipstick on and wear heels, except that I felt a resurgence of power inside of me. I was enjoying having two men wrapped around my finger, and that power was making me a little greedy. Why not more? I still had it, after all. Now I knew it.

"Not that I know of," I said. I leaned over Luke and put my hands on his thighs. Then I slid them closer, in toward his cock. I could see the two

forces inside him fighting, see it playing out on his face. But my fingers found his hard cock along the length of his thigh, and it trembled when I touched it. Then it leaped to life when I whispered in his ear: “But I can, if you want me to.”

Luke sucked his breath in, and gave me a grin. “I’ll tell him about boys’ night,” he said.

He sounded only 75% certain that he wanted to actually do that. But I smiled at him and sauntered out of the room.

Most of the time, that’s how I felt.

Every now and then, though, an attack of guilt would grip me. Like when I was driving that day, and I looked down at the wedding band on my finger. The diamond that Luke had saved so hard to buy, because he had wanted something that would remind me that he loved me even when times were tough.

My heart sank, right through my feet. What were we doing?

But then I thought:

Luke had suggested this. Luke was on board with this.

Luke wanted me to have this.

And that’s how the monster inside of me tamed my conscience.

CHAPTER 23

Luke

I wanted it to be over, I realized, after Lisa left.

But it wasn't.

I drove to work in a daze and locked myself in my office, staring at the computer without remembering to turn in on for an hour. My phone rang and messages piled up. Finally, Tom stopped by and banged on the door, and I was shaken from my reverie.

"Oh," Tom sneered. "So you're not dead in here. I need that report on White Store, like, yesterday."

I had to work for a while, because I didn't have that report on White Store ready at all. I spaced my way through a meeting, feeling like the world was dragging me down, down, into a pit of chaos.

At moments, I was high. These were the moments when I thought about Lisa at the restaurant, Lisa being wild in bed and excited and... what was the word for it? Re-animated. It was like we'd been zombies for the past ten years (or more), and suddenly we were cured. The look in her eyes when she got her devious ideas, the excitement that coursed inside her body when we had sex. This was all very good.

But then fear would grip me and drag me down into a state of despair.

I felt like Lisa was spinning off into another orbit. I didn't have any control over her. Maybe she was too wild, too much to handle now.

Did I want to be married to a woman like the woman from the restaurant?

Did I really want Lisa strutting around in high heels, feeling like she could have sex with other men if she wanted to? Believing that I wanted her to?

I clutched my stomach. "Ugh," I said. "I feel sick."

"You look pale," Rita Heller agreed, as I stood up to leave the meeting.

I *did* look pale, I discovered, when I got to the men's room. I felt pale. I felt ill.

I needed to get myself under control. First me, then Lisa.

I needed to put the brakes on things. Lisa would just have to deal with that.

But was that fair? I wondered. Was it fair to have pushed Lisa into this, to have gotten off on it as much as I did, and then to tell her she couldn't have what she wanted, now that *I* felt like it was out of control?

Also, there was her idea.

Arousal started to work its way into my body and clamp down on my cock.

Did I want my wife to be defiled like that? It seemed I did.

And I didn't.

I washed my face.

Small steps, I thought.

Okay.

I'd just fail to set up this "boys' night" on Wednesday. I'd just buy myself some time to think about things, for Lisa to simmer down, for her affair to proceed more slowly.

That was easily done, and it would give us both time to think. Because everything was moving way too fast for me.

I left the bathroom and went to my office.

Ah life.

Life has a funny way of sneaking up on you. Momentum, it would seem, had already built up, and we were going to go off the rails no matter what I did.

I re-read the email thirty times, not sure it was a joke.

Re: White Store

Luke,

WS's VP in resources is spooked about delays on the new Hamilton area research and responses to the Concord thing. Need you on site to smooth things over Wed.

Carol has your info will be in touch with flight/hotel ASAP

Jim

In many ways, it was my own fault. White Store was spooked because I hadn't done my work because I was busy thinking about my wife

fucking Wallace Brown. And now because White Store was spooked, the universe had just delivered my wife, another chance to fuck Wallace Brown. A perfect opportunity for her to be alone, in town, without me. Wallace would be able to confirm it easily, and besides it being perfect – so perfect, I couldn't have made it happen if I tried – there was next to no way out of it.

No way out.

Sure, I could tell Lisa that this was just a coincidence that had happened right after I had decided to put the brakes on things, so could she please not run off and have sex with Wallace again.

I could do that.

But I knew, as I typed my response into the computer with dread coating my insides like an oil slick, that I wasn't going to do that.

Deep down inside, I was afraid to ask Lisa for something like that.

Because deep down inside, I was afraid she wouldn't listen to me. I was afraid of that woman I had fucked in the bathroom.

Afraid of the monster I'd created.

Crushing as it would be to let her go fuck Wallace again, at least I could tell myself that I was *letting* her do it, if I kept up the charade that I was actively making it happen.

So I wrote a message to Lisa.

[Me]: *I did you one even better. Ill be out of town on Wed for a client meeting*

When I pressed send, I felt like I was sinking my thumb right into my own heart.

I was pretty sure this wasn't what I wanted anymore.

But hey, at least I *looked* like I had things under control.

CHAPTER 24

Lisa

I went shopping in the middle of the day on Wednesday, deciding that I wanted something more risqué than what I had. I needed a casual dress for a Wednesday night rendezvous.

I ended up buying new lingerie, a rust-colored dress that hugged my figure from thigh to top and swung low on my breasts. Then I had no choice but to buy a new pair of shoes. I spent wildly, blindly, without talking to Luke about it first.

But why talk to him about it? He was the one who was making all of this possible. He had even planned to be out of town, to really add a realistic factor to the “affair” I was having.

Wallace seemed to want to go out to dinner or something, but I preferred things happened much the same way they had before. There was something missing from our interactions – the barbecue had been the exception – that made it hard for me to “hang out” with him. Maybe it was me. Maybe I didn’t want to get into any real conversation.

I also had a plan for letting Luke at least get in on some of the action, but it required me setting it up in the room ahead of time. I didn’t want Wallace at my house, so I told him I’d booked a hotel room downtown. He didn’t really question it (this all happened in a series of texts), so I didn’t have to provide any elaborate explanation.

I did, however, lie to him and tell him I wouldn’t be there until eight. And then I went downstairs to the hotel bar and ordered two drinks.

I enjoyed that scene for a little while. The same way I had enjoyed the restaurant. All eyes were on me, and I looked good. I was getting high on my power to attract men, a power I’d kept buried and hidden inside of myself for so long that I had forgotten I even had it. It was intoxicating.

But Wallace texted me that he was on his way, and so I reluctantly left the bar, where a young-looking businessman was giving me the eye and looking like he was going to come and talk to me.

I went to the room, and called Luke.

Luke was in Brighton, a suburban hell of strip malls. He answered breathlessly. I enjoyed how he sounded: hooked, excited, as hungry to hear

from me as I was to do something wild.

“What took you so long?” Luke asked.

“I was at the bar,” I said, impatiently. “He’s coming soon. I’m going to put the phone in here, so make sure you’re on mute, okay?”

I couldn’t believe myself, what I was saying, the fact that I was saying it with such glee. I was obsessed. Obsessed with my plan, obsessed with Wallace, obsessed with my needs. I wasn’t even thinking about poor Luke, I’ll admit. Except for how I could place the phone so that my husband could hear me doing this very naughty, very dirty thing with Wallace.

“Okay, so... I’m going to put it down now,” I said.

“Okay...” Luke’s voice sounded uncertain.

I didn’t want to give him a chance to back out. “I love you,” I said quickly.

“I love you, too -”

He wanted to say something else, I knew he did. But I held the phone away from me, setting it against the wall next to a dresser. “Can you hear me?” I said.

There was a pause. “Yeah...”

“Okay,” I said.

There was a knock at the door.

“Mute the phone,” I hissed. And then, as an afterthought: “I love you.”

I was out of control, but that’s what happened.

I opened the door for him, wearing my dress and my new shoes. Suddenly, having gone shopping for a new dress seemed ridiculous, because I was just in it for the sex and I would have my clothes off in a matter of seconds.

Wallace looked me up and down, and I could see that even he was a little surprised by me. He had the same look on his face that Luke had: mildly fearful, a little amazed, aroused. He stepped toward me and I pulled him forward by the shoulder. I wanted to make it clear that there was no need to dance around what was going on here.

My mind went briefly to the phone, hoping it was okay, hoping it was still on. The idea that Luke was on the other end of that call somewhere, sweating in the dark, listening to what was happening in this room, the

sounds slightly muffled and teasing him more than anything – it drove me even wilder.

Wallace kissed me and I tried to make sure that our kisses were wet and loud. I pulled him toward the bed and started to unbutton his shirt as I did.

“Well, well, Miss Healy, you sure don’t waste any time.”

I ran my tongue along his upper lip. Man, I was feeling *bold*. It almost felt like another person had taken over my body. I could already sense that I was about to say things that I never would have said, do things I just never *did*.

“I have something I want from you tonight,” I purred in his ear, and as I did I moved my hand between his belt and his smooth, hard abdomen right into his boxers, where I found his big cock hard and ready. I wrapped my fingers around it, and for a second I felt a jolt of fear.

There was still time to back out of my idea, to never tell him what it was I had “planned” and not have to try and get this whole thick column in my ass.

But just thinking about it made me ache with a craving I had never felt before.

Wallace looked amused as I looked into his eyes. “Mmm,” he said. “And what’s that?”

I pulled him closer to the bed, and I climbed onto my knees and walked backward, pulling him with by his cock. I wanted to be close enough to the phone so that maybe Luke could hear what I was going to say next.

I lowered myself onto the bed, my legs on either side of me. I still had the heels on, because I knew it gave me a sluttier look, and that’s exactly what I wanted. I could see that Wallace appreciated it. His cock flexed in my hand.

“There’s something I’ve never done before,” I said. I was surprised by how steady my voice was.

Of course, I am a good actress. Maybe that’s why this was so easy.

My hand was working on his zipper and his belt, trying to undo his pants while I gripped his cock in the palm of my other.

“Something new,” Wallace said, after pressing his lips together. “And what would that be?”

I freed his cock and slid my legs back so that I could get down low, and get my mouth close to him. His musky scent filled my nostrils and sent a shudder through me. I stared at his cock, the length and thickness of it, the dark veins that sprawled across it. I turned my head and ran my lips along the length of shaft while I looked up at him.

As I moved my mouth over his dick, which was smooth and dry and let my lips slide easily over his velvet skin, I said:

“I’ve always wanted someone to take me... you know... from behind.”

Like I said, I wasn’t much of a cusser. It was going to take a minute or two for me to start throwing out all the dirty words, even if those two shots I’d done *had* gone to my head a little.

Wallace didn’t look shocked – he was more excited than anything - though his eyebrows did go up a little. He dropped a hand to my hair and raked his fingers through it gently, sending a shiver down my spine.

“Well, well, well,” he said. “Aren’t you a dirty girl?”

I knew Luke could hear *that*.

I pursed my lips and kissed his cock. Then I made a circle around the crown of his dick with my tongue, pleased that my suggestion had squeezed a drop of pearly white precum from the center of his head. “Can you help me with that?” I said. I took his head into my mouth and sucked on it, and the bitter taste of his cum filled my mouth. So unlike the taste of Luke, even though it was so much the same.

“Oh, I can do it,” Wallace growled.

I was wildly turned on by then.

I rose up to my knees and slipped my dress up and over my head. I tossed it aside and let Wallace take in my new lingerie. His eyes took a long, lustful walk over my body, eating me alive. There was nothing tender in his expression as he did this: he was a wolf and I was Little Red Riding Hood, and he was going to have me however he wanted.

And that’s the look I wanted.

I turned around and lowered my body onto the bed, lifting my hips and pushing my bottom up toward him. I knew the lacy half-thong disappeared into the crack of my ass, bright red where my gash was, and that the view was spectacular. I loved the feeling of bending over, offering myself to him, letting a dominating man take the lead and do with me as he pleased while I lay there in a submissive position.

Wallace kneaded my ass for a few moments, his big hands squeezing my flesh, softly at first and then with a firmness that seemed to be designed to send me a message: my ass was his, and he could do what he wanted with it. He drew his finger along the lacy lingerie between my legs, from my clit to my asshole, applying just enough pressure to make the lace scrape against my skin delightfully. He did this until I was moaning lightly with pleasure, aching for him to pull the panties away and expose my dripping cunt and the little hole I wanted him to fill.

I curled my hands into the sheets and tried to stay still.

At last, he hooked his fingers under the lace of my panties and I felt them sliding over my hips, down my thighs, and to the middle of my upper legs. Wallace pushed my legs together with his knees, and then he closed one hand around them, squeezing my ankles together firmly, and pressing them into the bed with a little shove.

“Leave your legs like that till I tell you otherwise,” he said. His voice left no room for dissent. I obeyed him, crossing my ankles.

He put his hands on my buttocks and pulled them apart, spreading my cheeks wide open and exposing my ass. He made a slow circle around my anus with his thumb, driving me wild. Again and again, his finger still dry, my anus still dry and soft. My breath became ragged and I moaned again.

Wallace cracked an open palm against my ass, sending a sharp sting through my bottom that made me gasp when I moved my hips. “Stay put,” Wallace commanded. “Just keep that ass right where it is.”

I obeyed him again, the pleasure of submitting making my pussy well up with liquid pleasure.

“You got a plan, little girl?” Wallace said, sliding his thumb into the folds of my slit, brushing over my clit and making me shudder. “You ever done this before?”

He moved his finger back up to the ring of my anus, and I shook my head. I *did* have a plan, in a way, that’s why I had practiced for this moment. But it was too much to explain, and I didn’t want to take the lead.

He moved his finger over my anus with more insistence now, pushing against it slightly without entering. The ache inside me ballooned, getting more insistent. But I knew I had a long way to go.

Wallace teased me like this a few more times, drawing what seemed like endless waves of my own juices from my pussy to my ass, until the

entire valley between my buttocks was wet and slimy, and his fingers moved with ease over the slickness on my eyelet.

He dipped his fingers into the hole of my cunt at last. They were warm and hard, and he slipped in two at the same time. The pressure of his hand pushed outward, slightly unsatisfying. He turned his hand around inside of me, and then when he was deep inside he curled his fingers outward toward the base of my clit to get me to mewl. I bit into the edge of a pillow to keep myself from moving my hips, and I balled up the sheets in my hands.

I had forgotten about Luke, and in that moment I remembered him. That he might be listening, that he would have heard the sounds that Wallace was wringing from my body. My pussy clenched around Wallace's fingers, and he made a low sound of approval.

Then he pulled his fingers from inside of my pussy and drew them up to my ass.

He didn't play with my ass this time; he pushed his forefinger in abruptly and I felt my eyelet clench around him. But the slick juices that coated his finger propelled him forward anyway, with a slightly sharp sting. My eyes watered and then I took a deep breath and remembered the experience I had given myself.

"Relax," Wallace said, but before the word had even left his mouth I was already pushing out, and I felt my body blossom open for him. His finger sank inside of me, and he made another low rumble of approval. "That's it." He began to slide his finger in and out of my ass. "You're a natural, aren't you? You like it. Some girls are just like that. That's good."

He finger-fucked me like that for a few moments, and then he slipped in his second finger.

"Oh!" I said, and involuntarily raised my head. The additional pressure came suddenly and it stretched me wide. My ass seized up around his fingers again and I had to concentrate to relax a second time.

"There you go," Wallace said, as I disintegrated into a puddle of moaning. The stretching of my anus and the dull, throbbing pleasure of his fingers inside of me, not quite satisfying the ache I had, were making my pussy overflow with excitement.

Wallace turned his fingers in my ass, much the way he had before, and I thought he was going to plunge his cock into my pussy as he leaned forward.

Instead, he pulled up on the gap of my hole, stretching the top of my ass and making me mewl again. I felt a third finger bat the lower part of my rim, sliding in. The stretch made me howl, but this time I was ready for it and I relaxed. His fingers wriggled into me, and then he began to pull outward, opening me up, stretching me wide.

The craving I had was to feel myself filled, but I knew that he needed to get my ring loosened up, relaxed. Once I was pried open, he would be able to fit his enormous girth inside of me.

I felt a warm wet drop in the center of my ass, a place where I had never felt anything before. It took me a moment to realize that he had let a large glob of spit fall into my stretched-open ass.

The humiliation of it was powerfully erotic. I closed my eyes and let the sensation of the next glob of spit swell over me, wrapping me up in the perverse pleasure of being made to submit utterly to the most base and animal of sexual gestures.

Wallace put a hand on my lower back and then grumbled. "Okay get up on your hands, but keep your back arched, keep your ass turned up so I can get at it."

I obeyed him again, contorting my body into the position he desired.

"I'm gonna fuck your pussy till my cock is nice and wet," he said.

I felt the blunt crown of his cock against my pussy, and then the fat length of it sliding in, slipping right into me. His fingers pulled on my ass, stretching me open further. "Oh fuck," Wallace breathed. "Your ass is so hot, that's gonna feel so good around my cock."

He was slowly fucking me in the pussy, getting his shaft wet in all the cum I was spewing. Another drop of spit landed in my ass and made me twist in pleasure. Wallace pressed outward with his thumb and made my insides ache. "Don't move. You just take what I give and you do what I say."

He fucked me a little longer, and then he slowly pulled out of my pussy. At the same time, I felt his fingers pull out, with a final stretch, before they slid from inside my ass.

His cock was pressed against the slightly-stretched hole immediately after that. My ringlet was quickly shrinking, squeezing the very tip of his crown, sliding up the dome of it. I started to worry that he wasn't going to take advantage of the stretching he had done -because that was the part that

was hard, the part that hurt. But almost immediately, he began to move forward.

I closed my eyes and my mouth fell open. I reminded myself to push out, and it worked like a charm. I could feel myself stretching, yawning open to accommodate Wallace's member.

That didn't mean it wasn't painful. "Oh!" I said. "Wait." I was panting with the effort of relaxing, of staying calm as he kept entering me, stretching me further than I had even thought possible.

It hurt, but the ache was good. It was scratching an itch I hadn't known I had.

Wallace slowed down, but he kept going. "You can do it," he said. "There you go, you're all stretched out. Now you're just gonna relax and take all that cock."

Inch by inch, he moved forward, and he kept filling me. I stretched from the inside out, and just when I thought I was as full as I could get, he kept going in. It was only when I felt his balls slip into the lips of my drenched pussy that I realized I had been making a long, strangled whine the entire time.

I leaned my head back. Sweat had gathered on my temples and the back of my neck.

And the most erotic ache I had ever felt was throbbing in my ass.

Wallace's thick black cock was inside of me. And it felt better than I had even imagined.

"You ready to take it?" he said, as if reading my mind.

I lowered my chest to the sheets to answer his question.

He started to fuck me. For a few moments it was the only thing I could think about. The movement of his cock in and out of my ass, the hard ache when he slammed into me, the fullness when he was at the deepest part of his thrust. The emptiness that went rushing through me like a receding tide as he pulled out. The return of the fullness. Over and over again.

He went slow at first, but then he began to hammer into me. My ass started to get sore, but that, too, felt good. I was sobbing and moaning in pleasure on the sheets.

I brought a hand between my legs when I thought I couldn't take it anymore and Wallace was about to come. I found my clit with my fingers, my body sliding up to the headboard with the power of Wallace's thrusts. It

took only a few strokes of the tip of my finger over my clit to make myself come.

The muscles in my ass spasmed around Wallace's cock. "Oh yeah, baby, that's right." He kept fucking me as I moaned and twisted on the bed, and rode to the height of my climax and back down.

But Wallace was still fucking me.

"Oh," I moaned, and I started to push up.

"Is your ass getting sore, little girl?"

I didn't say anything, just murmured something.

"Let me hear you say it," he said. "Let me hear you say your ass is sore."

I bit my thumbnail. "My ass is so sore," I said. His cock flexed inside me.

"You want me to come so you can take a break?" Wallace growled.

"Yes," I said.

I was starting to get hotted up again, the way he was talking to me.

"Let me hear you beg me then, baby. Beg Wallace for a big load of cum in your ass."

The words came as naturally to me as if I had been a porn star my whole life. "Please," I whined. I really did want him to come; I wanted to feel it and my ass was getting sore, even as much as I was enjoying it.

"Please, I want a big load of cum in my ass."

Wallace kept sawing at my ass. "You can do better than that,"

"I want a big load of cum, please. I want you to fill my ass up with cum."

Wallace growled. "More."

"I want you to pound that cum into my ass!" I said.

"That's it. Keep talkin. Keep begging me for my cum."

"Please, I want to feel your cum explode in my ass. I want you to pound it into me until it's dribbling out of my mouth."

That one sent him over the edge. In my own mind, I was actually scandalized by having said something so perfectly filthy. Worse yet, I was imagining it in my own mind.

What? I saw it once in an erotic cartoon. I never expected to *say* something like that.

Wallace drove his cock deep inside of me and grabbed me by the hips to grind his dick hard into me as his cum exploded, hot and wet and like

nothing I had ever felt before, deep inside my ass.

I hurried to pinch my clit until I came again, my fingers sloshing in my sopping cunt.

Wallace stayed inside of me, and his cock pulsed and stretched my asshole, and I both desperately wanted him to pull out and to stay in. I came again and screamed into the pillow, and Wallace murmured, “Jesus,” before slowly pulling out of me and rolling onto his back.

CHAPTER 25

Luke

I was miles away, too far away to do anything to stop the nightmare that I was hearing on my phone. I was holding it up in my palm, the light glowing in the darkening hotel room.

I could hear Lisa's voice, and the low rumble of Wallace's as he commanded my wife to do unthinkably filthy acts. Even though I couldn't catch every word, it was obvious from the squealing and the panting that Lisa was letting Wallace fuck her in the ass.

And that she liked it.

I was left to picture the scene for myself, with only the dirty talk and the sweaty slapping of Wallace's thighs against Lisa's ass echoing in the otherwise silent room. But I made a pretty clear picture of it in my mind: the length of Wallace's enormous cock sinking slowly into Lisa's ass. Lisa bent over, her skin as pale as the sheets, her hair sweaty and clinging to her neck as Wallace Brown manhandled her. I could see his big hands on her hips, his fingers indenting her flesh as he gripped her hard and pummeled his cock into her.

And then when Lisa started begging him, all of that filthy trash falling out of her mouth, I almost lost it.

I was in my boxers, and I wriggled free of them and leaned back on the bed to get my hand around my cock as I listened to my wife put on the greatest act I had ever heard: that of a filthy, dirty whore.

At some point I dropped the phone. The sounds of Lisa and Wallace coming were muffled by the sheets, and then I was also tipping over the edge.

When I sat up and snatched the phone, hoping to listen in on their pillow talk, the call had been disconnected.

I stared at the screen.

My abdomen went cold again, this time with a kind of despair.

Lisa's performance with Wallace had been hot as hell, and I couldn't deny that I loved every minute of it. The gut-wrenching pain of listening to Lisa be humiliated and ass-fucked was still ringing in my ears, throbbing in my balls, erotic and dark.

But another pain was spreading out inside my body.

Had we gone too far? I could still hear Lisa's moans and the shriek that she gave when she came. Would I be able to satisfy her again? Was this the way she wanted to be fucked? I wasn't sure I could do it like that. It wasn't just that I wasn't a muscled, well-endowed black man. It was that I just couldn't bring myself to use Lisa sexually that way.

My stomach twisted again.

And now there was nothing I could do but wait. Wait for the night to be over. Wait until Lisa called me, until we saw each other again.

Would they have sex all night, I wondered? Would she let him fuck her again in the ass, or would they get up to something even filthier?

And when I did see Lisa, would she be thinking of how inadequate I was? Or would she only be thinking of her next night with Wallace?

What the hell had we done?

I paced the room, then I broke into the mini-bar and drank pretty much the equivalent of the cost of the room, until I was bleary-eyed and unreasonable. I kept checking my phone, looking for a message or a call from Lisa, swiping through pictures of her from a time before we had done this wild thing.

I stared at a sweet picture of her in a field from about three autumns ago. She was wearing a rust-colored shirt and her golden hair had been caught in the light. She was smiling, holding a pumpkin she had declared to look just like Abraham Lincoln.

I touched the screen, and her face. Why had I been such an idiot all my life? I wondered drunkenly. Not to know that I had the perfect wife? Why had I risked her love and her loyalty in such a stupid, stupid way?

I lay down on the bed, my eyes getting wet with frustration and anger at myself. Thinking about what my life would be like if Lisa left me, if I had to live out my days knowing that she was gone because I'd been so stupid, so needy, so wanton, so greedy.

It was a less than glamorous end to my fantasy. I don't know what time I passed out, but I was still lying there with my dead phone in my hand when the morning light started shining right into my face, and I had to stumble around in a hurry to make check-out.

*

My flight was delayed, and I waited impatiently for my phone to charge at the airport, plugged into an obscure little outlet near the floor in an older part of the airport where they apparently still hadn't heard of technology.

There was nothing from Lisa, and by then it was almost eleven o'clock.

I wrote several versions of a text message before settling on:

[Me]: *Hey. My flight is delayed. Can you call me?*

But there was no answer.

I didn't want to seem like the paranoid, crazy man that I was, so I boarded the flight and tried to get some sleep (my head was pounding). But I could only think of Lisa, and whether or not she had run off with Wallace and left me for good.

Or that perhaps this was the beginning of awful years of her having an affair with him, maybe even in secret.

My heart was racing and I was sweating. I hoped the guy next to me thought I was just afraid of flying. If only he knew he was sitting next to a man who had just let his wife go get fucked into a whore by a hot black man.

I realized about ten minutes before touchdown that Lisa had a dress rehearsal today, that this was the show she had gotten tickets for Wallace for. In all of this excitement I had completely forgotten that she was even in a play, or that it was the pretense under which she'd even begun her relationship with Wallace.

It made me feel better for a moment: in all likelihood she wasn't answering because she was busy all day.

I got in the car and cursed myself all the way to the office, where I needed to drop off a few things and gather some work to take home over the weekend (since I'd gotten very little done on my "trip"). It was so typical of me, again, to focus on myself. I had been so focused on my fantasy, and on Lisa complying with it, that I'd forgotten all about her having her own life outside of these things. I'd just actually completely forgotten about her classes, her play, her MFA... everything.

I was such a fucking jerk. Such an idiot.

It was about 3:45 when I arrived at the office, which was just a short jaunt from the airport. When I walked into the building, I made a right instead of a left at the double staircase in the grand lobby. Up the stairs, up another flight, down the hall, looking for Wallace.

I don't know what propelled me there, or what I had thought I was going to do when I got there. I just knew that I felt like I was suddenly made of steel. I was envisioning myself pushing the door to office open without knocking. Telling him to stay away from my wife. Maybe just giving him a steely stare. Perhaps I would get fired, but I no longer cared.

I pushed the door open without knocking, just like I had planned, and the guy in the office next to him stared at me, reaching for his phone the way people reach for a gun. I must have looked unhinged.

I looked around the empty office.

Then I yelled through the glass. "Where's Wallace Brown?"

"He's not in," the guy said, his face still contorted into a look of fear and confusion, hand on the phone. "He's not coming in today."

I left, turning down the hallway and heading back to my end of the building, without closing the door.

I had Wallace's number in my phone, and I almost called it. Then I decided better, and called Lisa. She didn't answer. I left a message asking her to call me, please.

I sat in my office, staring at the dark computer screen, my mind completely blank of what I had wanted to do or get.

My phone never rang.

After the initial rush that had propelled me to Wallace's office, I had lost some of my swagger. Now I was too afraid to call him, too afraid to confront him on the phone.

I put my head in my hands.

You're going to lose your wife.

The thought punched me in the stomach.

I pushed my chair back, grabbed a few things hastily, and marched out to the car.

*

The play had already started by the time I found parking at the downtown campus, and then found out where the play was. It took another

round of questions to semi-interested campus rats to locate the building, and then I entered at the wrong end and had to run-walk through empty, half-lit corridors, my shoes squeaking obnoxiously on the floor, to find the auditorium.

I was surprised, as I flew through the doors, to find that the stage looked really professional and amazing (not the school-play setup I had envisioned) and that there was an audience of about fifty people scattered through the seats. It looked like the place would hold hundreds of people.

Lisa was not on stage. A few people glared back at me as the door clicked loudly shut. I put up my hands in apology and scrambled into a seat.

As my eyes adjusted to the dim light, I searched the room for Wallace. I was still looking for him when I heard Lisa's voice on stage.

She was wearing a wig of long brown hair, and dressed in a very ornate period dress. I was pretty far back, so it was hard to see her clearly, but from the moment she stepped on the stage, she captivated me.

I forgot, momentarily, that I was looking for Wallace.

I realized I hadn't seen Lisa in this element – which I was recalling at that moment, she frequently talked about and professed to love – in more than fifteen years. She hadn't been able to finish the degree she had wanted, or continue pursuing a career in acting, and I had never given much thought to how that must have felt for her. It had all happened in such a blur.

But here she was, almost forty, and she looked as young as any of the other students on stage. Her voice was clear and beautiful, echoing all over the theater. She had presence, gravitas. She was amazing.

I got sucked into the play, forgetting (mostly) about Wallace (the play was, after all, *Othello*, and there were some fairly steamy scenes with Lisa and her black male counterpart, who of course triggered thoughts about Wallace every time the two of them were together).

Occasionally, my stomach sank when I remembered why I was there, and I searched the audience again and again for Wallace. I didn't find him.

Maybe I had the date wrong.

The first act ended and an intermission was called. The audience shuffled out to the hallway.

I sat where I was, watching the audience shuffle out. I watched them shuffle back in.

No Wallace.

I sank back into my seat. My heart was pounding again and I felt I was going crazy. Wallace not being there was causing me to have an adrenaline crash.

I watched the rest of the play in a daze, my senses razoring into focus on Lisa when she was on stage, paranoid thoughts creeping in when she interacted with Othello. I sank into disturbing thoughts about what we had done, where we were going from here. I stared at her dress, at her pale skin, thinking about all the ways that the body hiding beneath those pretty fabrics had been defiled just the night before.

By the end of the play I had decided that I needed to tell Lisa to call it off. I needed to get her back. I was particularly inspired by the paranoid, crazy behavior of Othello, which I knew wasn't what you were supposed to get out of the play, but there was a reason Shakespeare lasted so many years and that was because he appealed to man's most base instincts.

Jealousy being one of them.

When the curtain came down I rose from my seat. The cast came out for a second round of applause, and Lisa saw me standing there.

Her face was plasticized into a stage smile, and she didn't break it for a moment. She bowed, smiled, and went backstage.

Before I had a chance for my mind to catch up with the ideas it was producing, I was off. I strolled down the center aisle, walked past the front row seats, hopped onto the stage at the end, and pushed my way through the heavy curtain to backstage.

Lisa was standing there, her hands together over her dress, looking in my direction as if she had expected me all along. It was fitting that she was wearing a wig, looking so unlike herself.

She smiled at me, but it was a strange smile.

I crossed the floor to her, and I was still wondering what wondrous thing would come out of my mouth next. At this point, my insides were in such turmoil it could have been anything.

But Lisa put her hand out to my shoulder, almost like she knew everything that I was thinking and why I was here. It was a reassuring touch.

"He's not here," I blabbered.

This shouldn't have made much sense to Lisa, but somehow it did. My breathing was fast, I was close to going over the edge. I had come here to confront Wallace, dammit.

Lisa shook her head, and met my eyes. “I asked him not to come,” she said.

I stepped back, my mouth open in surprise.

“I can’t believe *you’re* here,” she said. She smiled. “What did you think?”

My head was spinning. I opened my mouth to ask more about Wallace. Wallace was what I was here for, Wallace was who I wanted to know about.

But before I got the words out of my mouth, I had an epiphany of sorts.

Lisa’s eyes were lit up, she was looking at me with a genuine smile. She was thrilled that I was here.

And that’s when I realized: I needed to care more about *Lisa*. More about what was right in front of me, because she cared about it. She was happy that I was here to see her play, and whatever had happened with Wallace could wait.

“You... are amazing,” I said, taking her hands. “I can’t believe how good this whole thing was.”

Lisa looked down at her feet and she blushed. When she looked back at me I could see she was thrilled.

Someone called her name from behind. She turned quickly, and then stood on her tiptoes to give me a kiss on the cheek. “I have to go run through all the notes and change. It’ll be about an hour.” Then she stepped close to me, and put her hand on my neck, stroking the back of it sensually. She whispered in my ear: “How’d you like the *other* play?”

“Yes,” I said, dumbfounded.

Lisa grinned. “I’ll tell you all about it, in detail,” she said. “Later.”

“I can wait for you,” I said.

“It’s like an hour, at least.”

It was no problem.

“It’s no problem,” I said.

Lisa smiled.

And I knew that she loved me. And I had made her happy.

CHAPTER 26

Lisa

I spent the whole night with Wallace, acting out my wild fantasies with him.

It was earth-shattering sex, and it left me dizzy, exhausted, and thoroughly satisfied.

Physically.

And I guess, curiosity-wise.

But at about three o'clock, when we were both too tired to move, and I was lying there staring at the ceiling thinking about how I had a dress rehearsal the next day, I realized that I had gotten everything I wanted from him.

I had sat up in bed, the sweat- and cum-soaked sheets pulled up to my chest.

I looked over at Wallace, who had his head resting in his hands. He didn't seem surprised by my abrupt sitting-up. He looked at me. "Gotta go?" he said, almost cheerfully.

I leaned my cheek on my knees. "How'd you know?"

Wallace gave me a smile, and in a way it was a little bit sad. He knew, the smile said.

I got dressed and he called me a cab, because he knew, as well as I did, that I was in no position to drive. "I have a dress rehearsal tomorrow," I said, as a way of explaining why I suddenly needed to leave.

Wallace kissed me, and I have to say, he seemed to know it was the last time. "Give me a call," he said, as I left, but it didn't seem like he genuinely meant it.

All I knew was that I needed to go home. After all of that, it suddenly seemed wrong to be lying there with him. I didn't want to put my head on his chest or talk to him like I did with Luke. I just wanted to get home, back to what was familiar. I couldn't even imagine feeling the way I had felt just before I had gotten there.

I didn't want to talk to Luke that night either. Not just yet. I was feeling conflicted. Guilty, strange, irresponsible (how was I going to get through the next day?). I had satisfied my sexual urges and now I felt spent,

and part of me wished I could just put everything back the way it had been before I had run into Wallace.

And what if Luke had liked it as much as he hoped to? What if he wanted me to keep going, to carry on this affair until Wallace left town?

What if I woke up the next day and found that I wanted to do that, too? Or didn't, and Luke did? Or vice versa?

When I got home I showered, barely able to stand up. I felt so tired I thought I might fall asleep standing up.

When I woke up the next morning at nine, I grabbed my phone from my purse first thing.

There was no message from Luke. I toyed with the idea of sending him something, and then I realized that what I really wanted to do was to text Wallace.

And tell him it was over.

*

When I saw Luke out there in the audience, my heart almost leaped out of my chest. I had a hard time keeping it together.

I don't think I could have said, with any real truth behind it, that I'd "fallen" in love in my whole life, up until that moment. What happened with Luke up until then was more like the careful cultivation of love, under some crazy circumstances.

Until that moment.

Luke, standing there backstage.

That was what I really wanted, all along. And maybe it's crazy, but I think we had to do what we did with Wallace. Because Luke was looking at me differently at that moment. Like he really, actually *saw* me.

That's when I fell in love with him.

So what if it wasn't in the first act?

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Click on the links to see the blurbs for more stories that are like *Claudia* because they are [interracial](#), [romantic](#), or [fun summer swinger stories](#). Or maybe you want to change tack and explore [darker themes](#) or [suspense?](#)

APOLOGY!

Due to a glitch in the Amazon system, I've had to remove direct hyperlinks from my backmatter. I apologize for any inconvenience this causes my readers. Any of these titles can be located on [My Author Page](#)

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn - one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make

things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless.

Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties.

One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let

Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is

open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

*Explore **darker** themes by Arnica Butler:*

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of

their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “reliability” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.

*Hotwife **Suspense** By Arnica Butler*

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...